ESSENTIAL JAZZ VOCABULARY WORKBOOK

TIMELESS PHRASES AND APPLICATION

- 180 LINES OF MATERIAL
- APPLICATION ON VARIOUS JAZZ CHORD PROGRESSIONS
- GUIDED INSTRUCTIONAL TEXT
- VARIATIONS OF EACH PHRASE
- INTEGRATION EXERCISES
- SOURCE PHRASES IN 12 KEYS

JAZZ LESSON VIDEOS

NATHAN GRAYBEAL

Essential Jazz Vocabulary Handbook

Nathan Graybeal

Copywork by Jack Lanhardt

Phrase Recordings: https://tinyurl.com/EJVWRecordings

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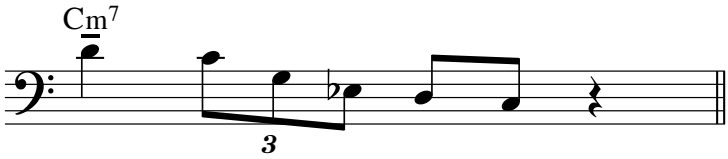
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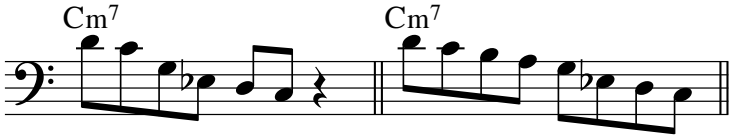
Lick 1

Cry Me a River (CMAR)

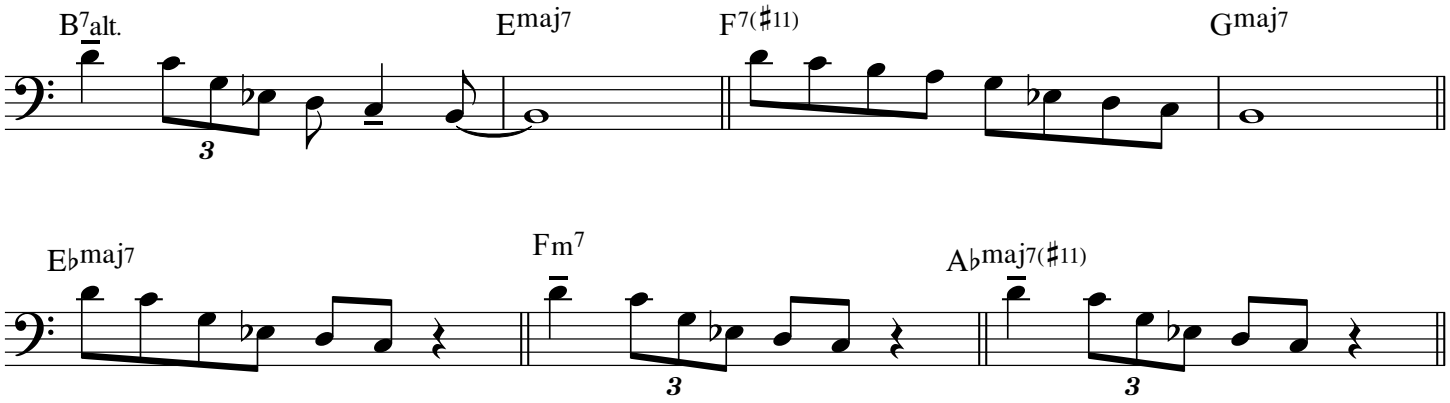
This is the "Cry Me a River" (CMAR) lick:
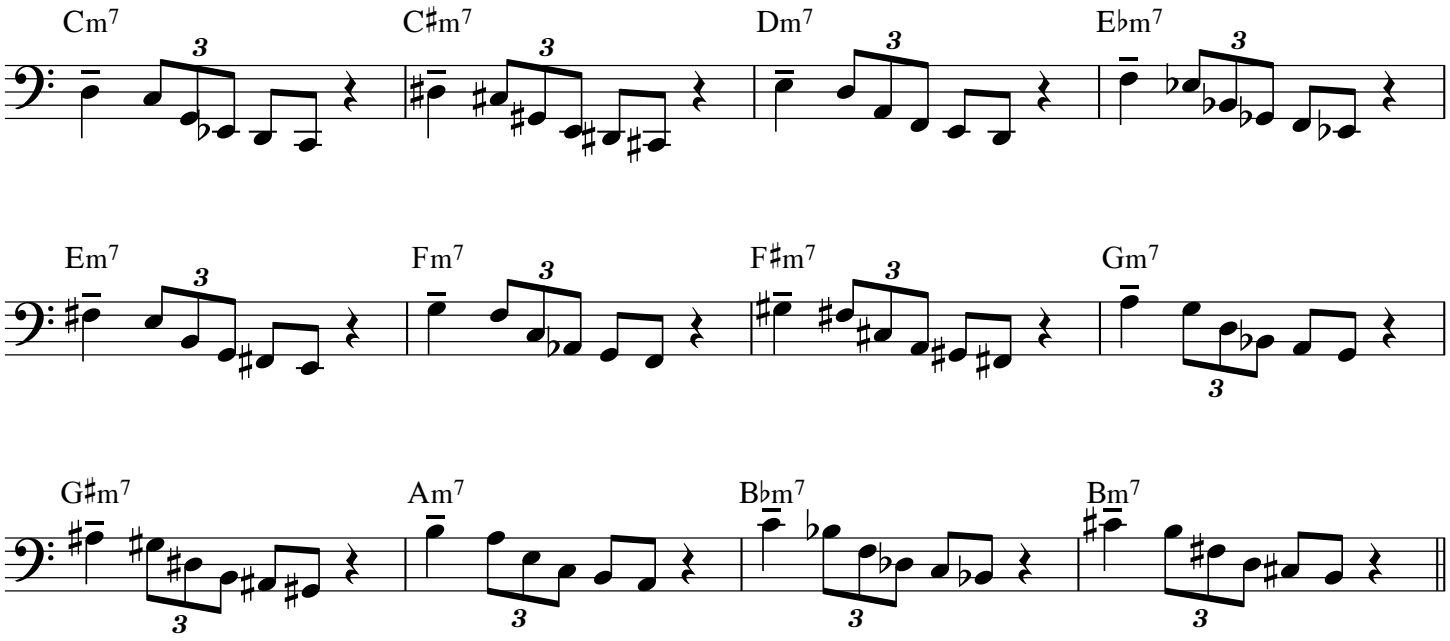


Here's a couple of common variations of the CMAR lick:



The CMAR lick fits in many other chords as well:
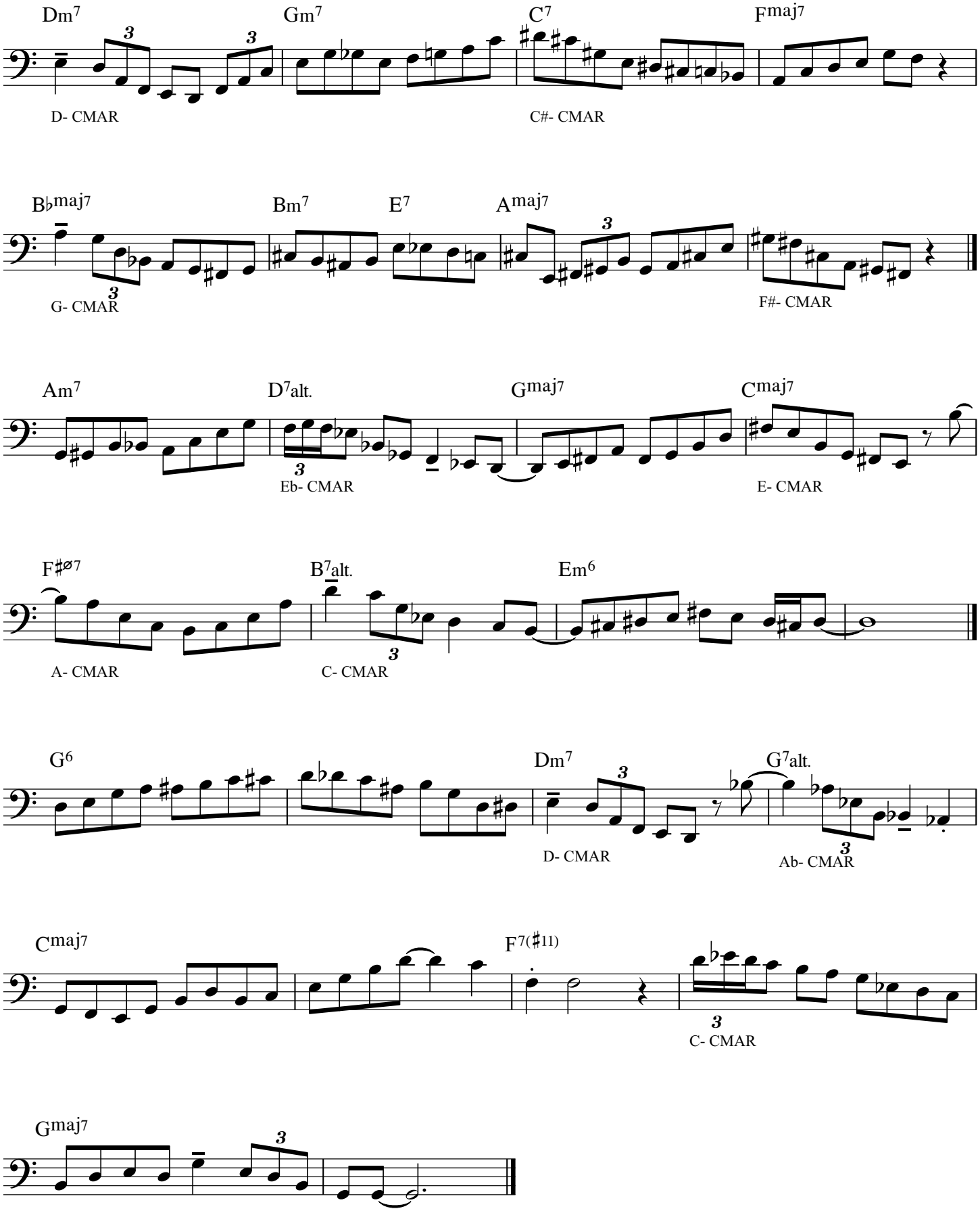


It will be easier to apply the CMAR lick to various chords if you first memorize it in all 12 keys:



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2 Here are several phrases of the CMAR lick played within common jazz chord progressions:
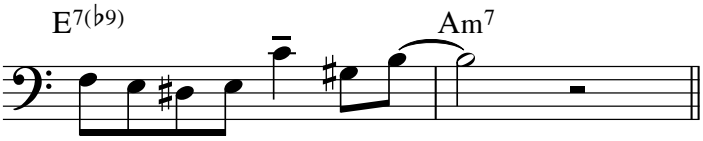


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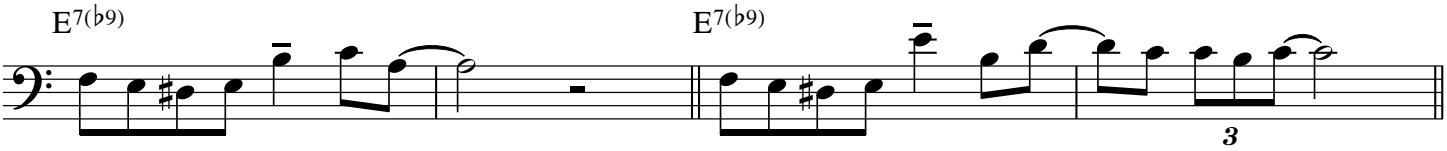
Lick 2

Embellished Minor Resolution (EMR)
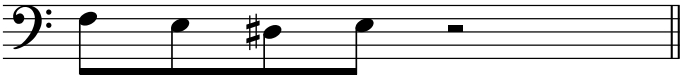
This is a classic lick that is heard in many important jazz recordings. It does not have an official name, so let's label it as the "Embellished Minor Resolution" (EMR):
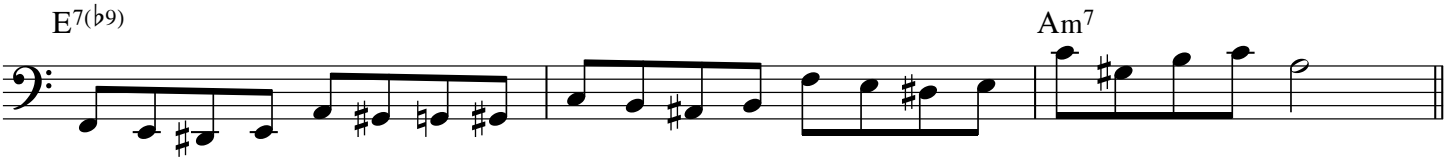


Here's a couple common variations of the EMR lick:
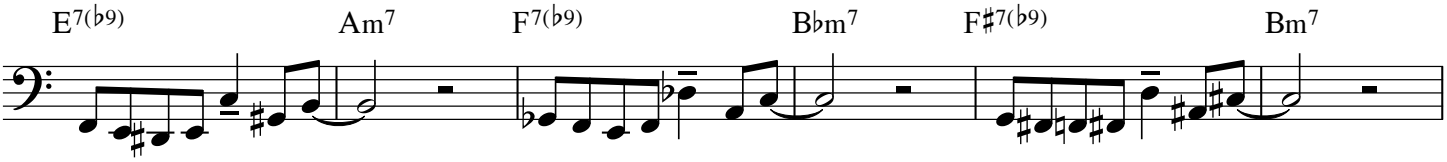


The first half of the EMR lick is really a chromatic embellishment around E.
See how F and D# encircle around the note, and E is played twice?
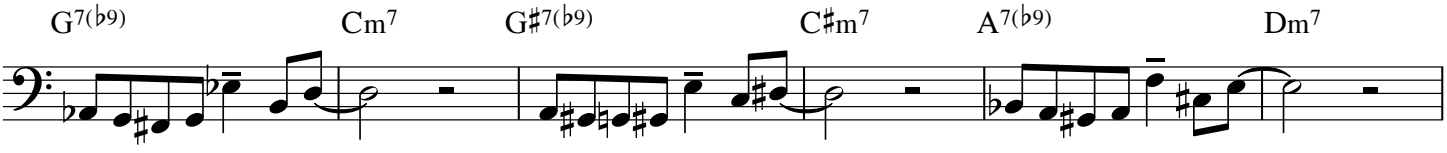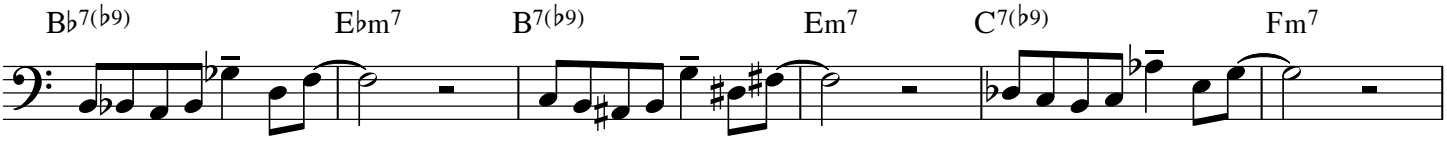


Well, you could do this from each note of the E7b9's triad (E major triad). It sounds pretty cool!
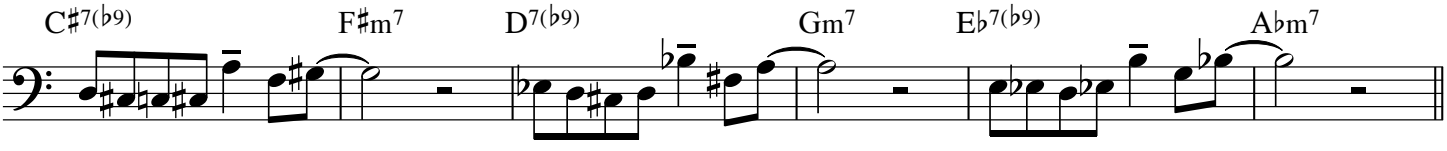


The EMR lick is definitely worth memorizing in 12 keys.
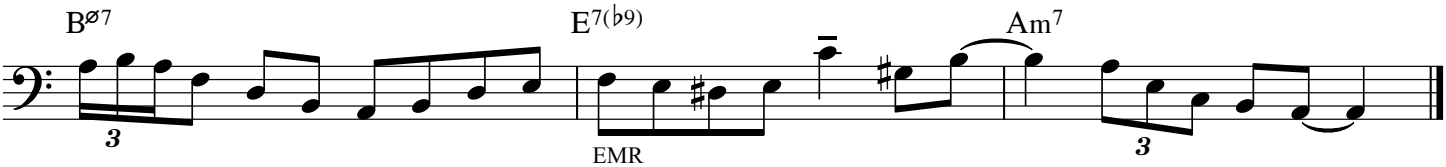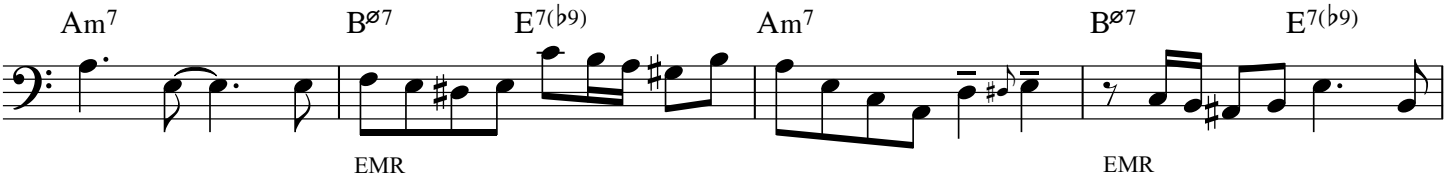






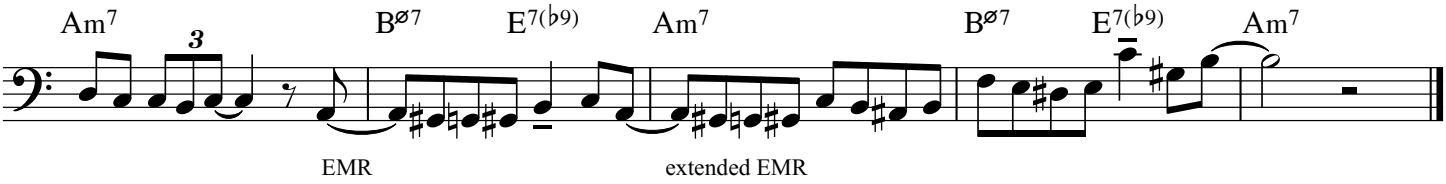


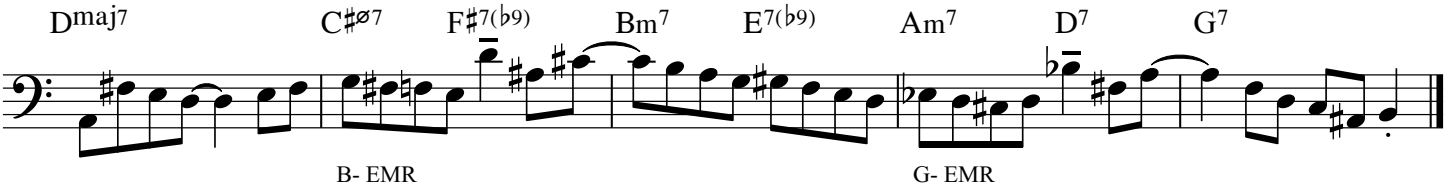
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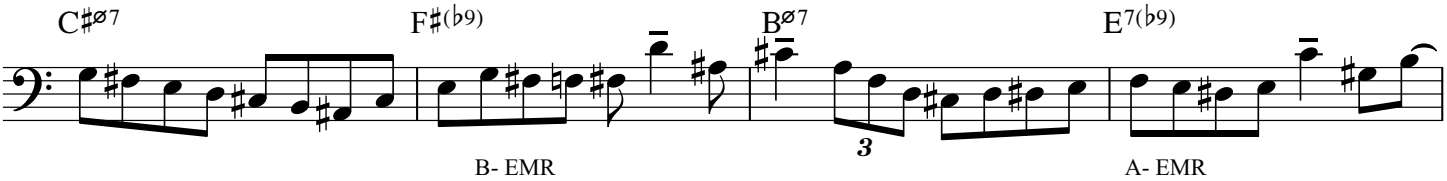
4 Here are several phrases of the EMR being played within common jazz chord progressions:
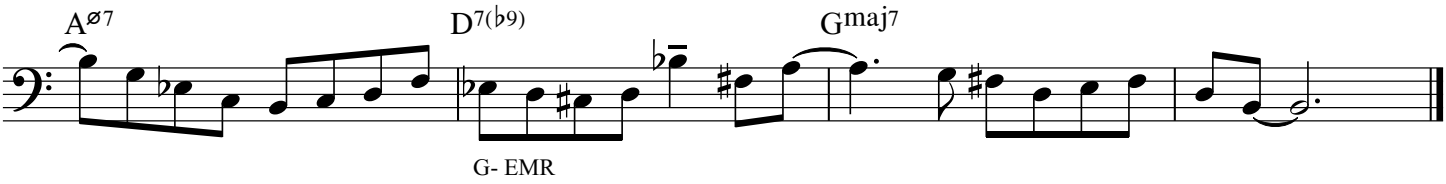










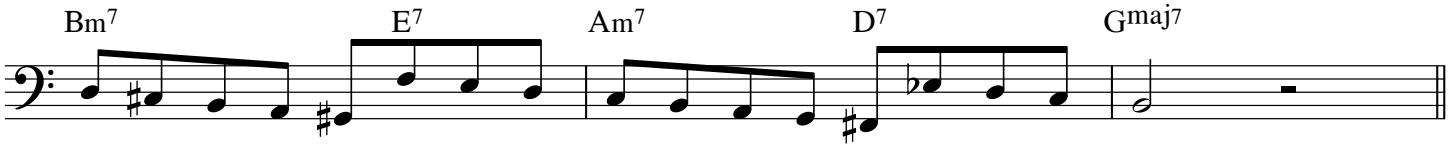


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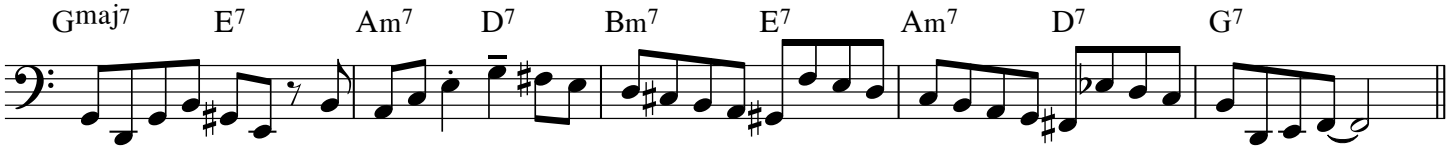
Lick 3

Guide Tone Sequence (GTS)

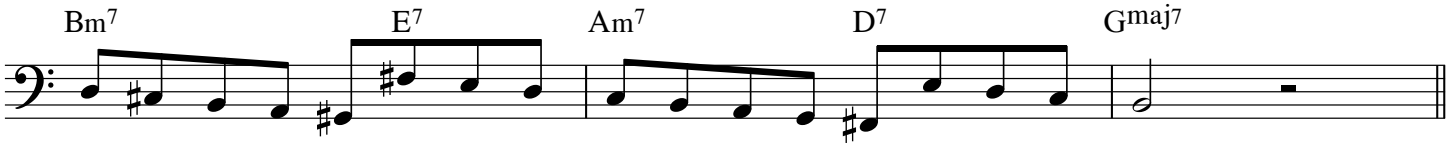
Here's an important sequence that you'll hear variations of within hundreds of jazz recordings.
Let's call this one the "Guide Tone Sequence" (GTS):
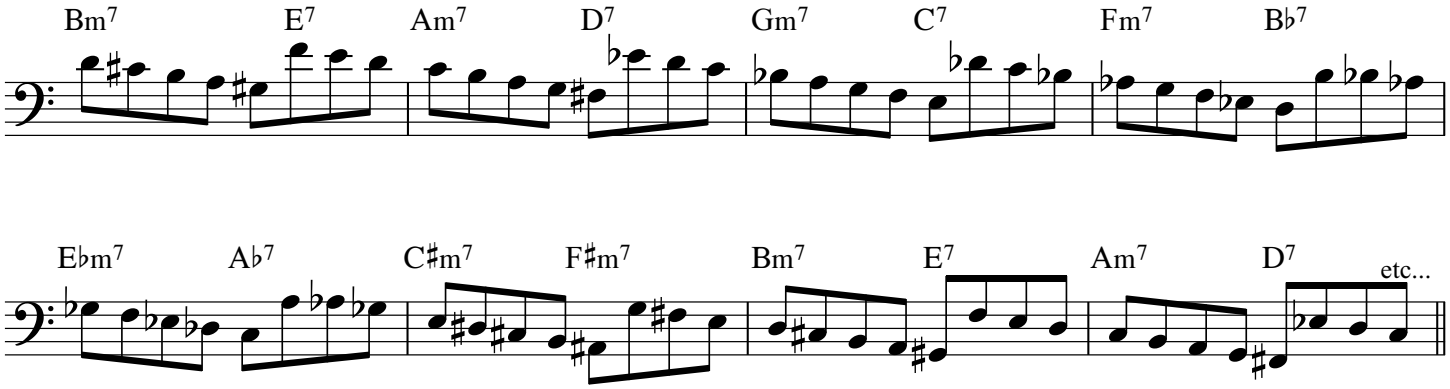


It's really effective within the A section of a rhythm changes (tunes like I Got Rhythm, Oleo, and Anthropology):
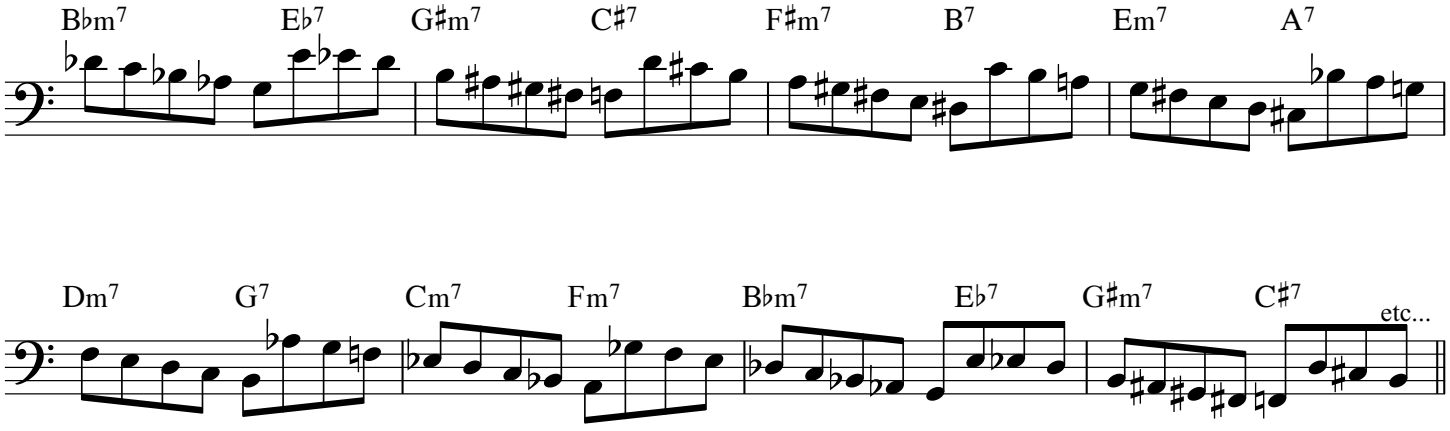


Major 9ths for the dominant chords (instead of flat 9ths) also sound nice:



A great way to solidfy this into your ear is to turn the last chord into a minor 7 chord, and keep it going forever:

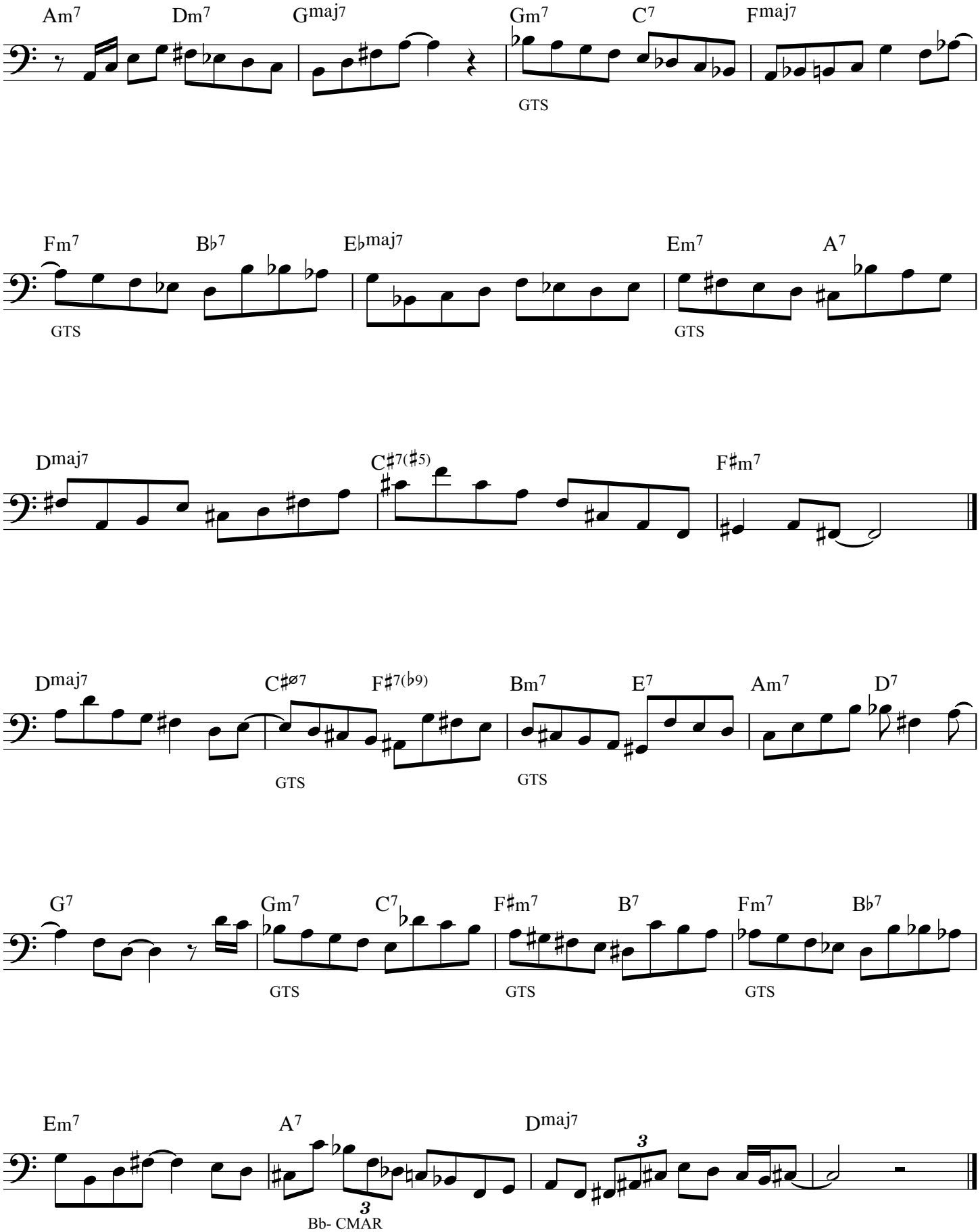


After six keys, you'll reach the end of the loop. So, don't forget to practice the other six remaining keys:



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 Here are several phrases of the GTS being played within common jazz chord progressions:
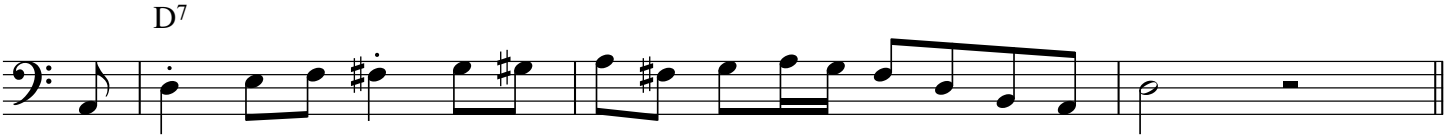


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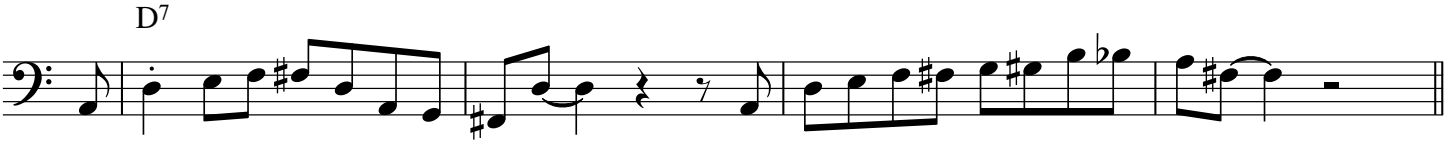
Lick 4

Bird Opening (BO)

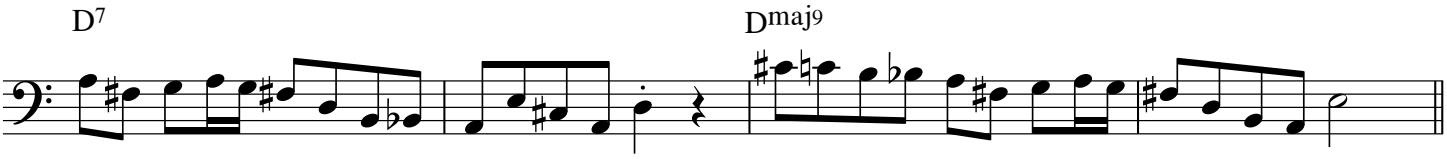
Here's a signature of the great Charlie Parker's vocabulary. His nickname was Bird, and he often used this line to begin phrases, so let's label this the "Bird Opening" (BO):
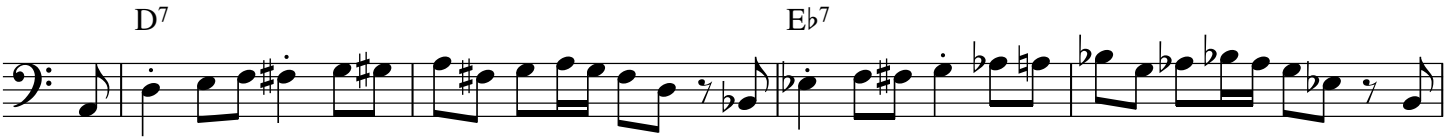


If you split this phrase in half, both halves are very versatile. Here's the first half being utulized in other ways:
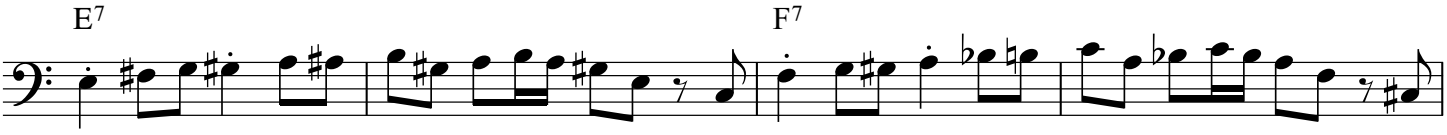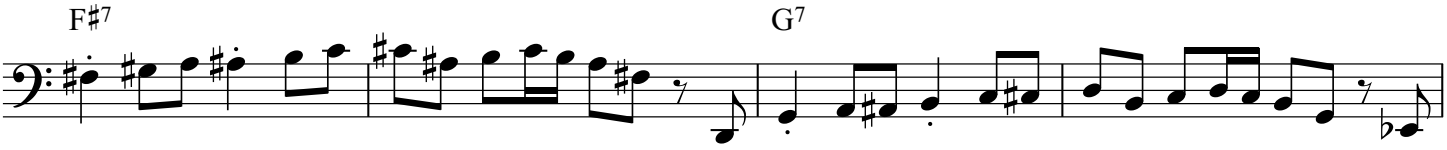


Here's the second half being utulized in other ways:
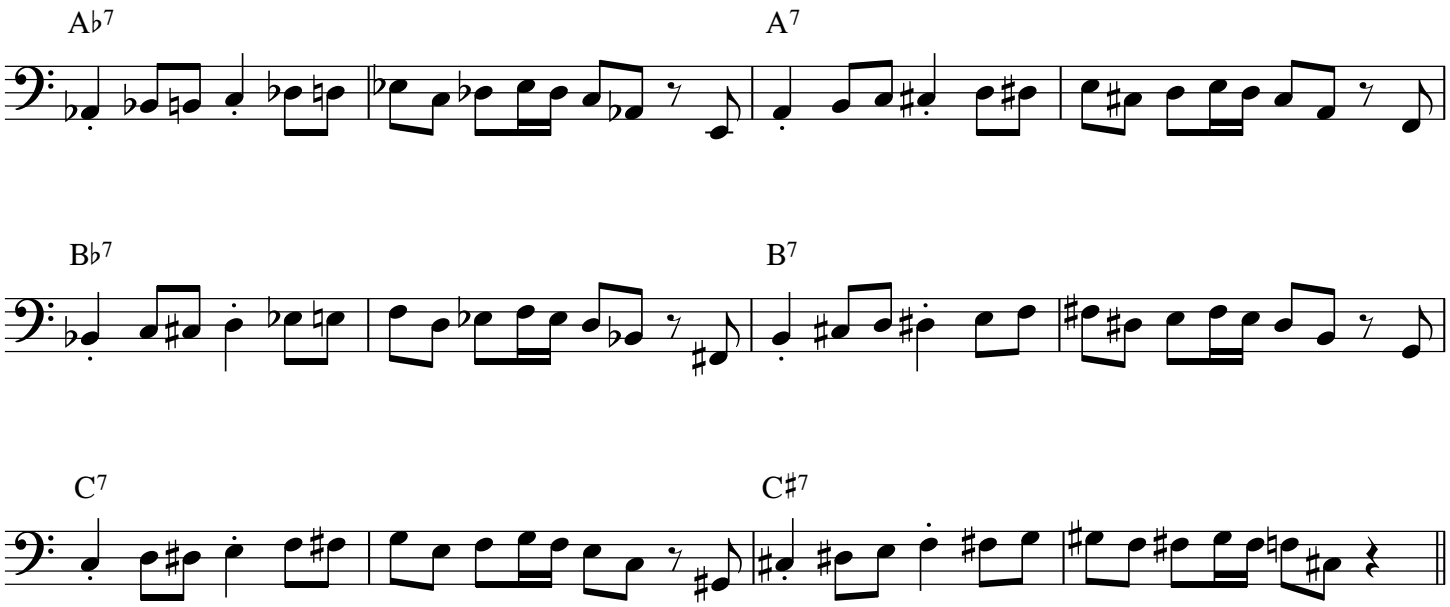


Like any bit of jazz language, you'll want to have it internalized in 12 keys:
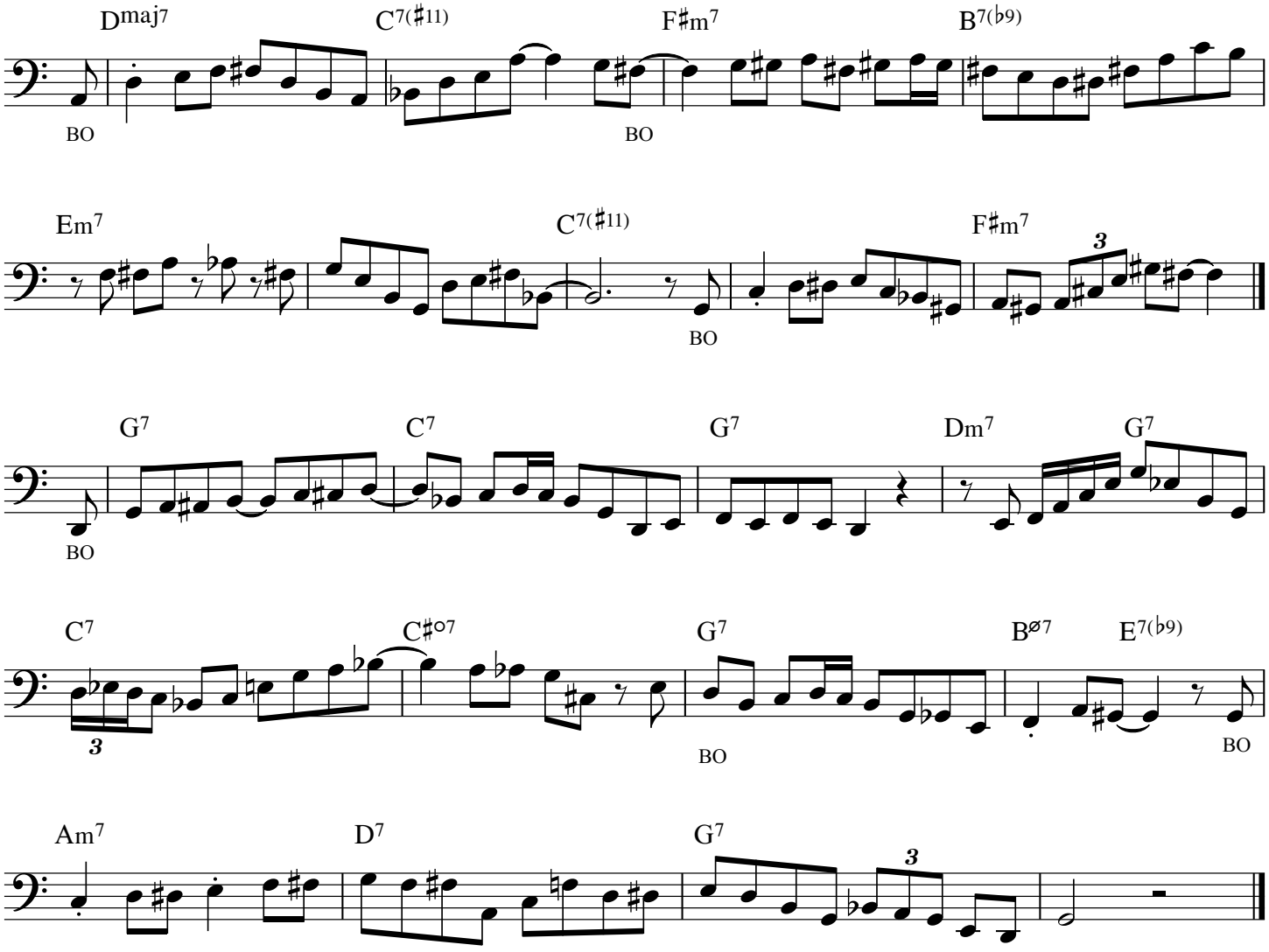






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Here are several phrases of the BO being played within common jazz chord progressions:

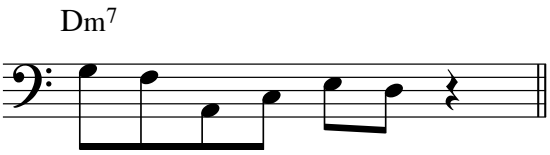


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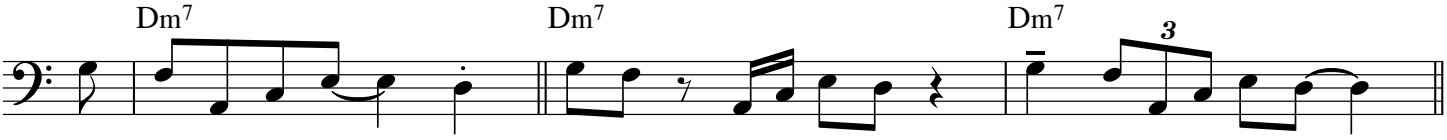
Lick 5

Honeysuckle Rose Lick (HSR)

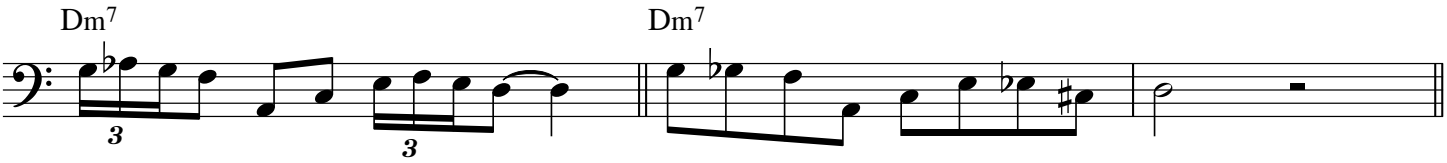
This is the "Honey Suckle Rose" (HSR) lick:



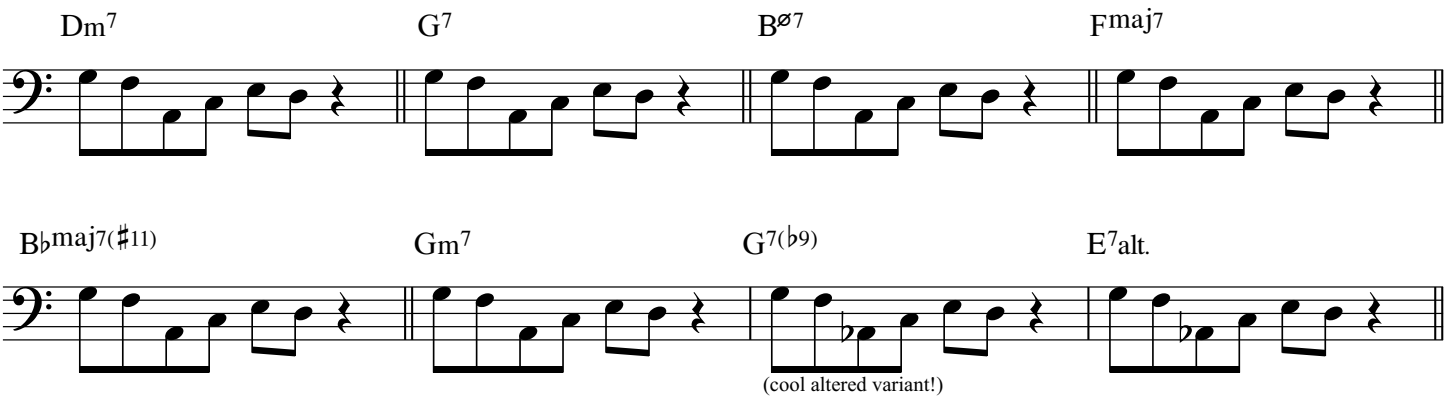
Here are some rhythmic variations of this line:
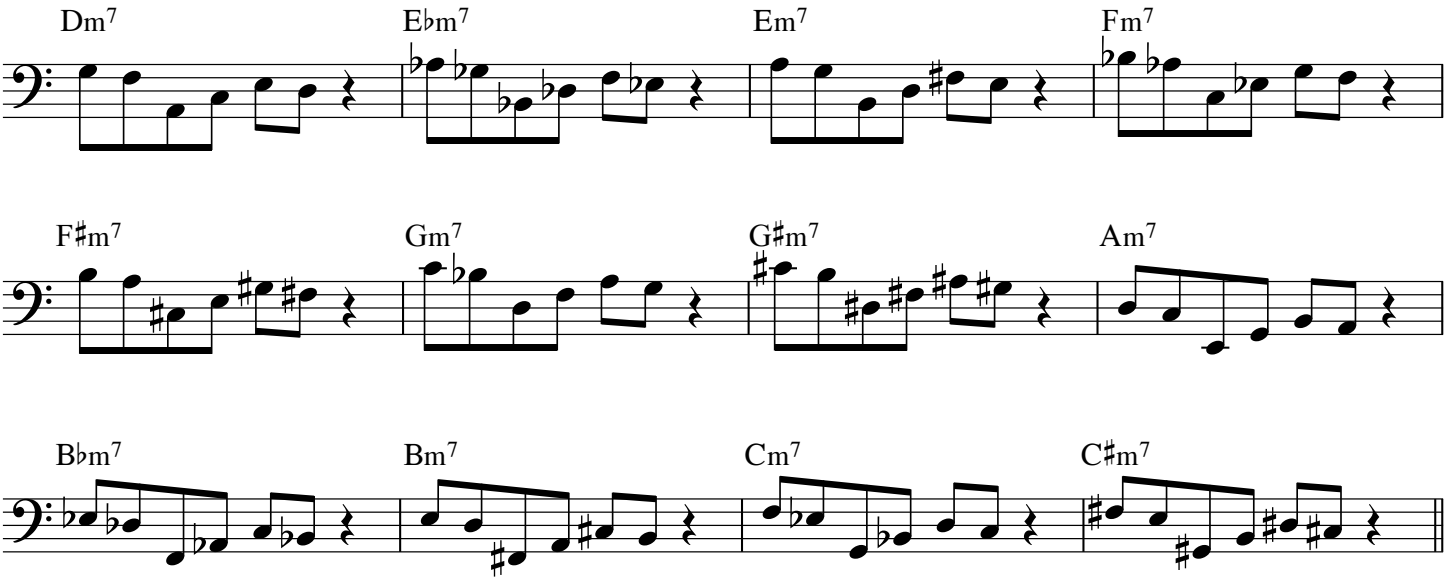


It also sounds great when its melodically embellished:



The HSR lick works over many chord qualities:
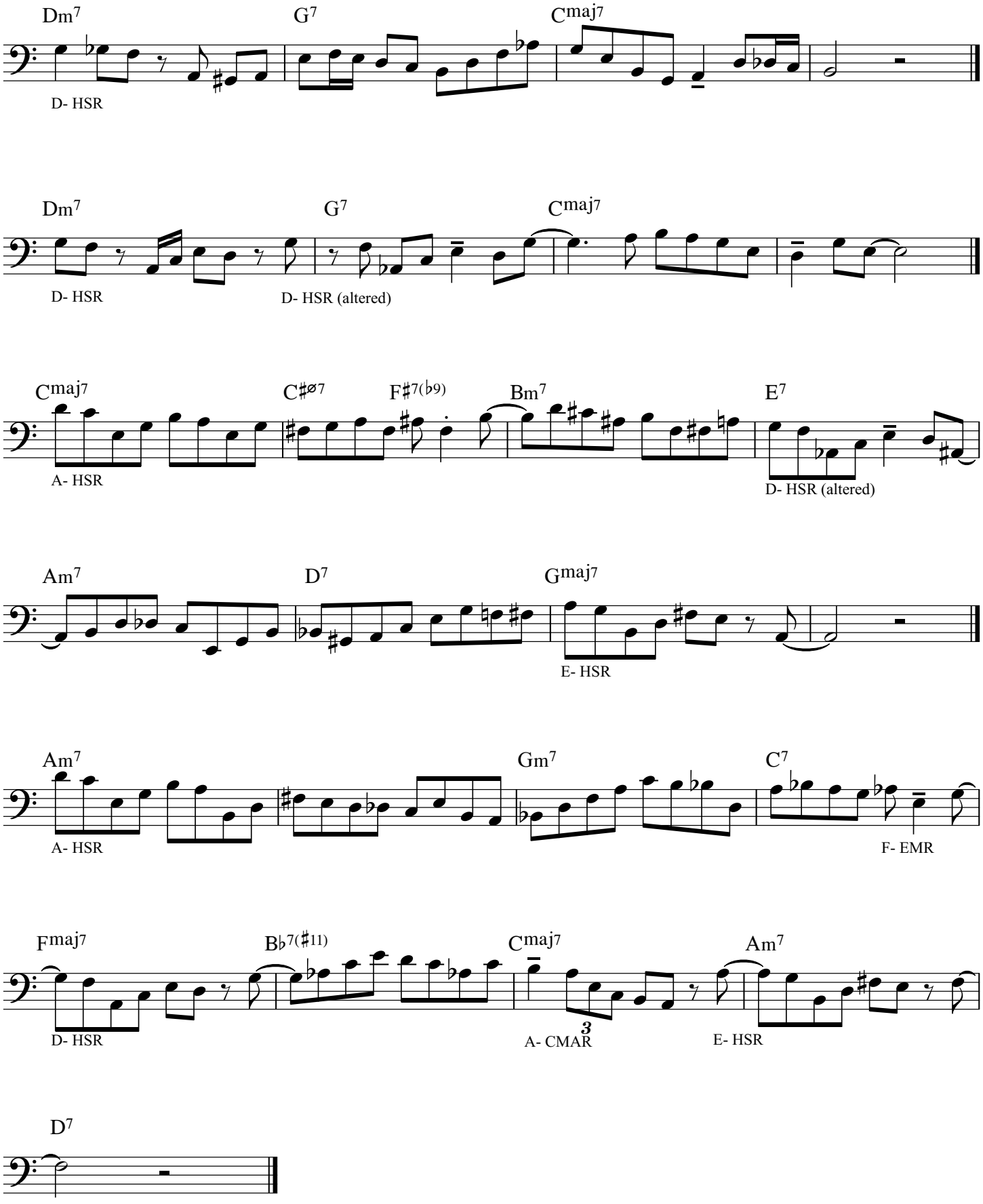


This one is definitely worth memorizing in 12 keys:



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10 Here are several phrases of the HSR lick being played within common jazz chord progressions:
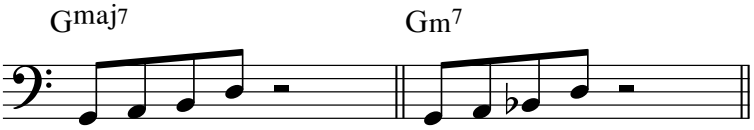


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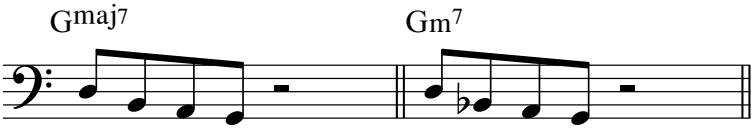
Lick 6

1235 Cell
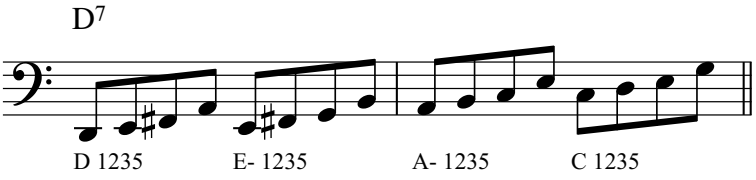
This is the 1235 cell. On the surface, it might look quite bland. But it's incredibly versatile, and heard in probably 90%+ of jazz solos. Let's unlock its power!
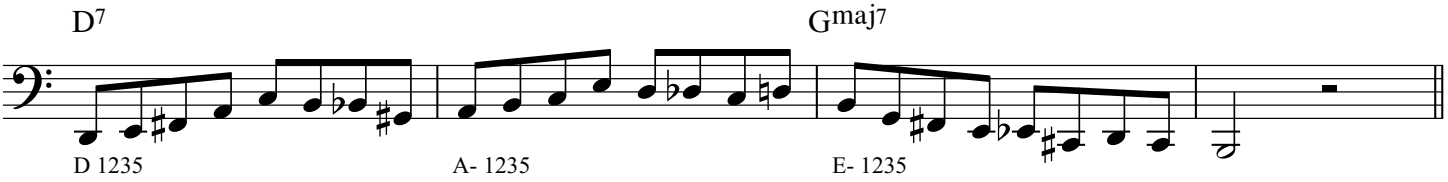


You'll often hear the 1235 being played backwards, as well.
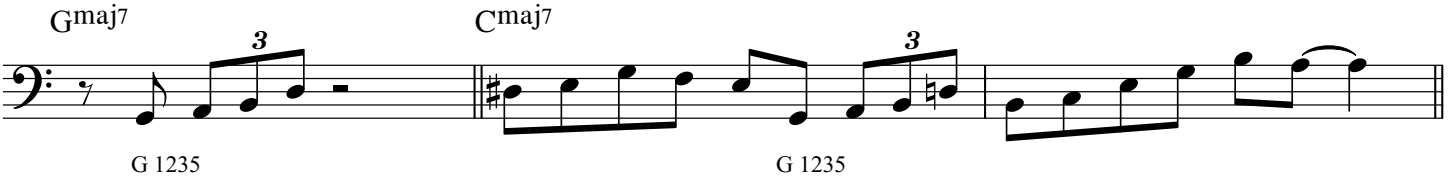


Look at all of the favorable places a 1235 cell is found diatonically within a D7 chord!



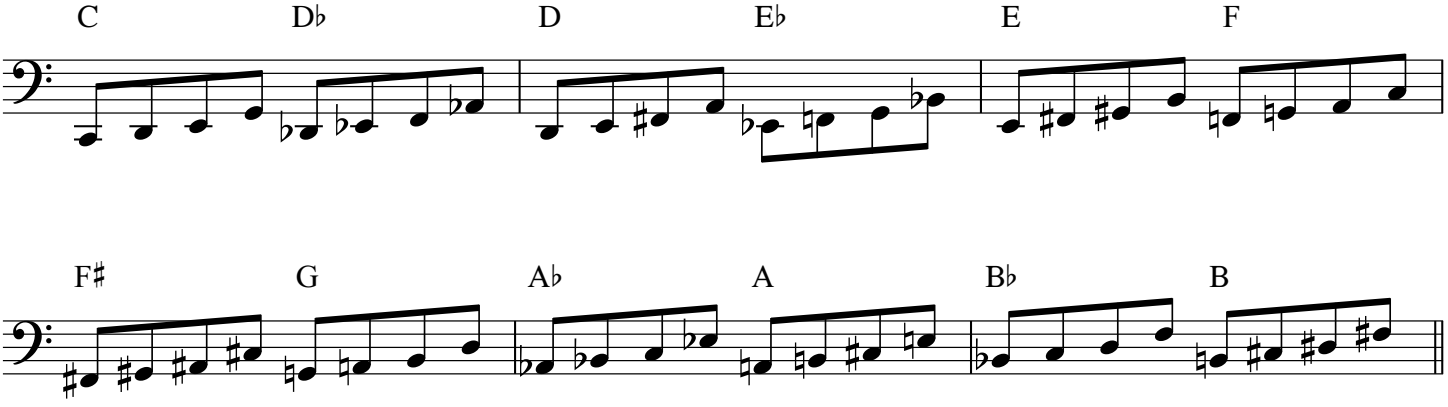
The 1235 cell is a reliable way to extend melodies:



This is a really popular rhythmic alteration of the 1235 cell.
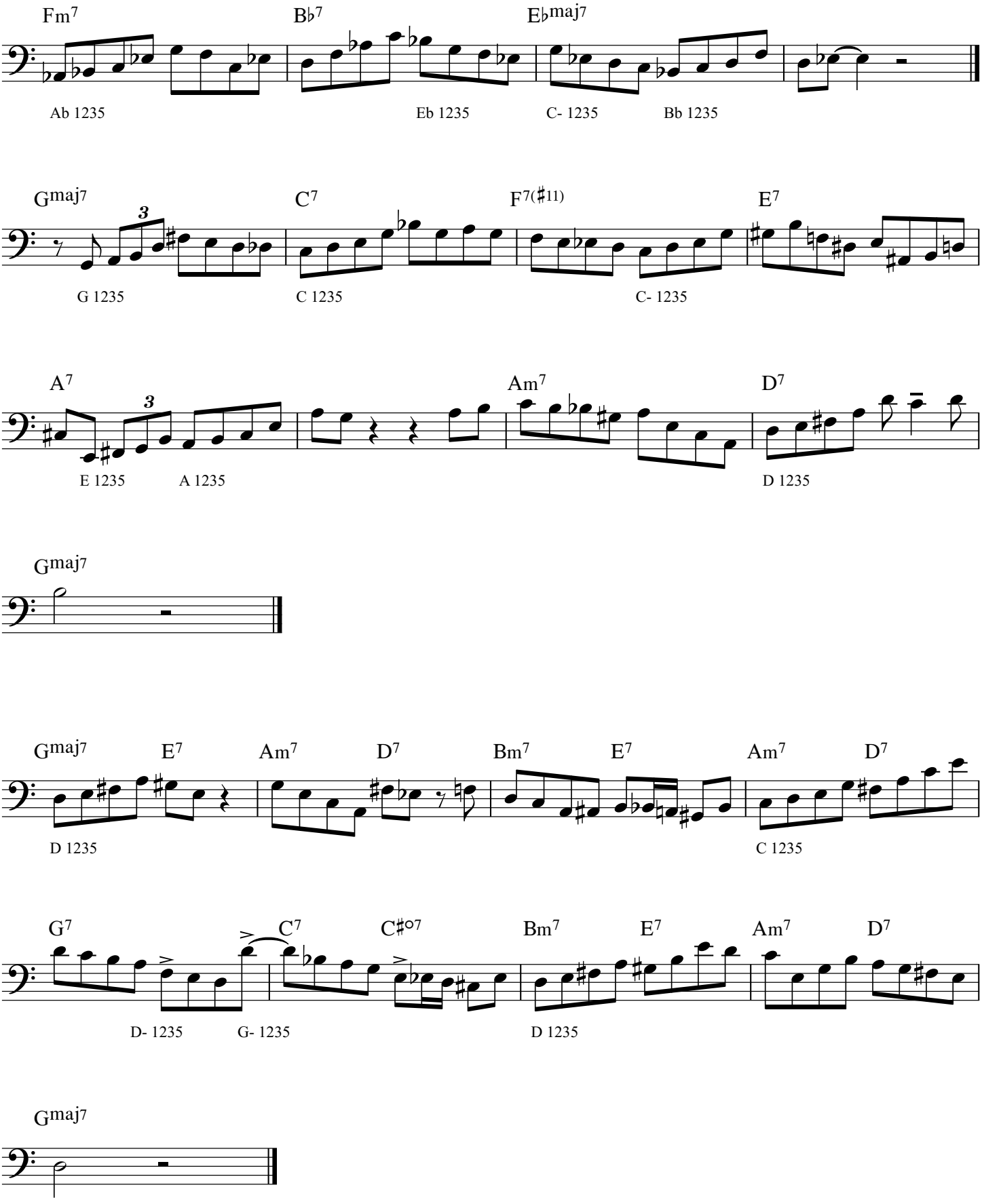


Memorize and internalize the major 1235 cell in 12 keys. Once it feels easy, move on to the minor version, and also practice both of them backwards.



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12 Here are several phrases of the 1235 cell being played within common jazz chord progressions:
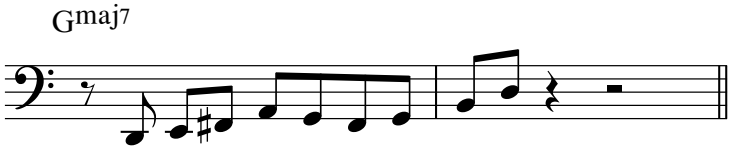


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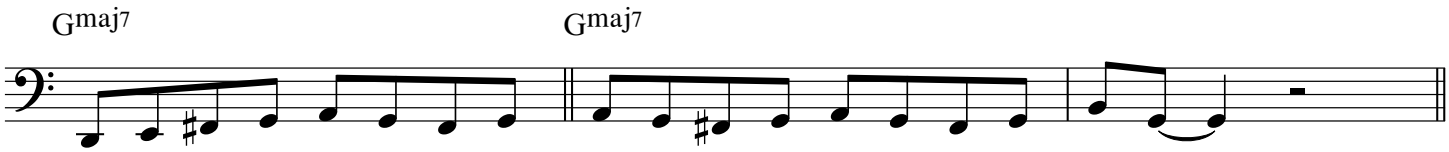
Lick 7

Bird Resolution
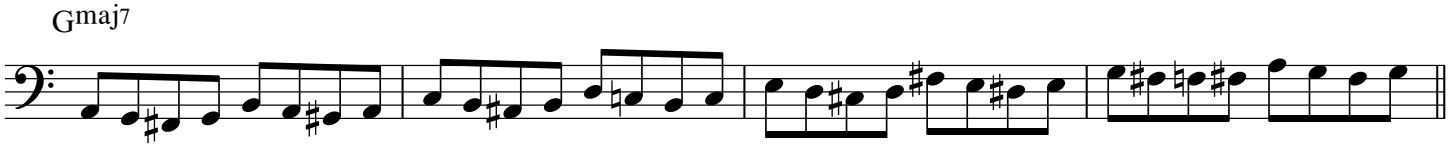
Here's a resolution that was very common in Charlie Parker's solos. Let's call this the "Bird Resolution" (BR):
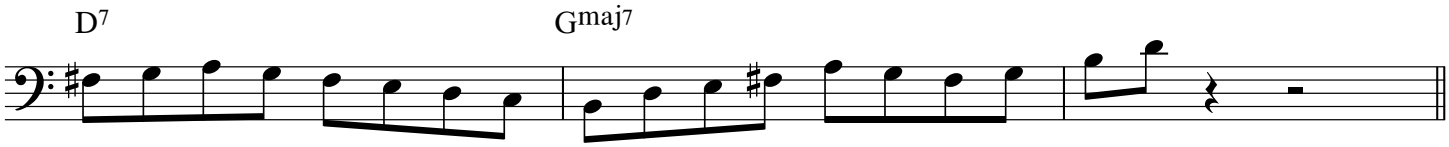


Here are some slight variations of the BR.
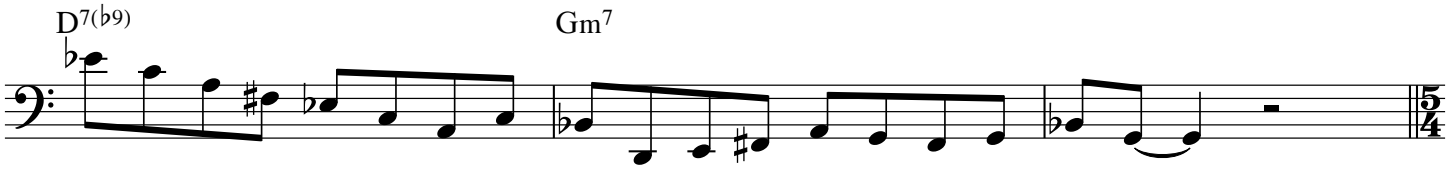


You can take the embellisment around the root and transfer it to every note inside of a scale!
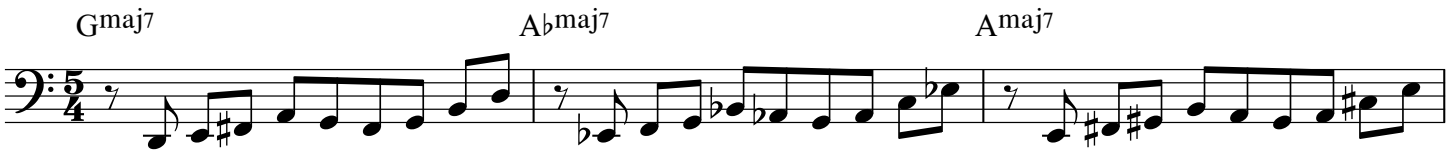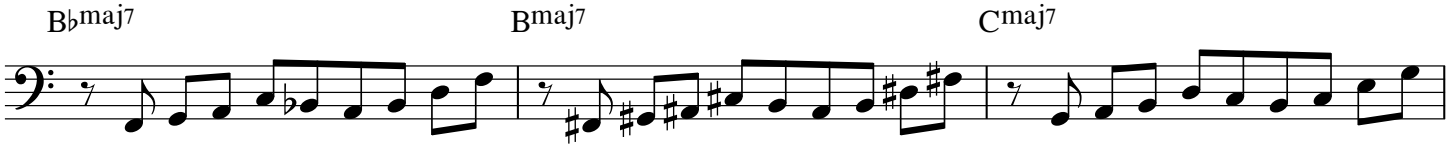


Most commonly, this line is accessed after resolving to a 3rd of a major chord.



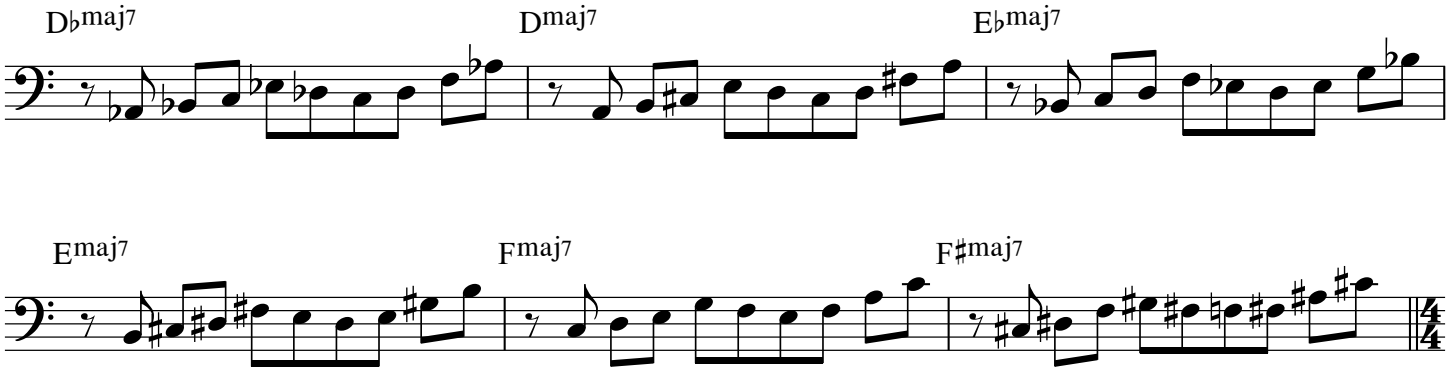
It's also nice after resolving to a 3rd of a minor chord for a melodic minor sound.
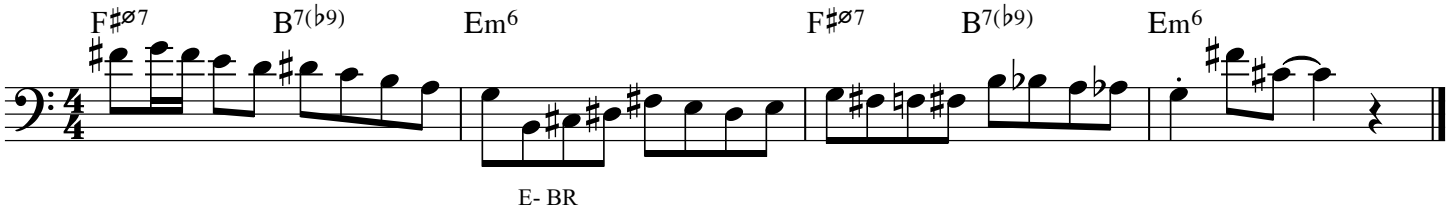




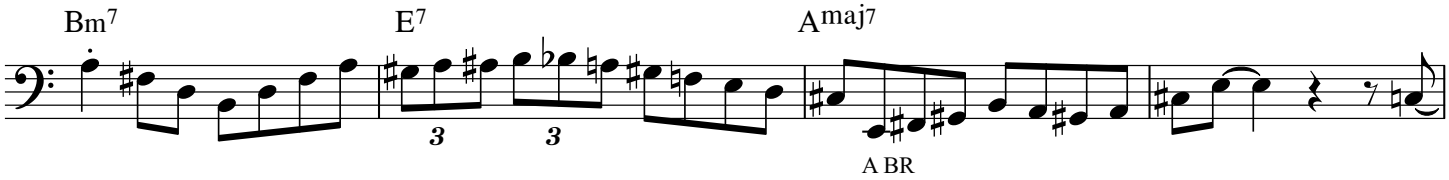


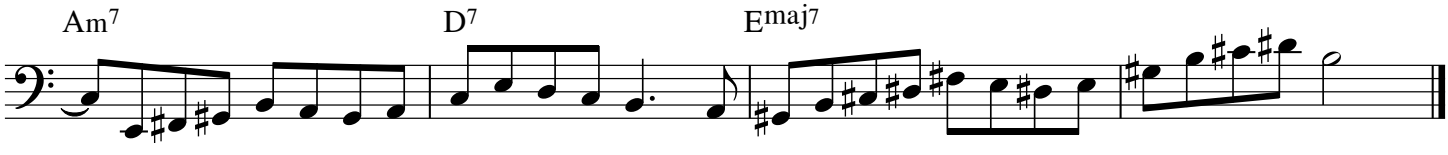
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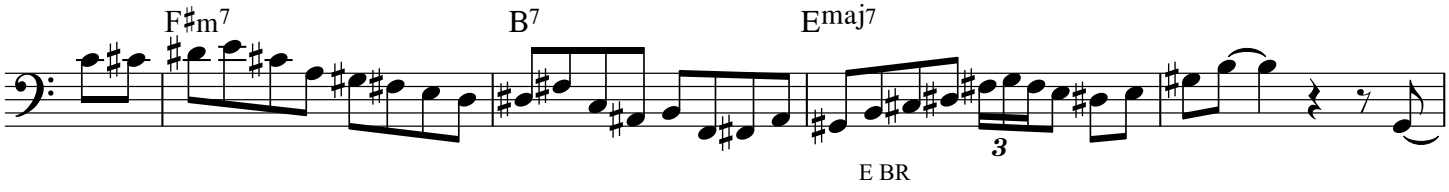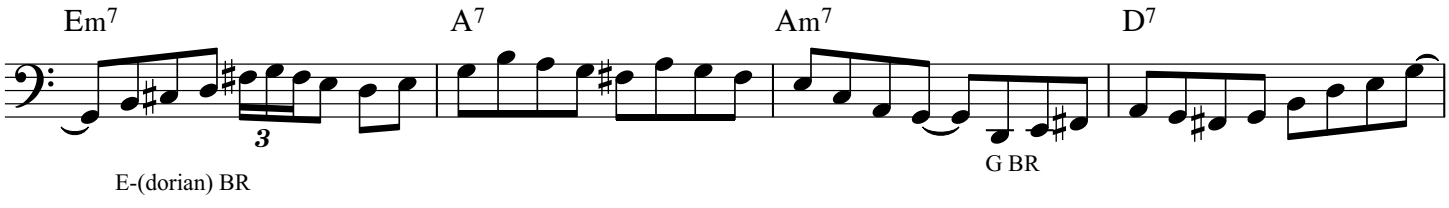


Here are several phrases of the BR being played within common jazz chord progressions:

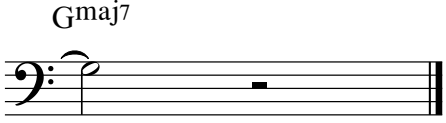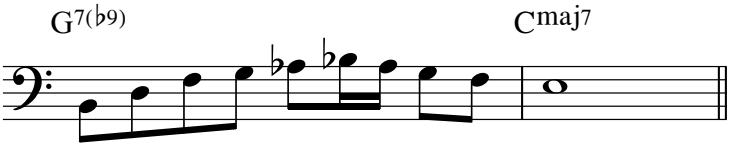












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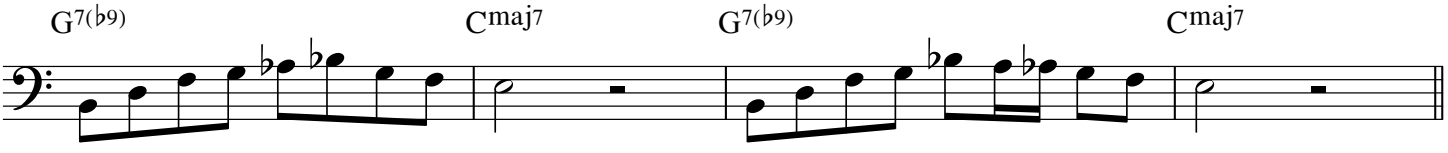
Lick 8

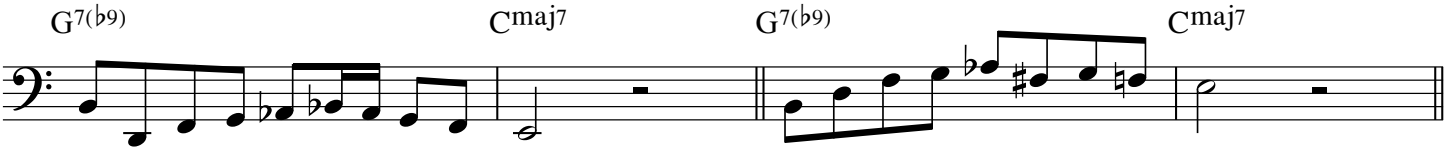
Donna Lee Resolution (DLR)

Here's a really common and effective resolution. It's heard in the melody of Donna Lee, so let's call this one the "Donna Lee Resolution" (DLR):

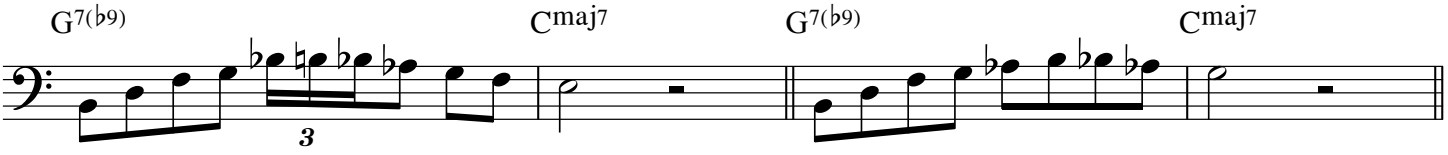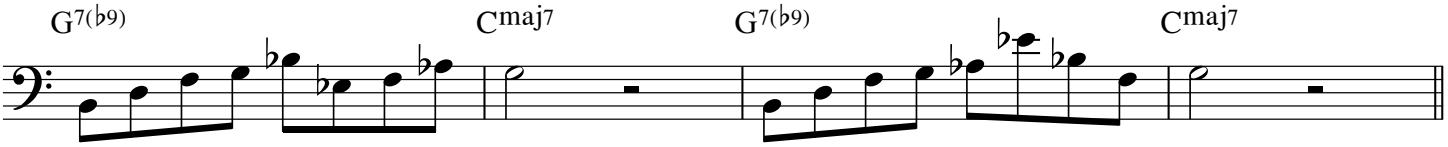


Here are some common variations of the DLR.
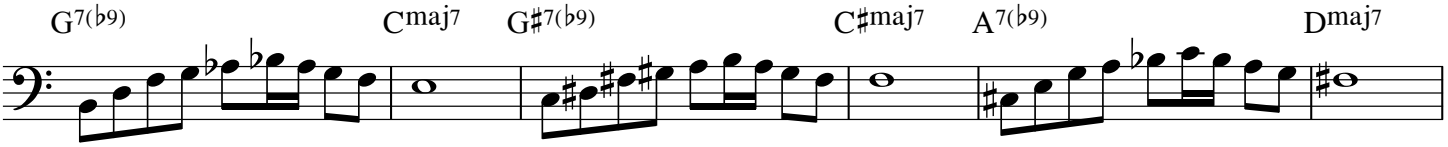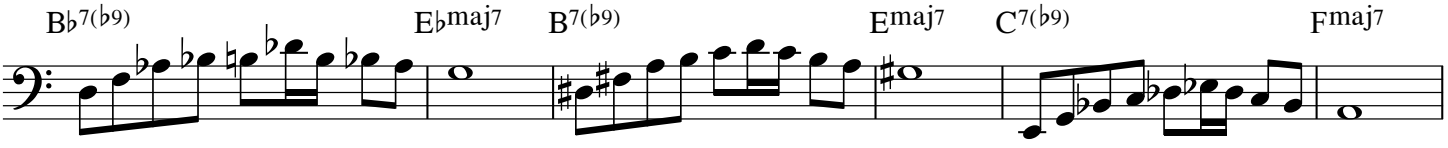




Really, after the first 4-note cell, it's fair game as to how you want to resolve.
Just put some altered notes somewhere and resolve to a chord tone on the destination chord!
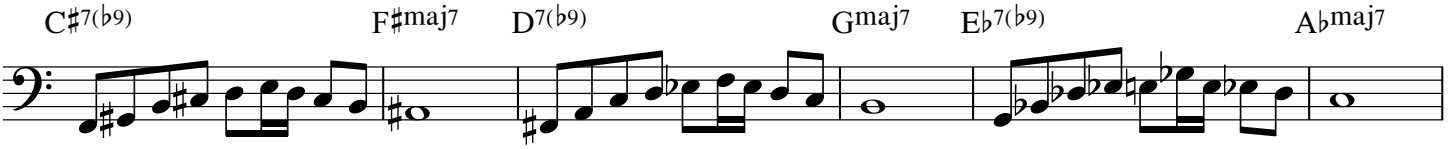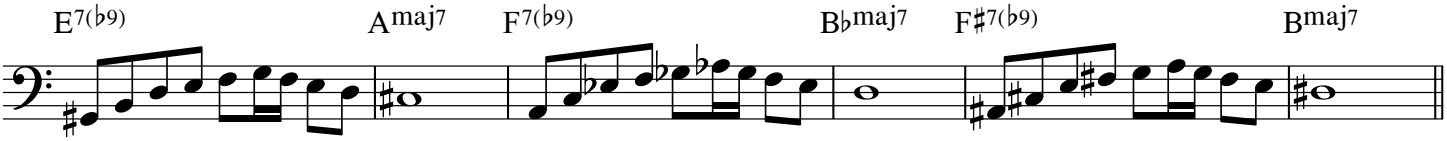




If you ingrain the original one into your ear in 12 keys, then modifying it on the spot during your improvisation will come naturally through time:



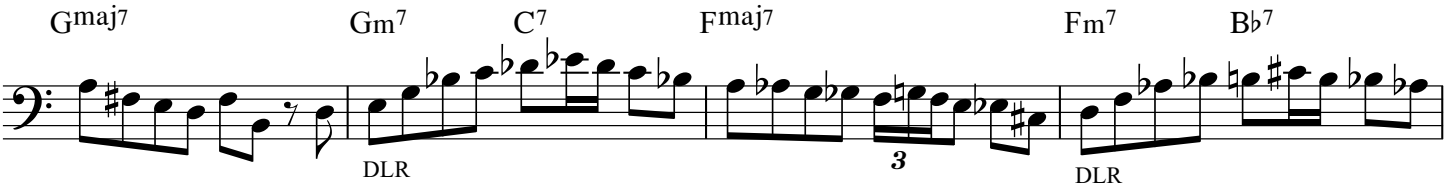


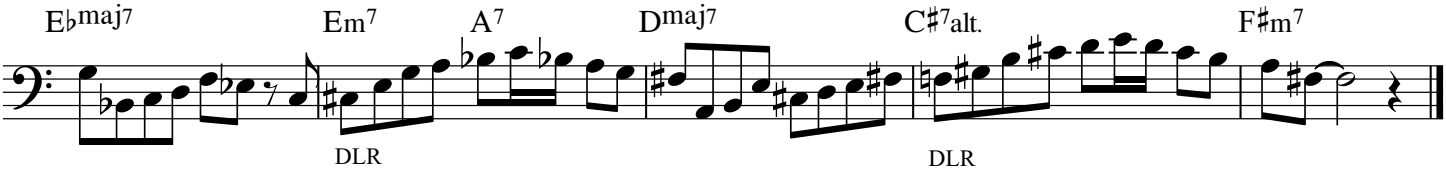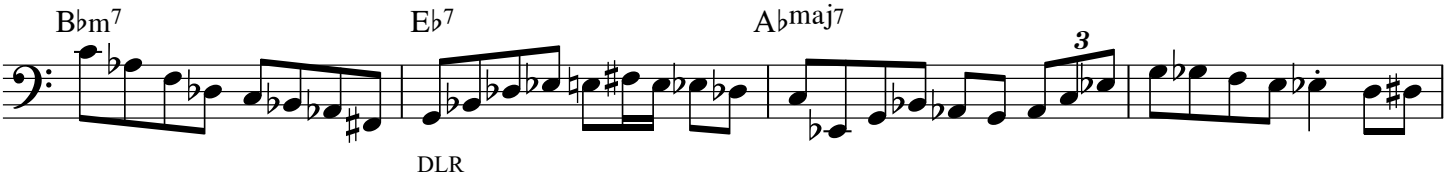


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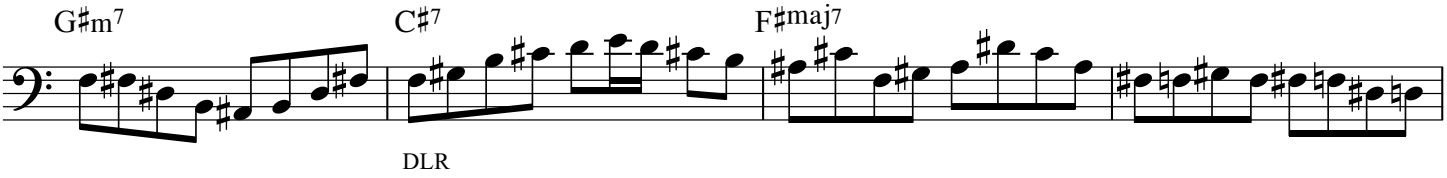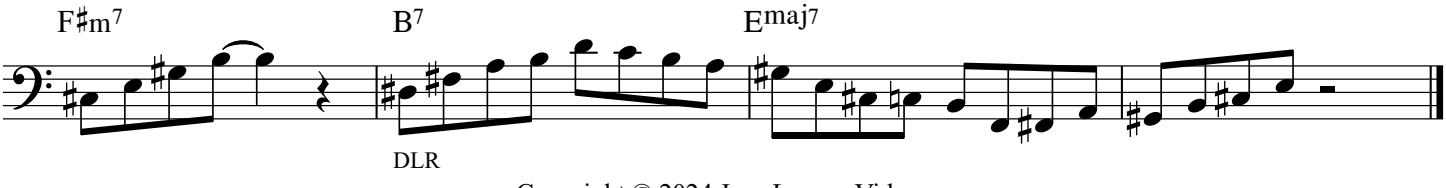


Here are several phrases of the DLR being played within common jazz chord progressions:









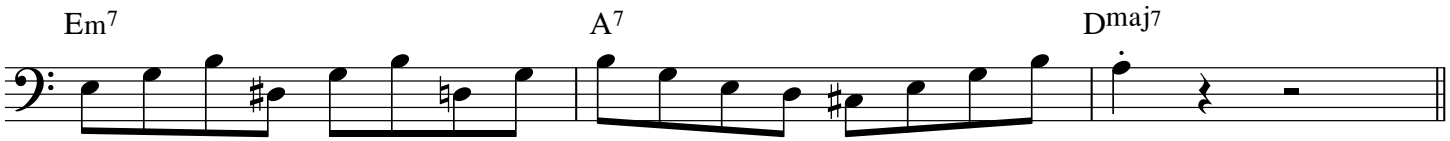


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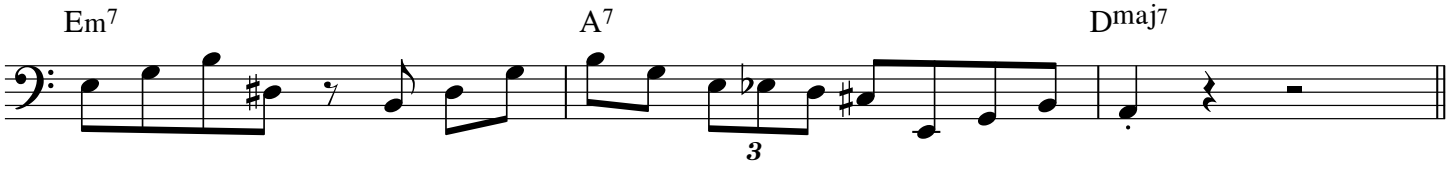
Lick 9
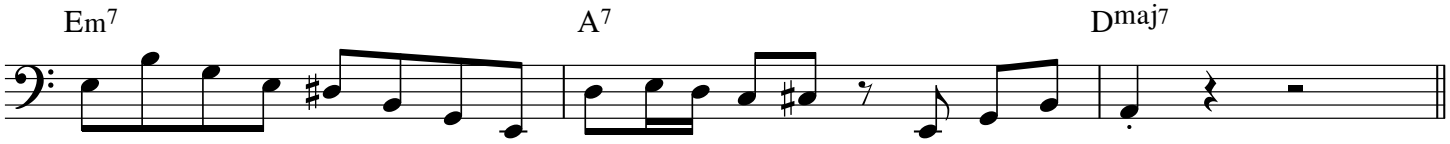
Arpeggiated Chromatic Voice-Leading (ACVL)

Here's a lick made popular by Sonny Stitt. It's a mix of arpeggios infused with chromatic voice-leading.
So, let's call it the "Arpeggiated Chromatic Voice-Leading" (ACVL) lick:
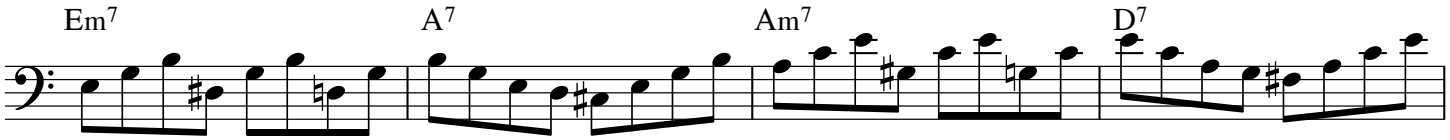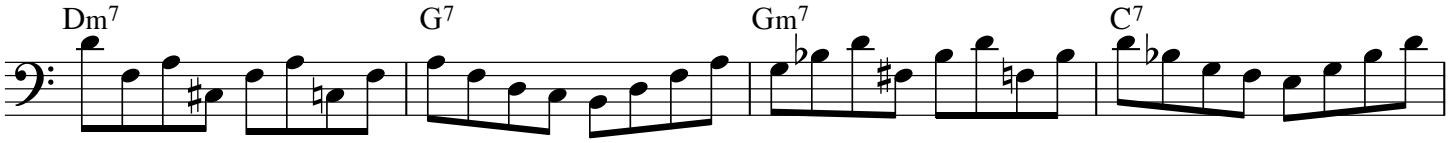


Here's a couple variations of this line:
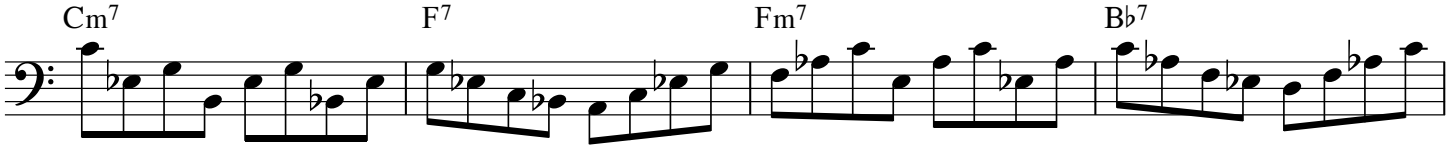


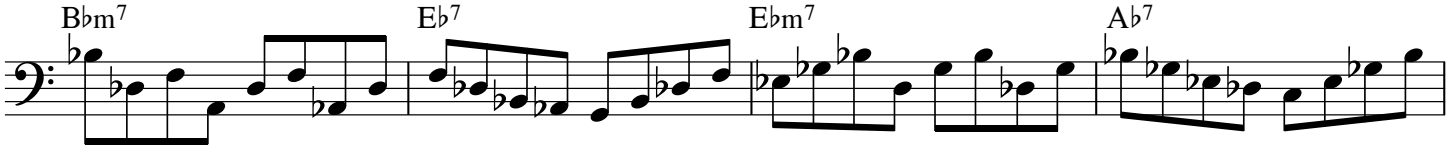


If you tonicize the final note, you can restart the pattern from there and practice it in all 12 keys:

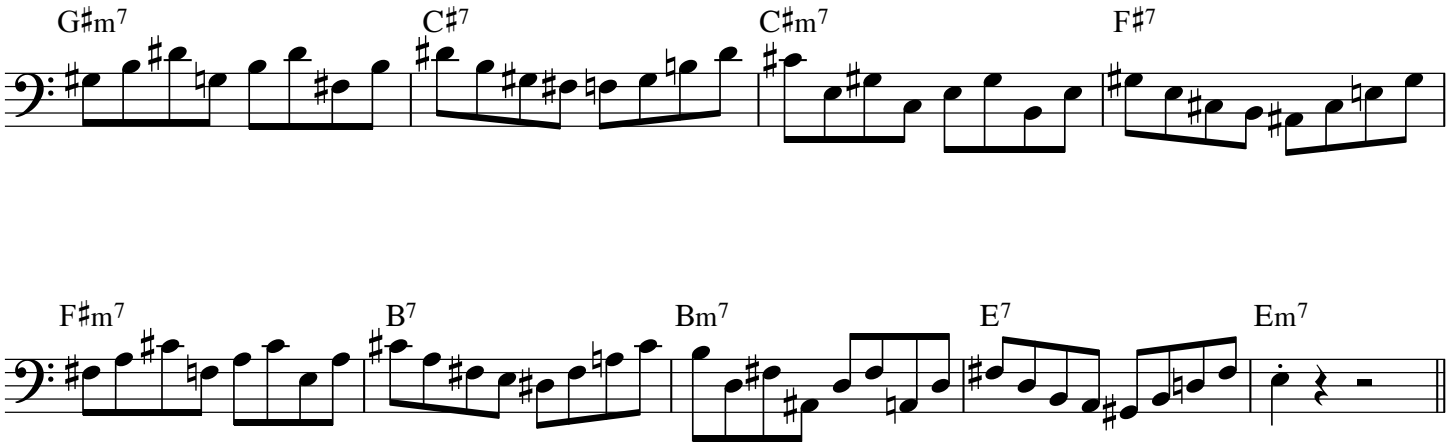




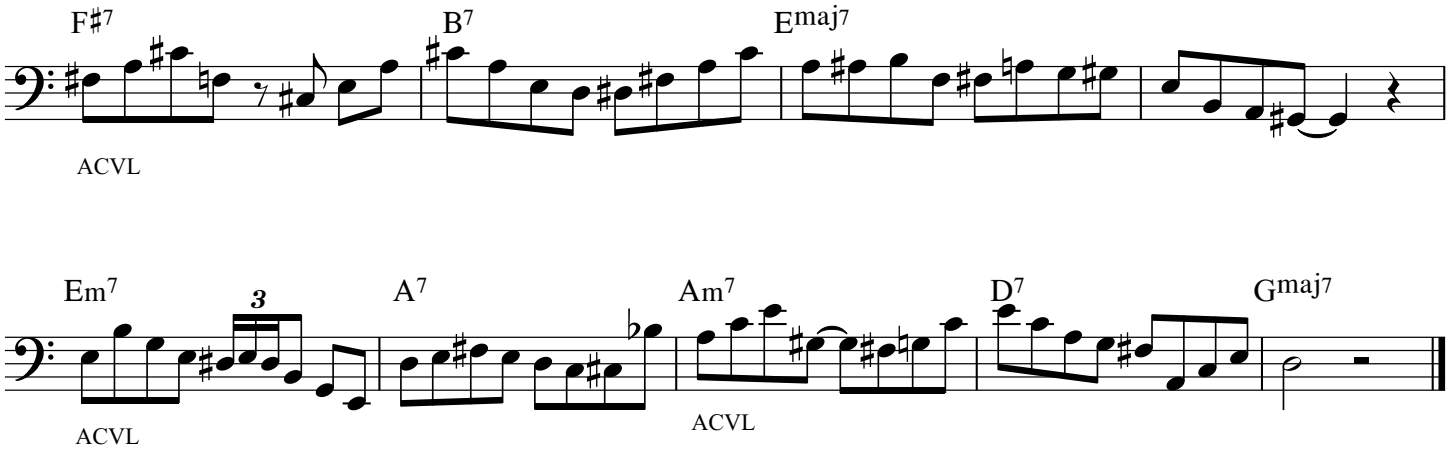


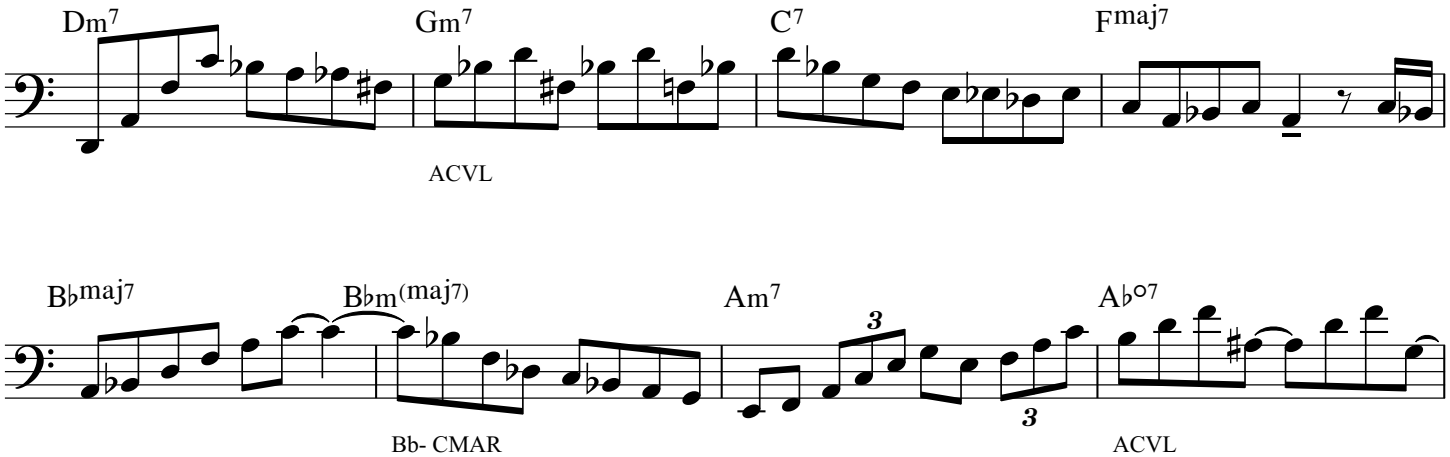


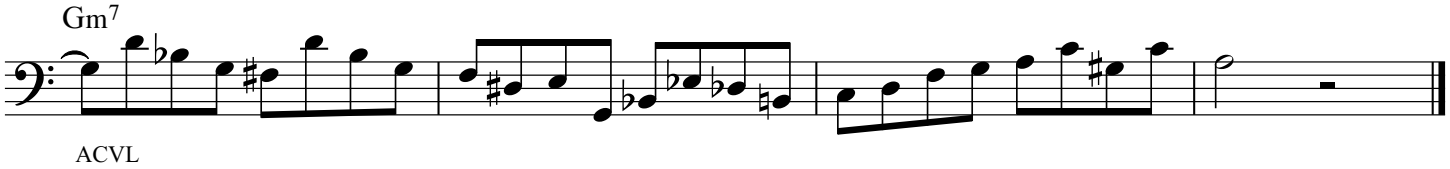
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Here are several phrases of the ACVL lick being played within common jazz chord progressions:





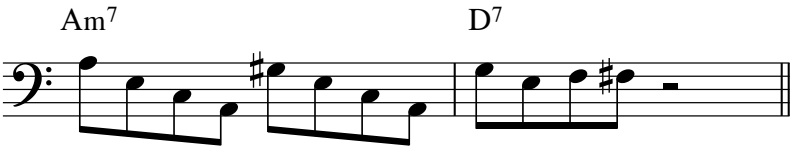


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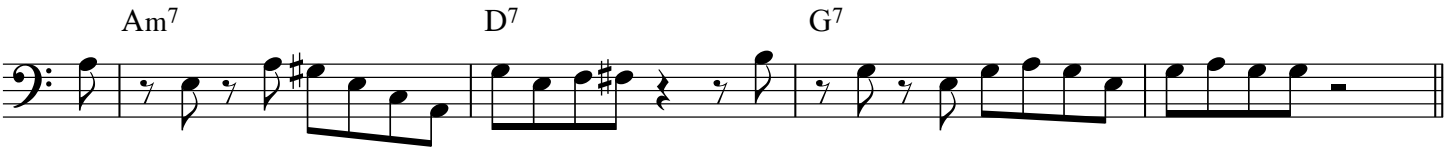
Lick 10

Tenor Madness (TM)

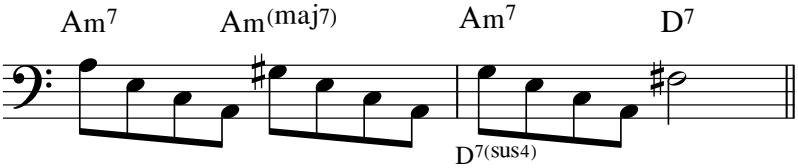
Here's a lick that's similar to the previous one. It's the idea behind what's going on at the end of the melody of the tune "Tenor Madness." So, let's call this one the "Tenor Madness" (TM) lick:
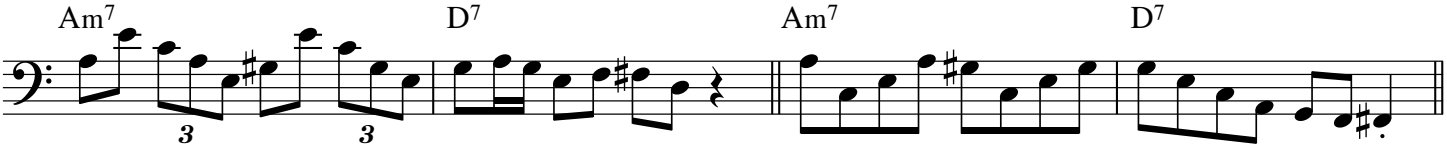


Here is that part of the original melody:
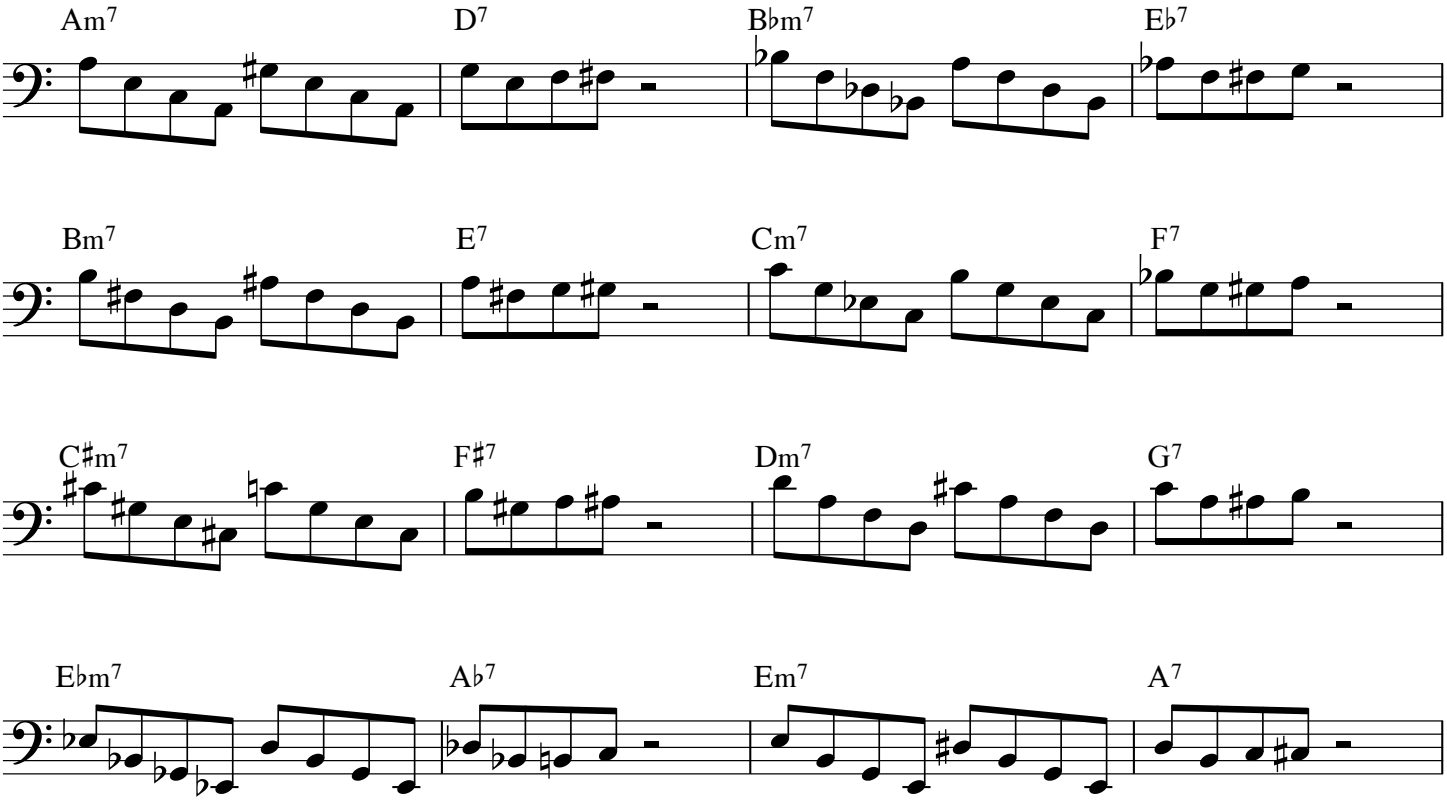


Stripping it down, the TM lick is essentially these structures in this order:



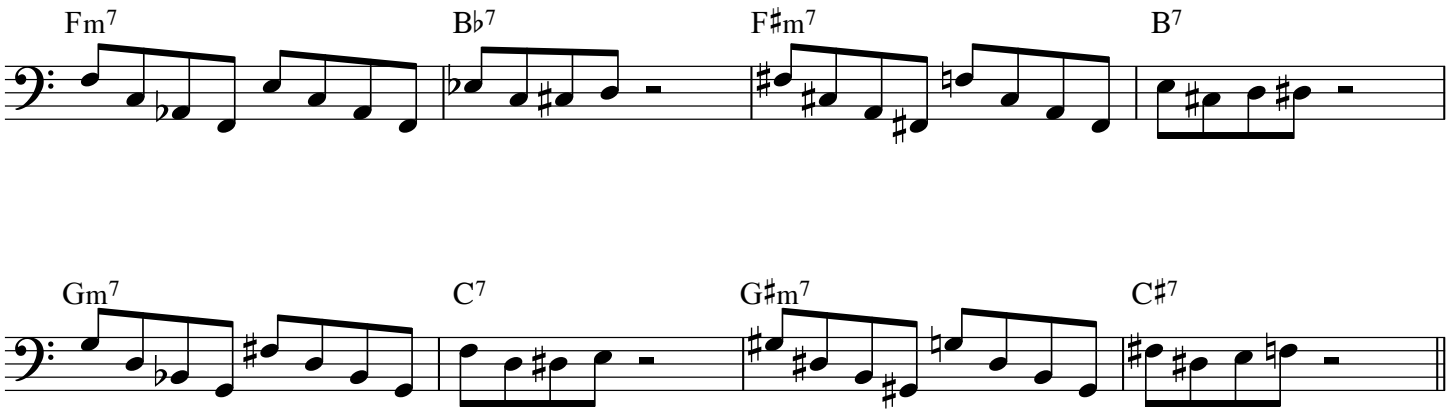
When you're retaining these structures, it's free rein as to how you want to melodically reconstruct them:
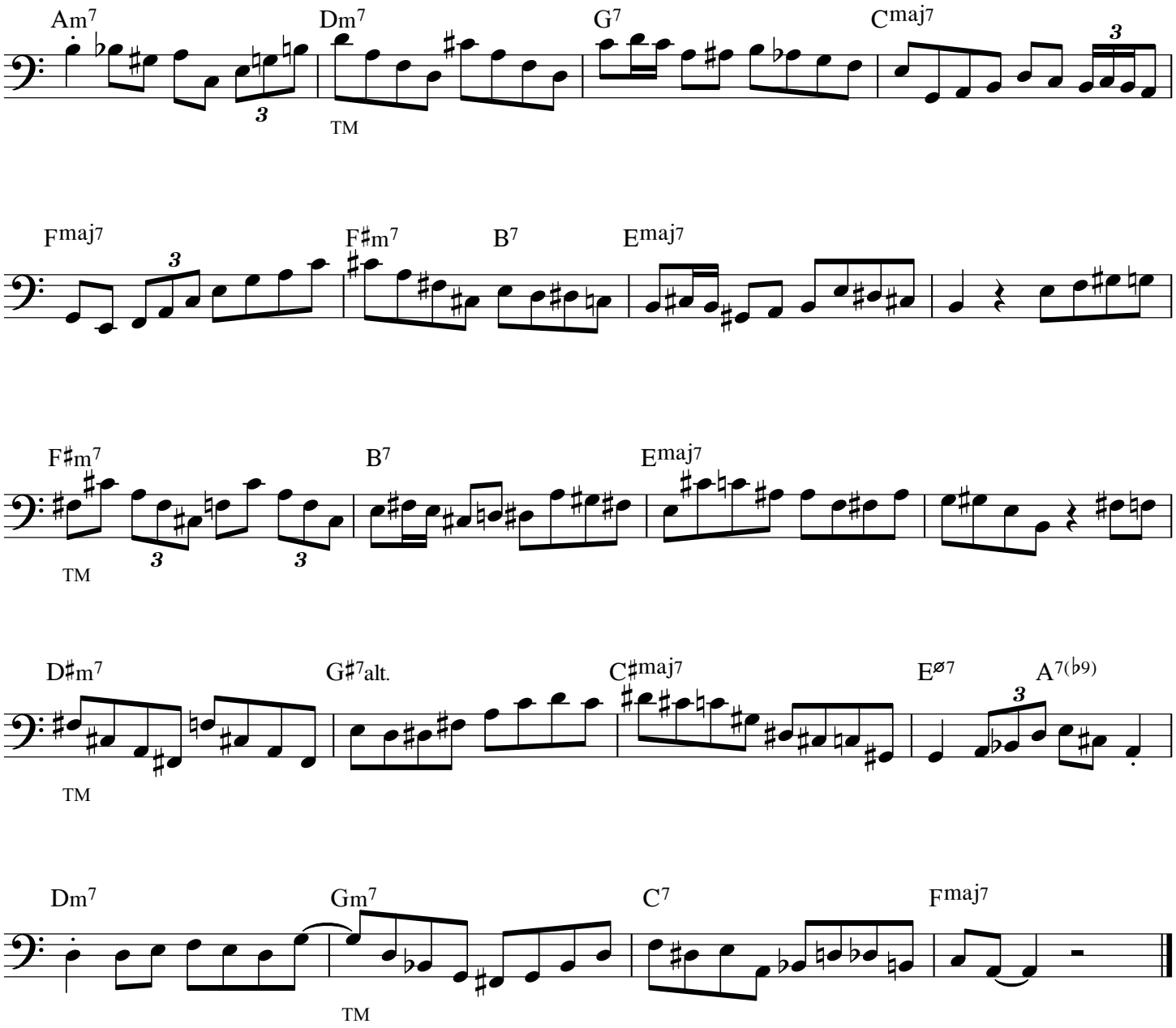


Memorizing the TM lick in 12 keys will be very helpful in the long term:



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Here are several phrases of the TM lick being played within a common jazz chord progression:

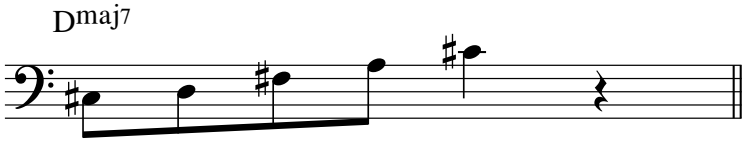


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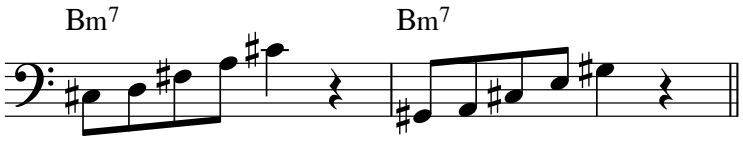
Lick 11

Third Inversion Seventh Chord (TISC)
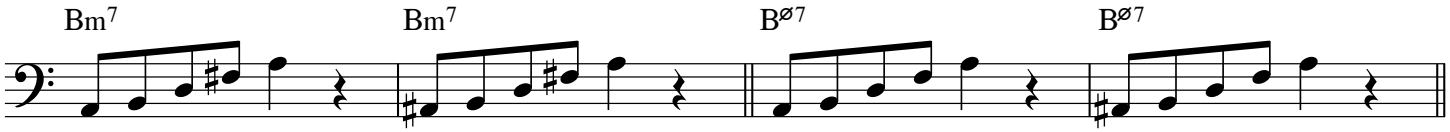
This cell is in 90%+ of bebop solos. It's an upwards arpeggio starting on its 7th - in other words, the third inversion of a seventh chord. So, we'll label it as the "Third Inversion Seventh Chord" (TISC):
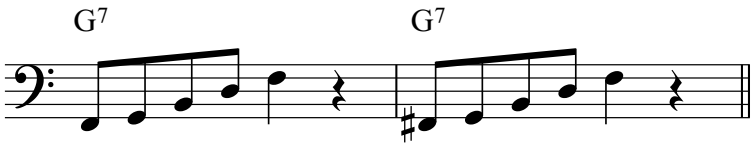


You can play this cell from multiple spots within a chord.

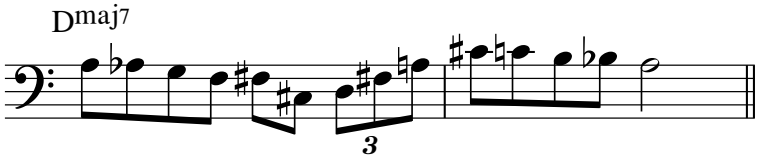


The cell works for other chord qualities as well. It's also pretty common to change their starting minor 7th into a chromatic approach note into the root instead.

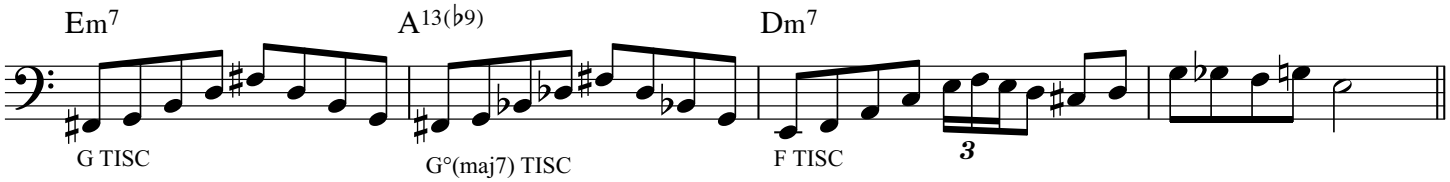




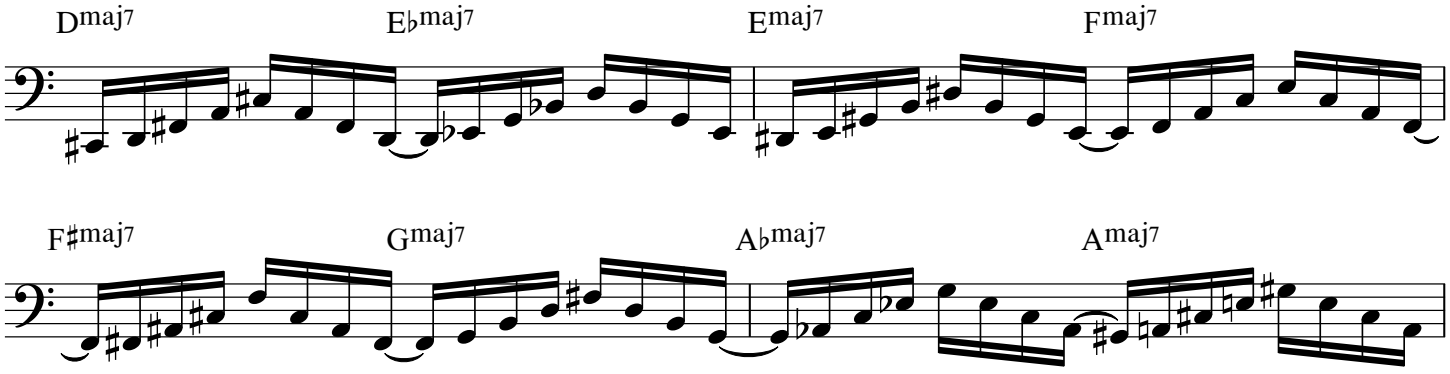
The TISC is a powerful melodic "connector" that allows you to quickly ascend up the registers of your instrument and continue extended melodies:



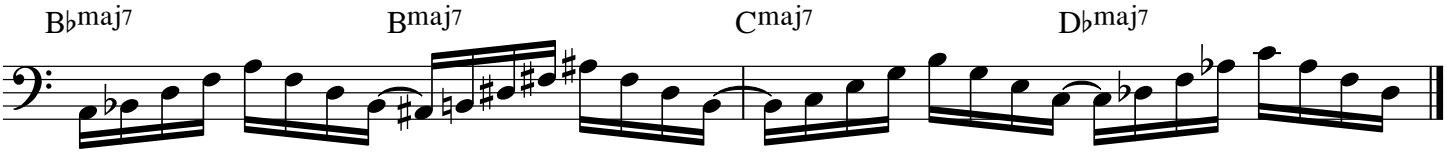
It's very easy to generate beautiful melodies with this cell:



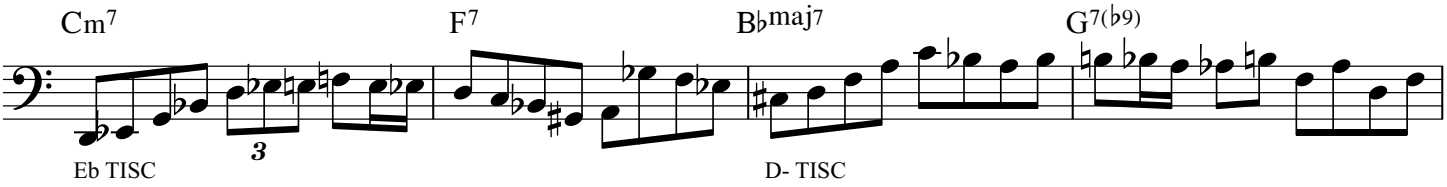
Here's a nice exercise to get you started with internalizing this concept in all 12 keys:
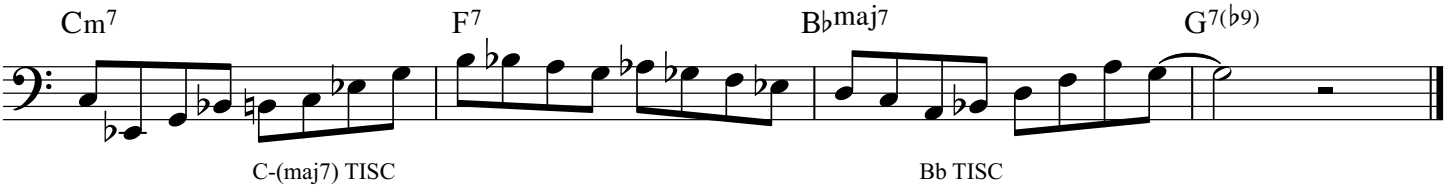


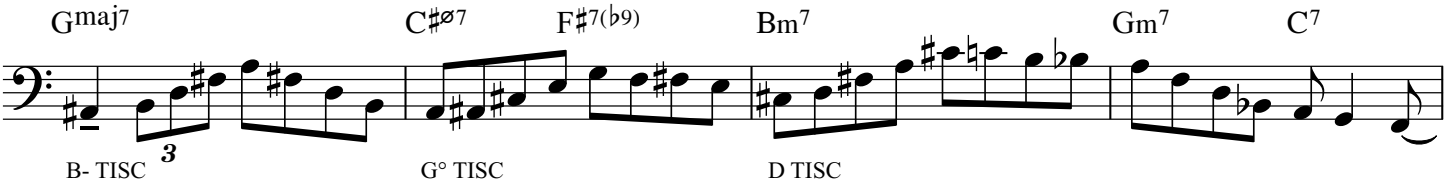
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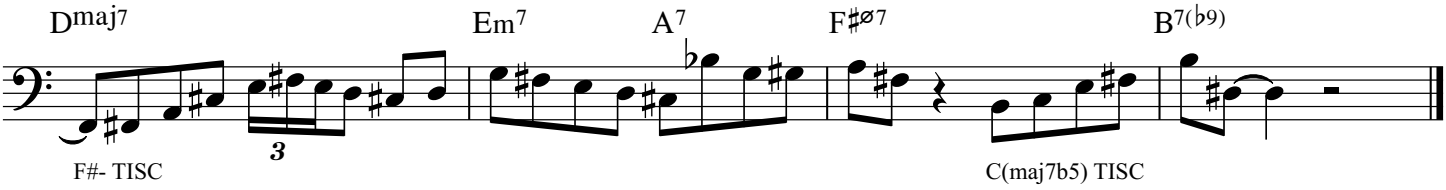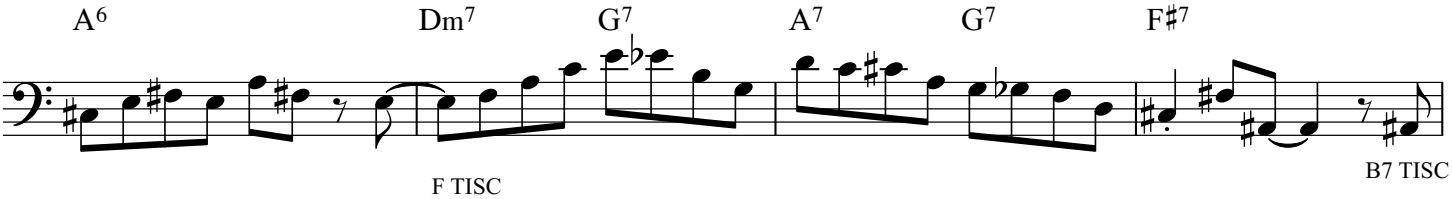


Here are several phrases of the TISC being played within common jazz chord progressions:
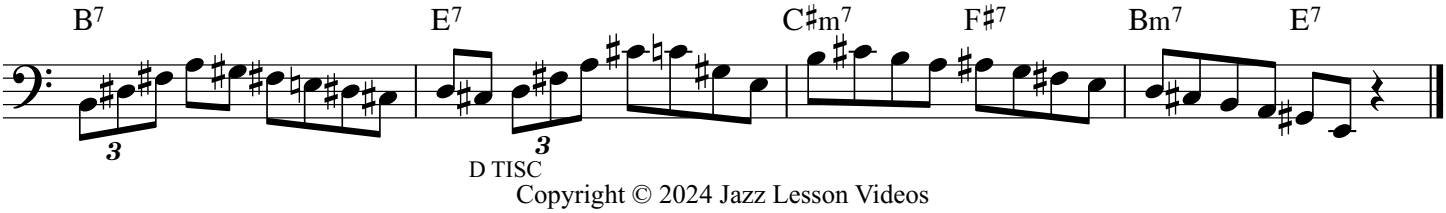










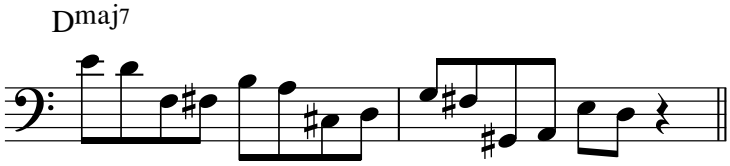


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Lick 12

Embellished Triad (ET)
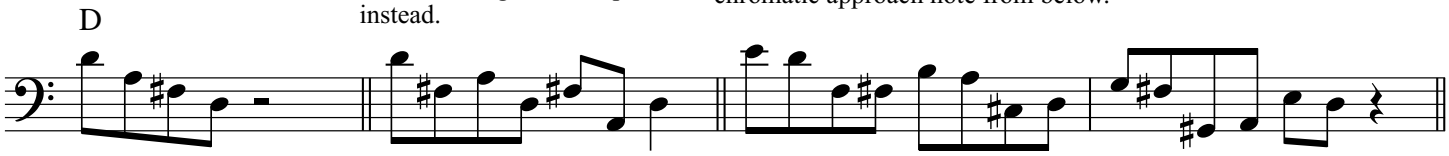
Here's a figure you'll most likely come across in multiple jazz recordings. It's a major triad that's being embellished, so we'll call this the "Embellished Triad" (ET):
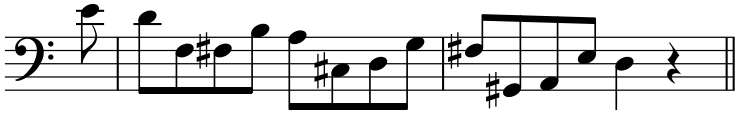


Essentially, we are taking a descending triad...

... and making it stairstep instead.
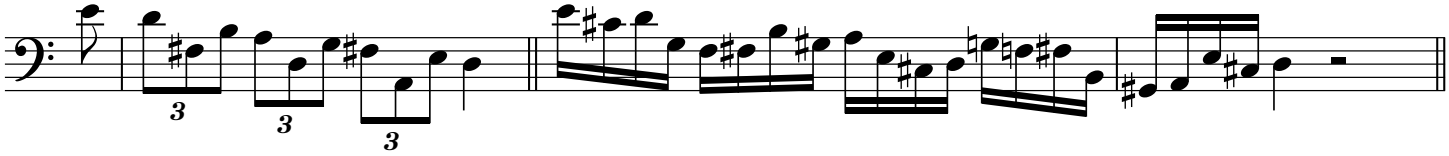
Then, in an alternating fashion, we'll approach a triadic tone with a diatonic note from above, and then the next with a chromatic approach note from below.
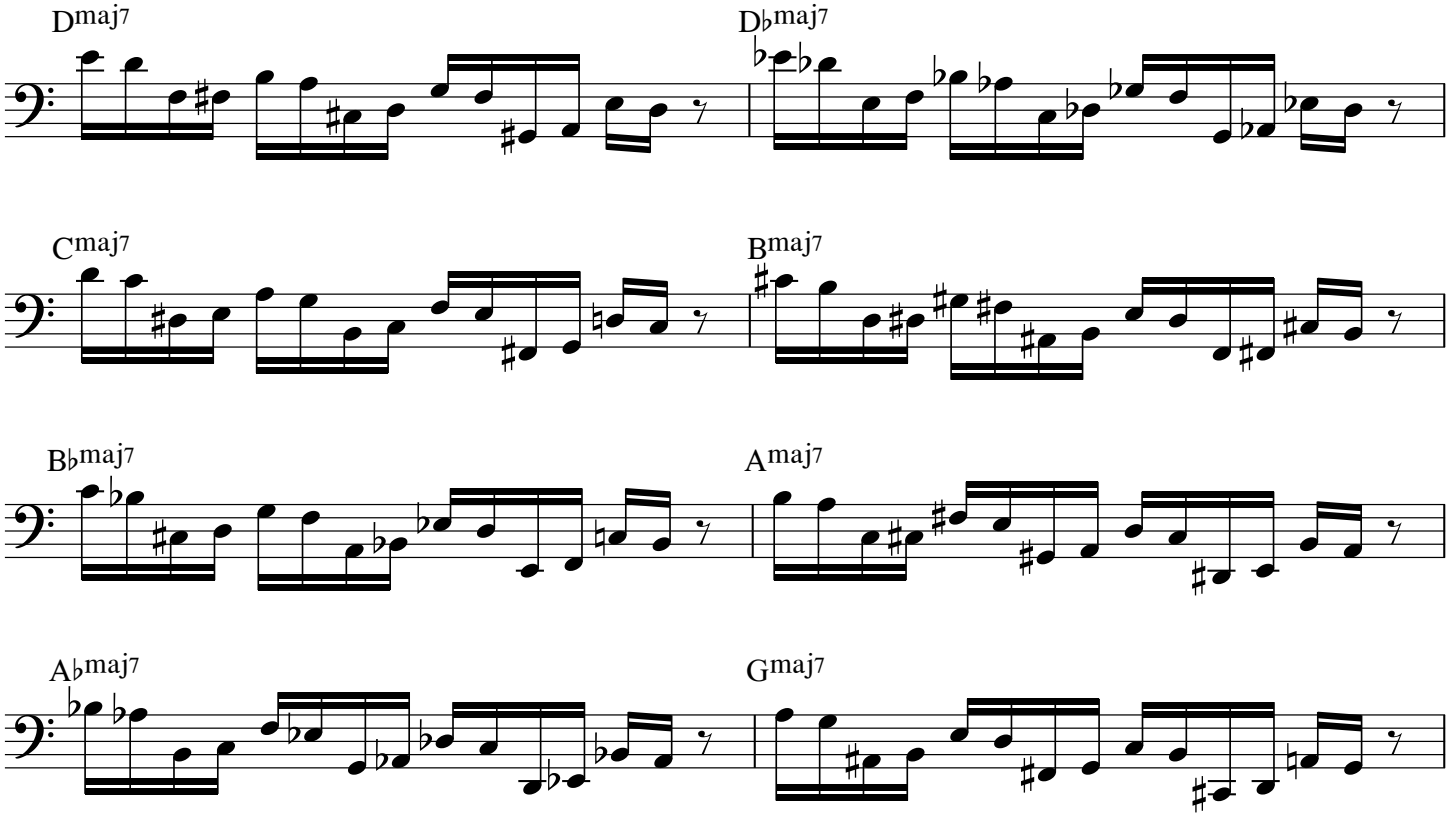


It also sounds nice when the triadic tones are on the downbeats instead:
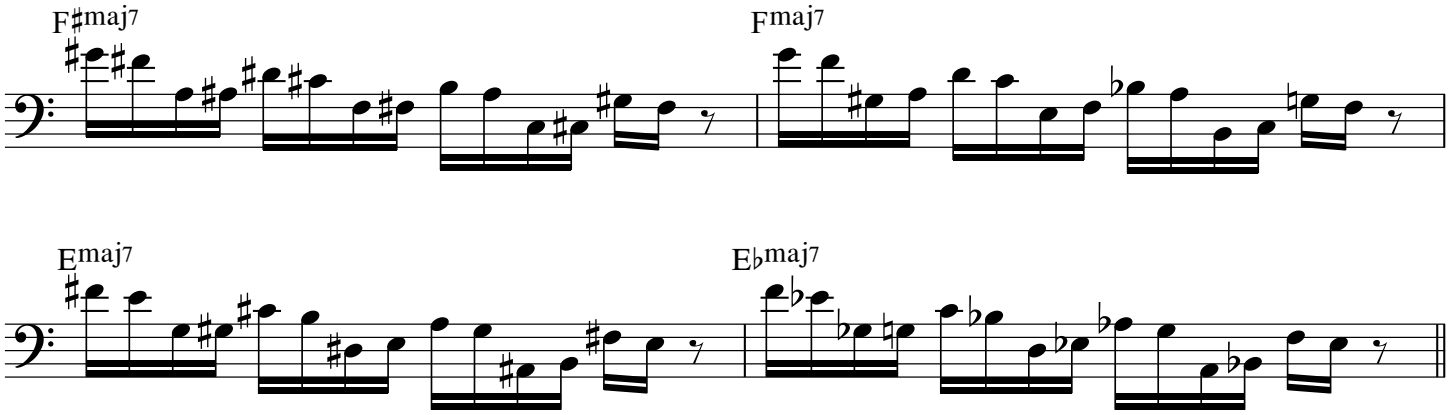


The potential variations for embellishing triads are quite vast!
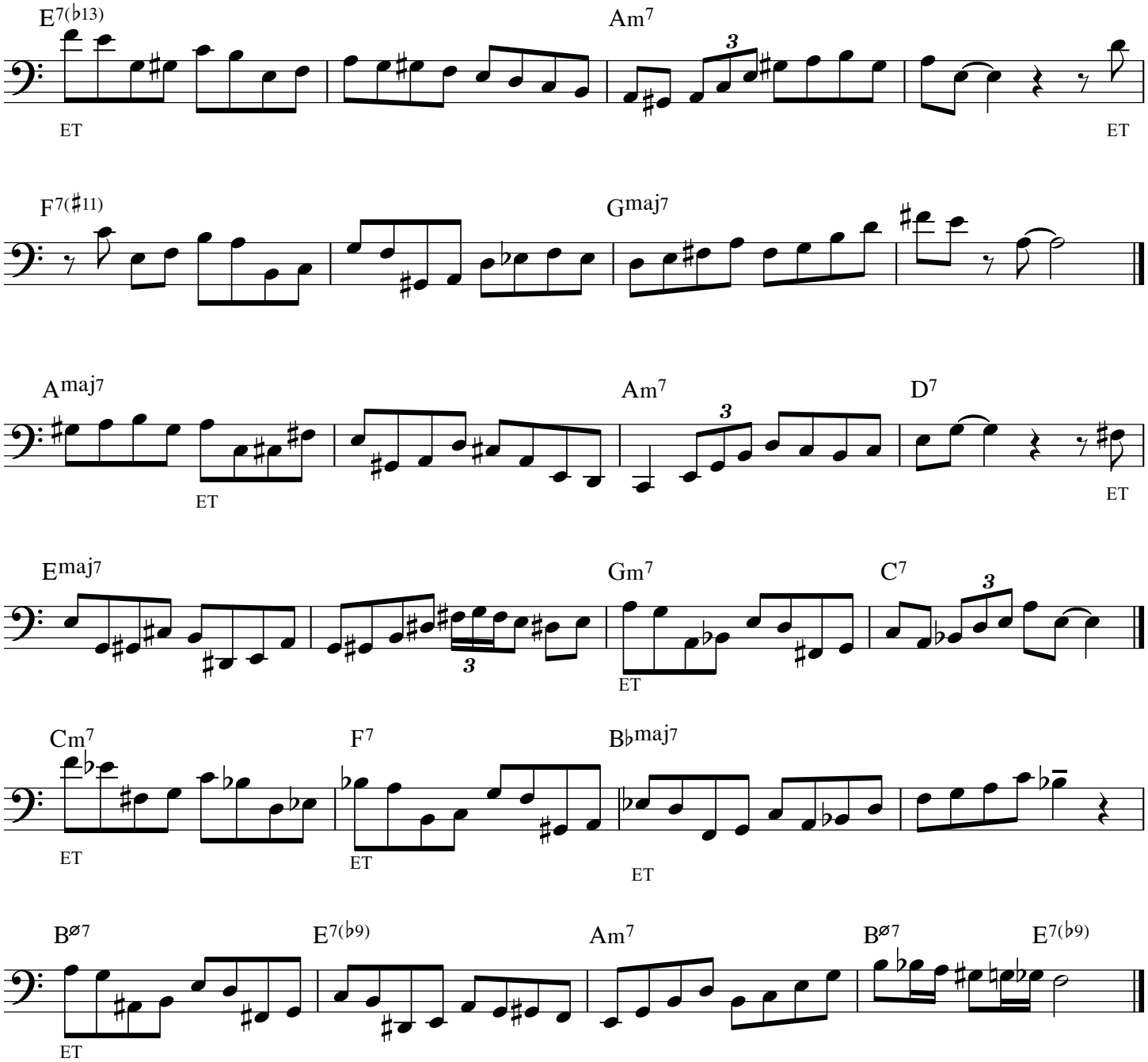


Internalizing this idea in 12 keys will make recreating it on the spot more natural:



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Here are several phrases of the ET being played within common jazz chord progressions:
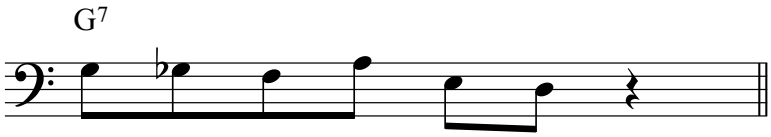


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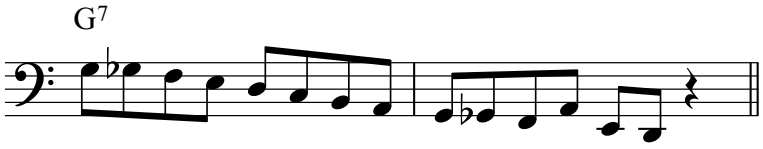
Lick 13

Classic Bebop Cell (CBC)

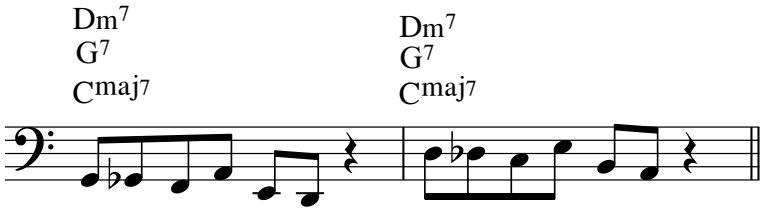
Here's a classic bebop cell that even Cannonball played often. We'll call this one the "Classic Bebop Cell" (CBC):
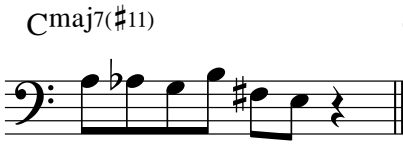


It's helpful to ingrain this figure into your ear by ending descending bebop scales with it:
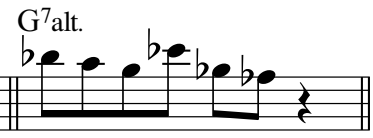


For everywhere that you'll find this phrase works in a V7 chord, it will also work in its ii-7 and Imaj7 chords:
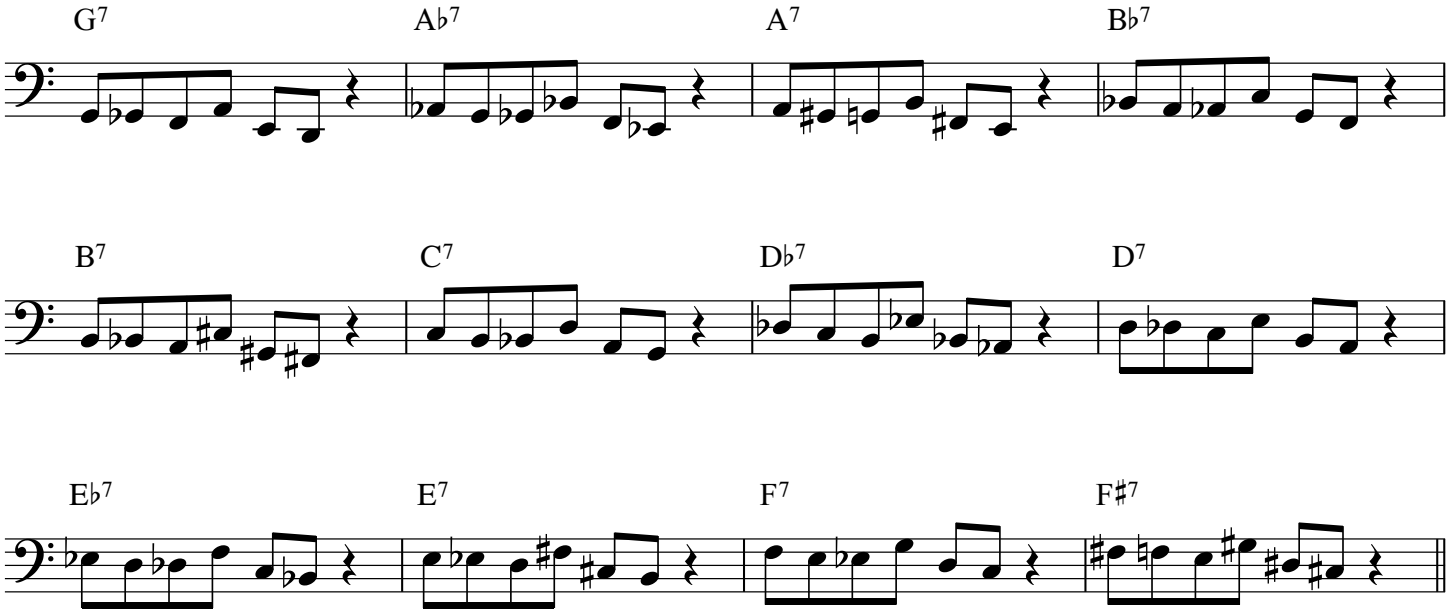


For #11 chords, this cell starting from the 6th works great:



For altered chords, play the figure up a tritone from the root for a really effective sound:
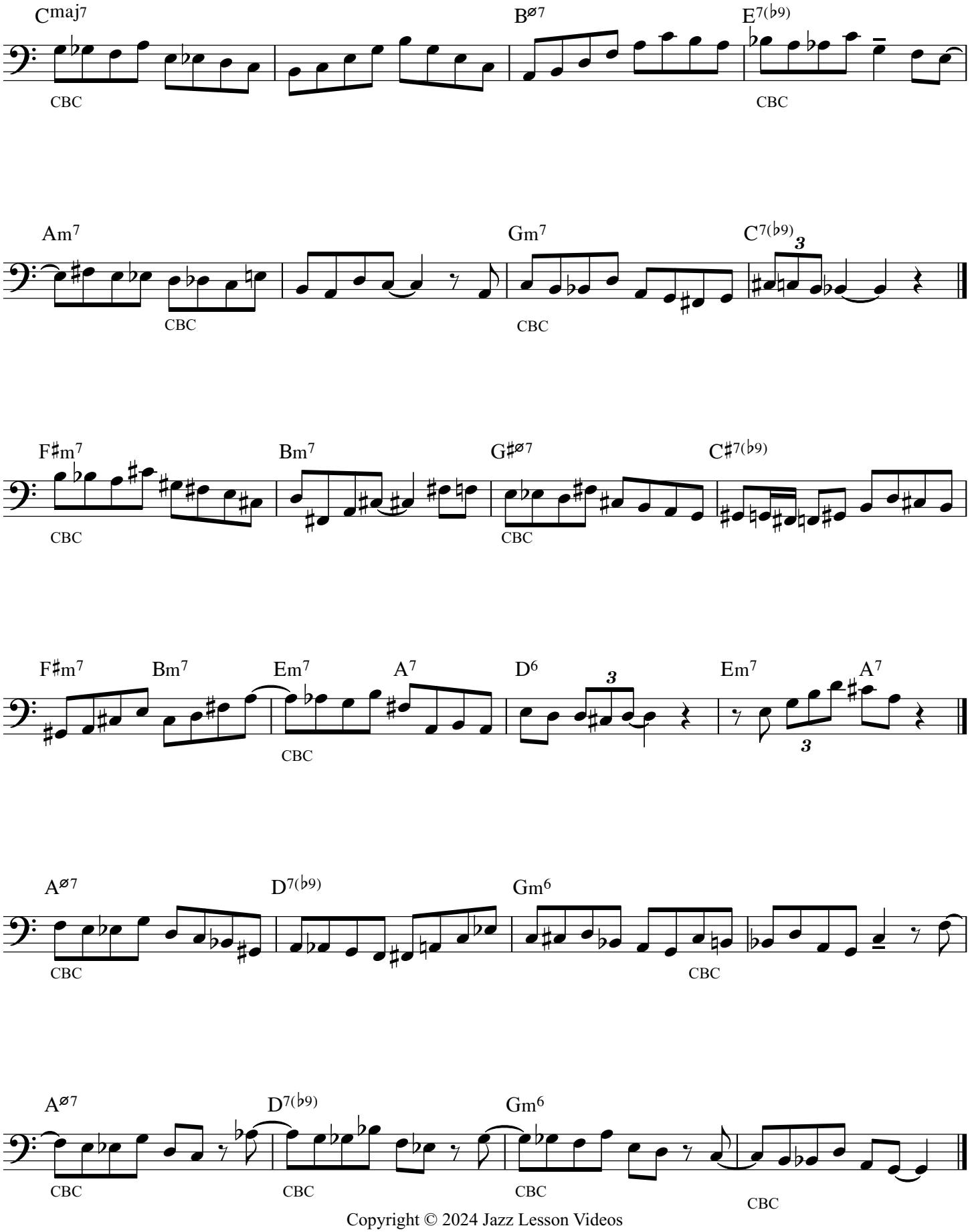


Memorizing this in 12 keys will help you transcribe some solos faster since you're bound to hear this again and again:



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26 Here are several phrases of the CBC being played within common jazz chord progressions:
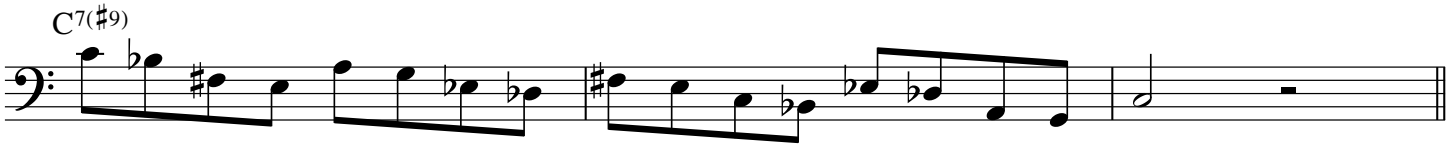


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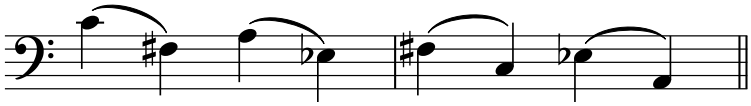
Lick 14

John Coltrane Diminished Pattern (JCDP):
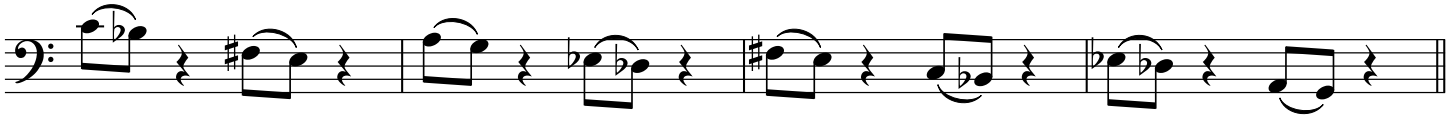
Here's a diminished pattern made famous by John Coltrane. So, let's call this the "John Coltrane Diminished Pattern" (JCDP):
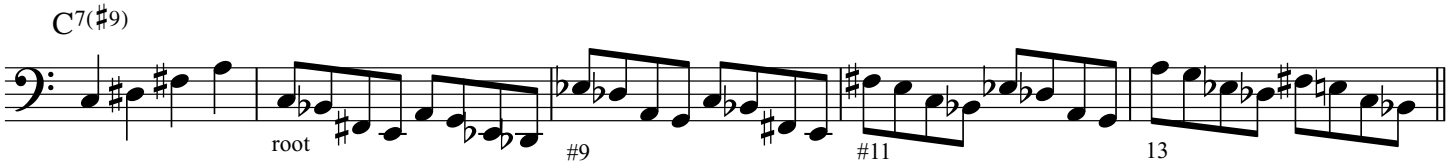


Here's the skeleton of this pattern. It's a tritone interval, descending in minor 3rds.



Then, each pitch travels down a major 2nd.

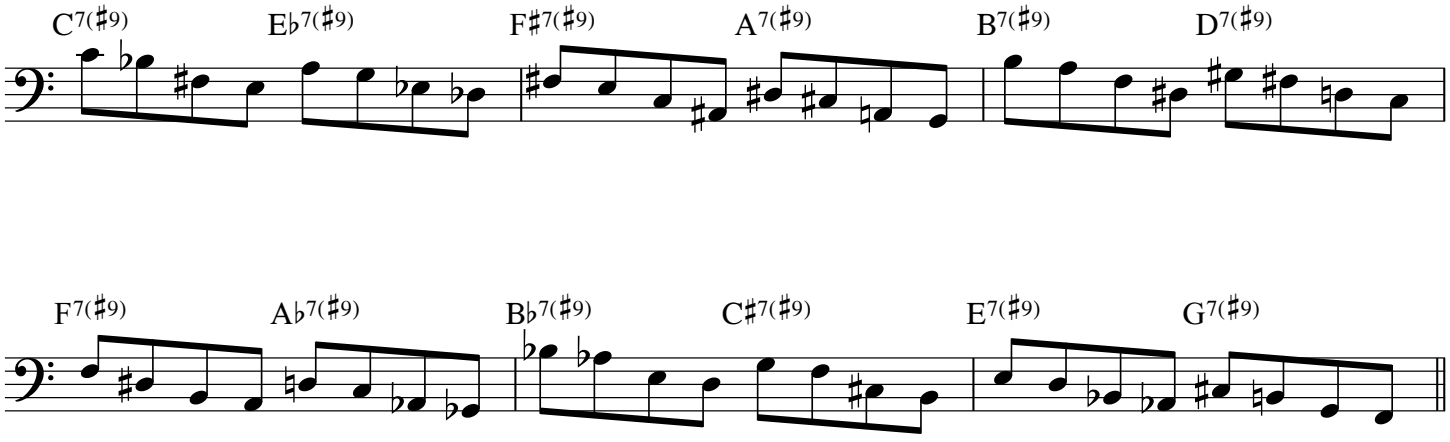


For dominant chords with altered extensions, this pattern will work when starting from the root, #9, #11, or 13:
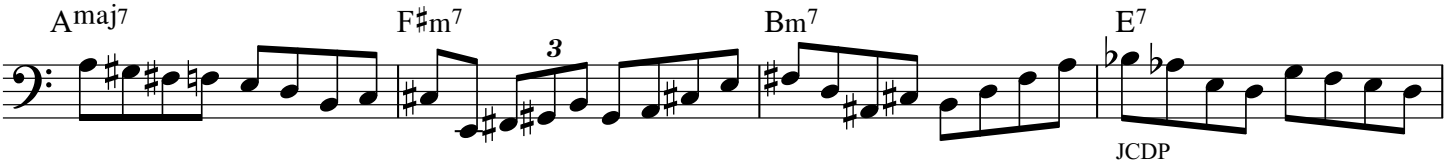


*for diminished 7th chords, this pattern works when starting from 7, 9, 11, or b13.
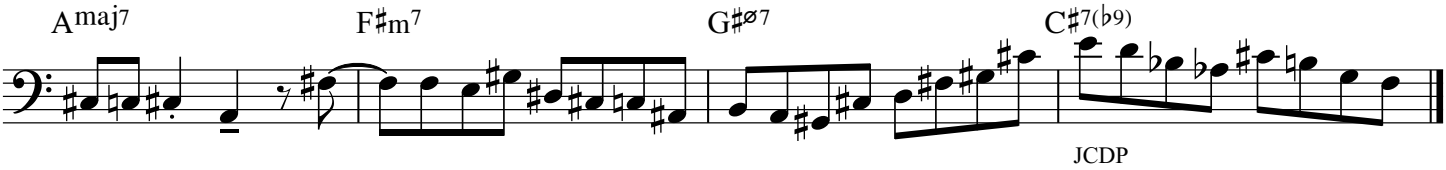
This pattern can be tranposed to two other keys. Each key covers four different dominant chords, totaling to 12:

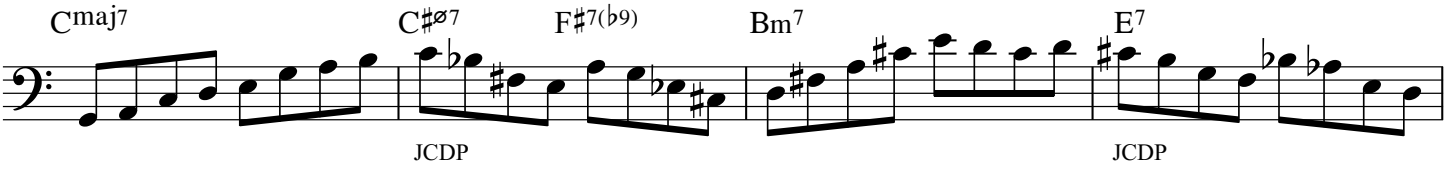


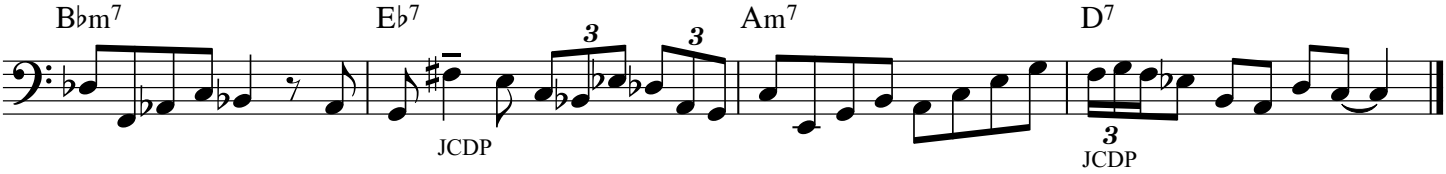
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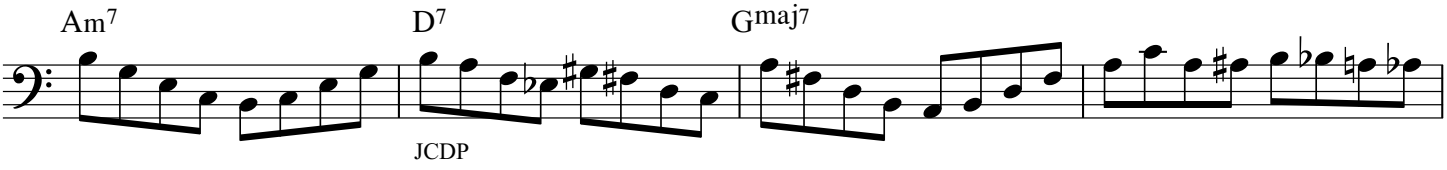
 Here are several phrases of the JCDP being played within common jazz chord progressions:
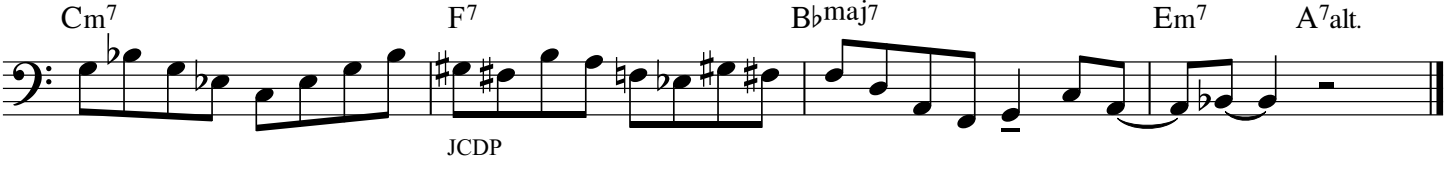










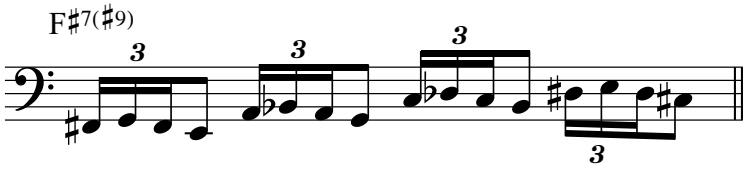


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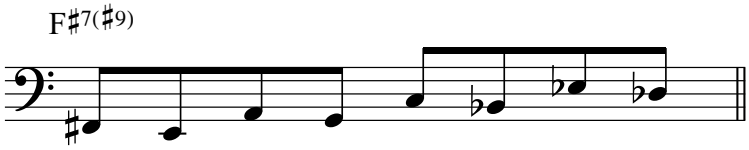
Lick 15

Turning Diminished Pattern (TDP):

Here's another diminished pattern that Sonny Stitt played frequently that features the ornamentation known as the turn/flip. Let's call this one the "Turning Diminished Pattern" (TDP):
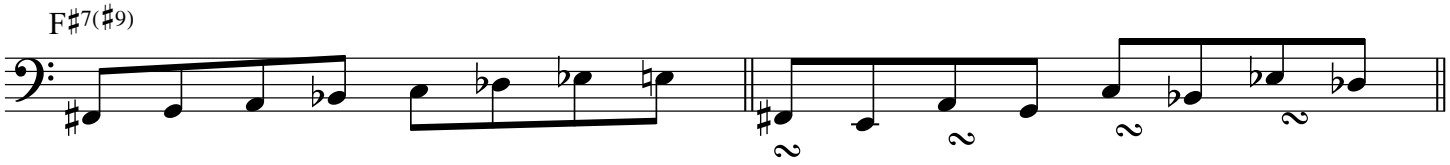


This is the skeleton of the pattern:
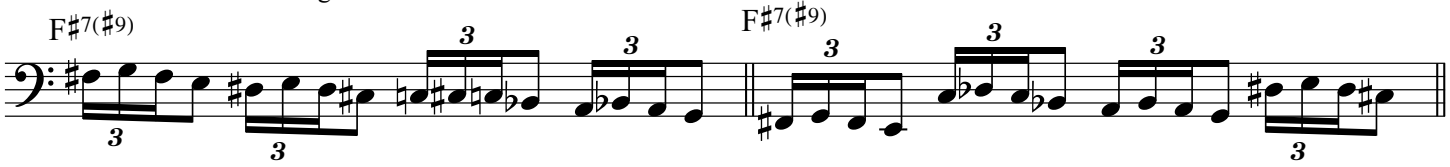


By using half-whole diminished scale....

... you'll add turns to the 'skeleton' like this:

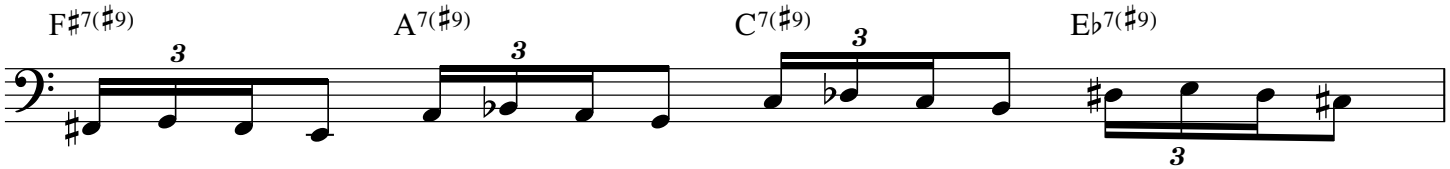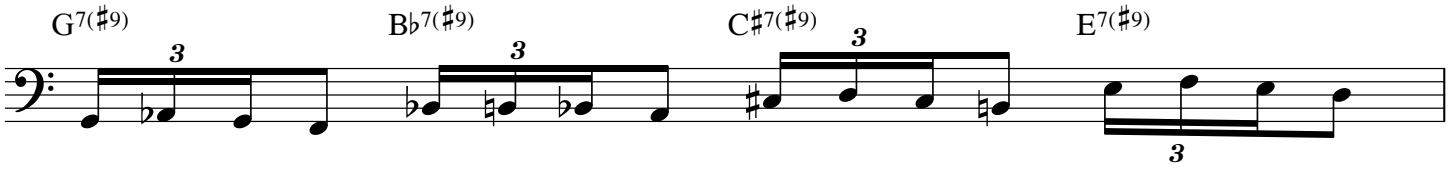


It also works descending...

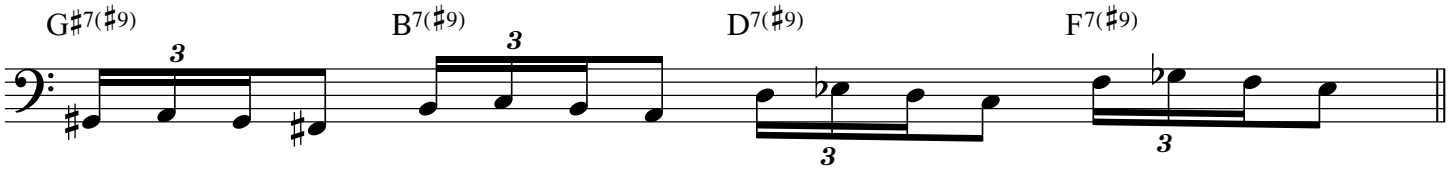
... and really, in any order:



There's 3 total transpositions of this pattern and each one covers 4 different dominant chords, totaling to 12:

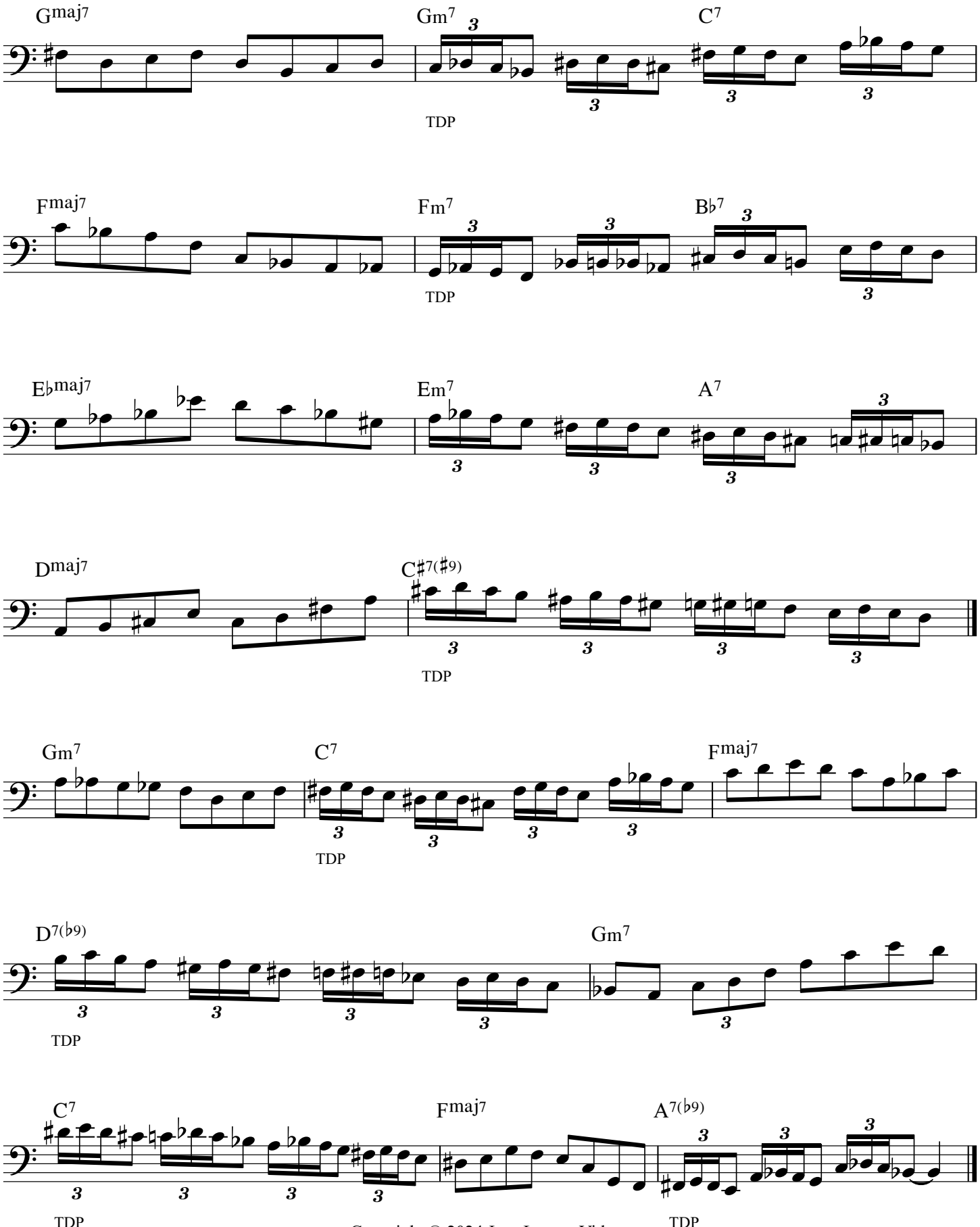






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 Here are several phrases of the TDP being played within common jazz chord progressions:
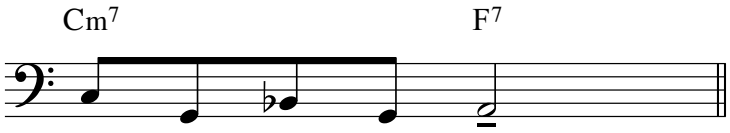


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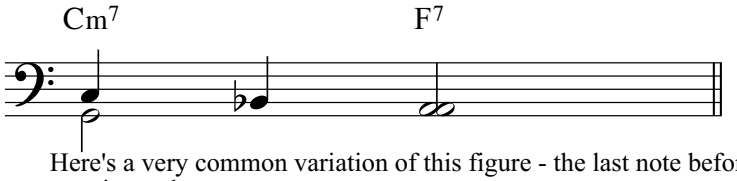
Lick 16

Sandwich Enclosure (SE):

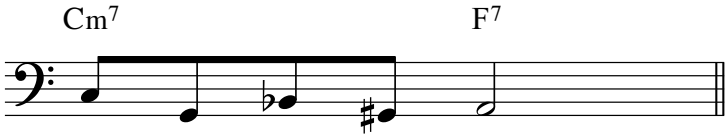
Here's an important sound heard in hundreds of bebop solo recordings. We're approaching the 3rd of the dominant chord with a zig-zag 4-note enclosure, so let's call this the "Sandwich Enclosure" (SE):



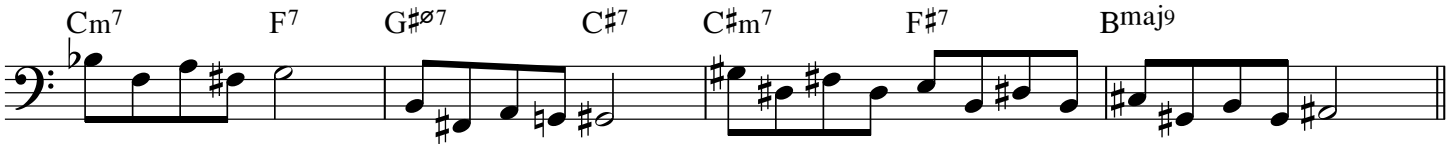
This is what's really going on. Essentially, you're acting as two voices at once - the top voice travels downwards from the root and resolves onto the third of the next chord, and the bottom voice sits on the fifth and resolves upwards onto the third:



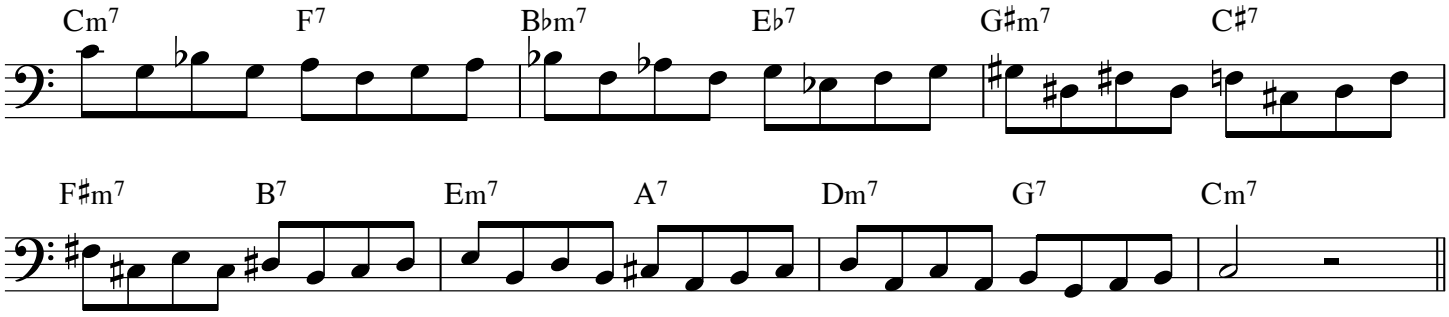
Here's a very common variation of this figure - the last note before the third becomes a chromatic approach note instead:



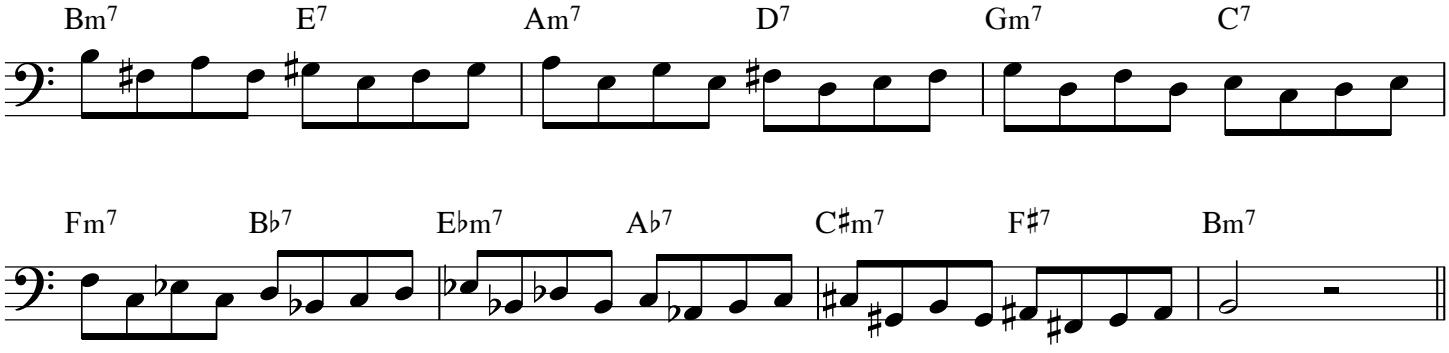
As long as your first 2 notes are a diatonic 4th apart, you can really "sandwich" any desired target!



But, using it to target the 3rd is undoubtedly the most common context you'll hear this figure in, so it's best to start there and learn it in all 12 keys. Here's a fun pattern to try:
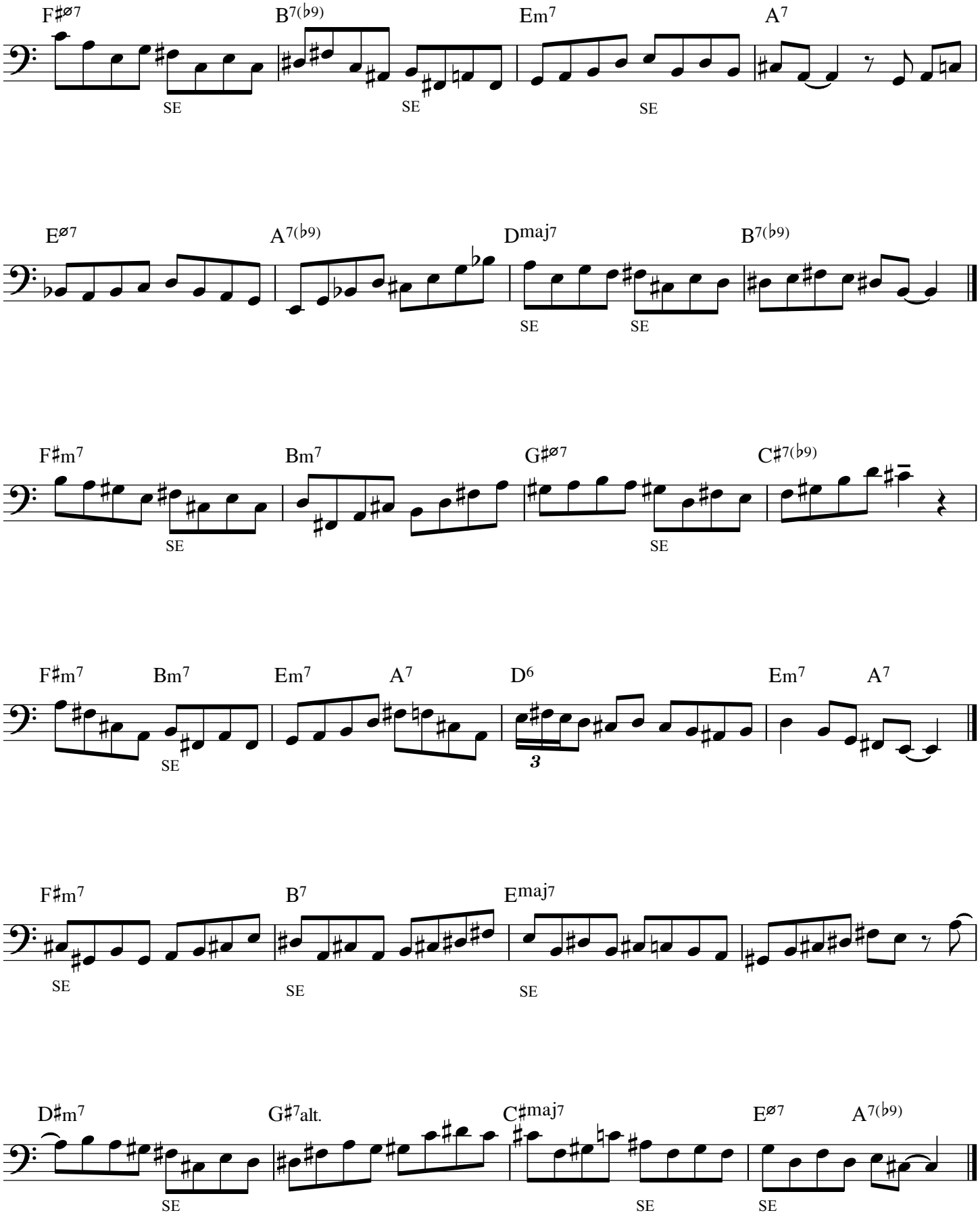


Don't forget the other 6 keys!



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 Here are several phrases of the SE being played within common jazz chord progressions:
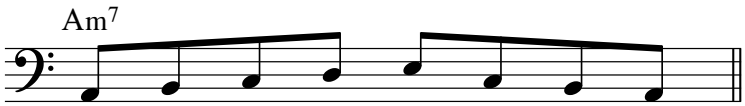


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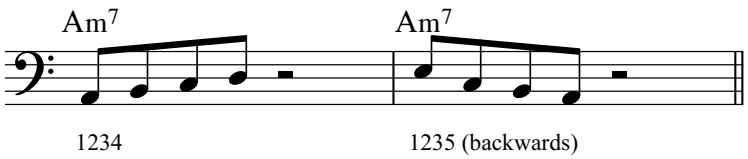
Lick 17

Minor Passage (MP):
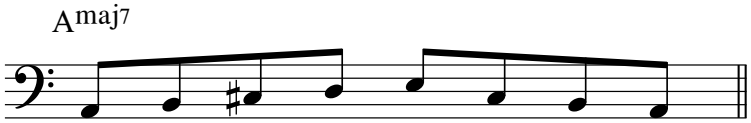
Here's a common passage often played in minor chords. Let's label it the "Minor Passage" (MP):
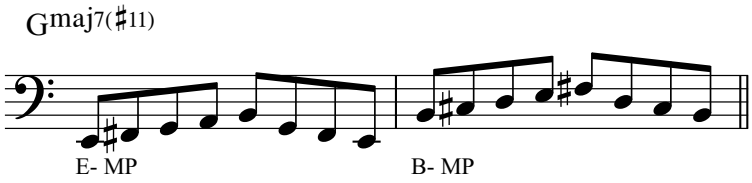


Essentially, it's just a 1234 cell connected to a backwards 1235 cell, in a minor key!
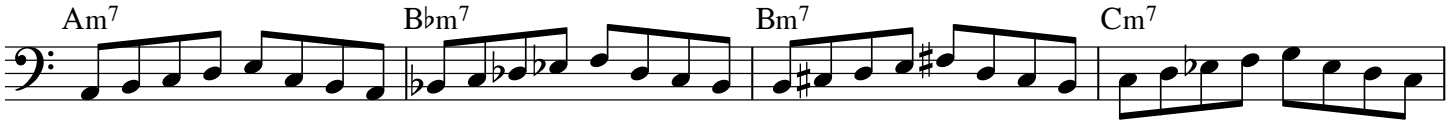


You can make it major as well, but it's not heard nearly as often (and in my opinion, doesn't sound as cool):
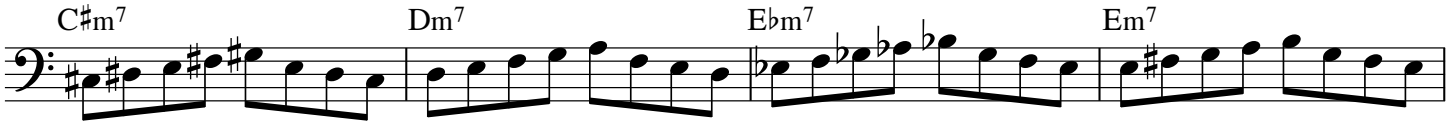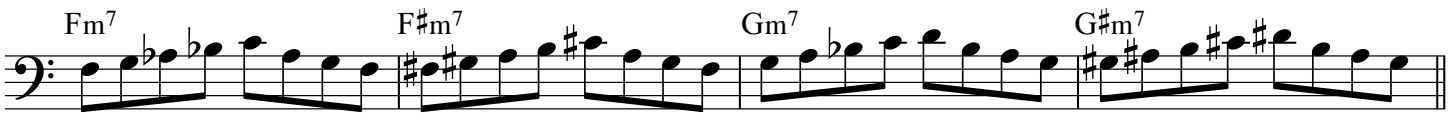


When exploring a chord, check for all the spots where the MP fits diatonically:



Because this passage is inherently melodic and is a reliable way to fill up a measure, this one is absolutely worth mastering in 12 keys:

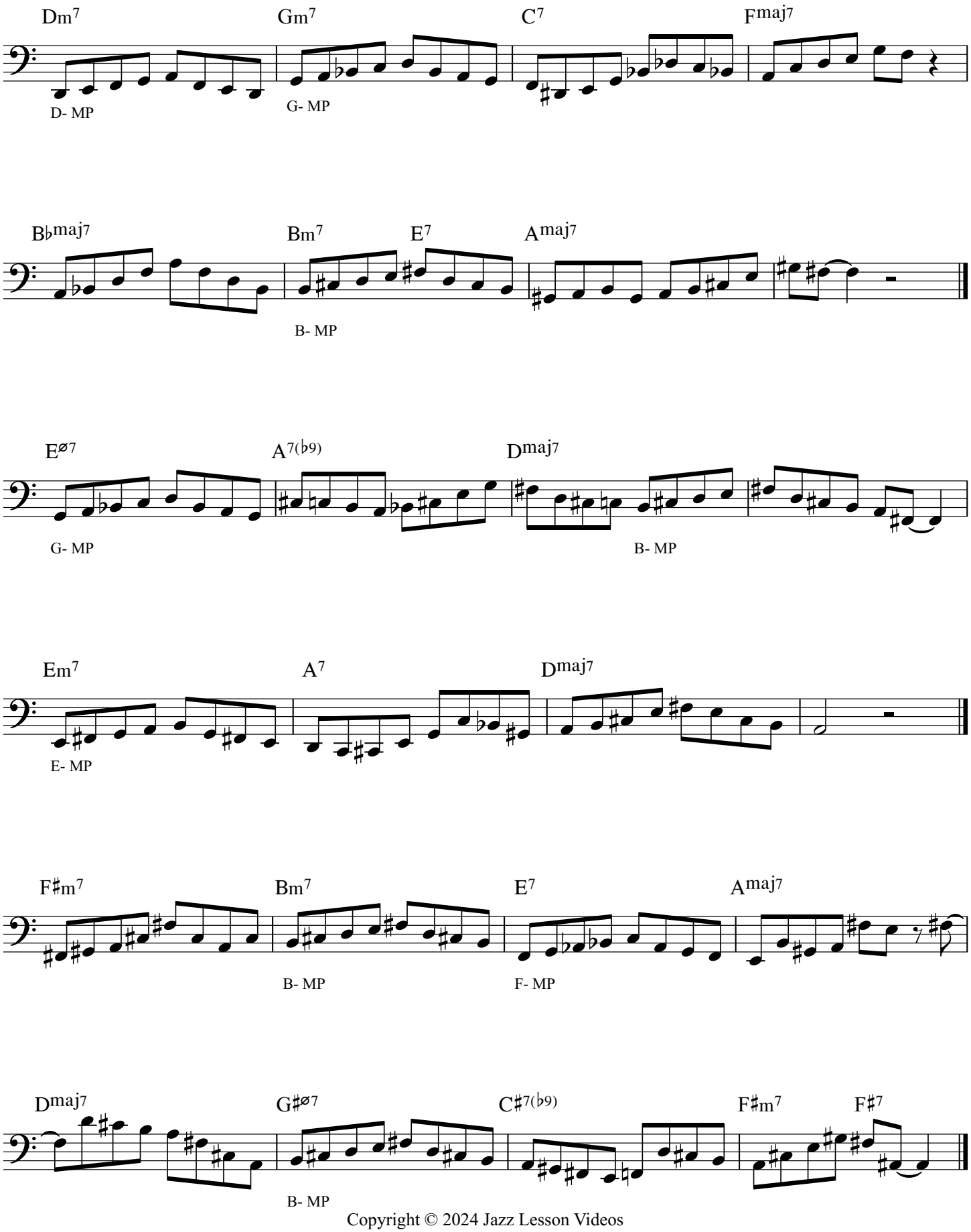






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 Here are several phrases of the MP being played within common jazz chord progressions:
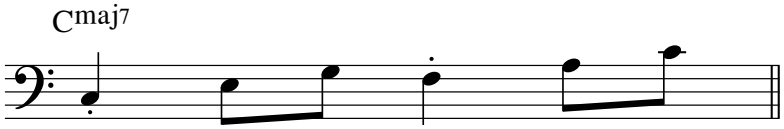


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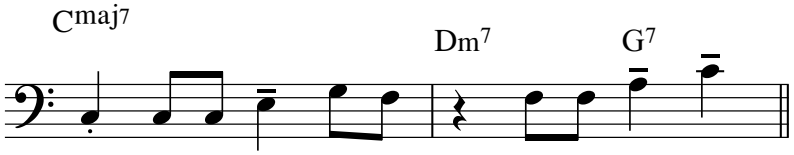
Lick 18

Sonny Stitt Resolution (SSR):

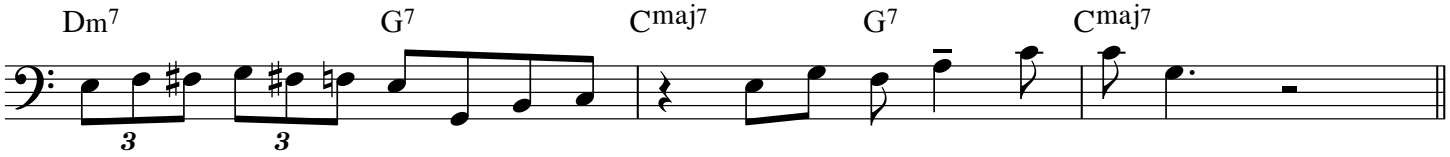
Here's a resolution Sonny Stitt made famous. Let's call this the Sonny Stitt Resolution (SSR):



If you make it twice as long, it can be a great way to end a solo:

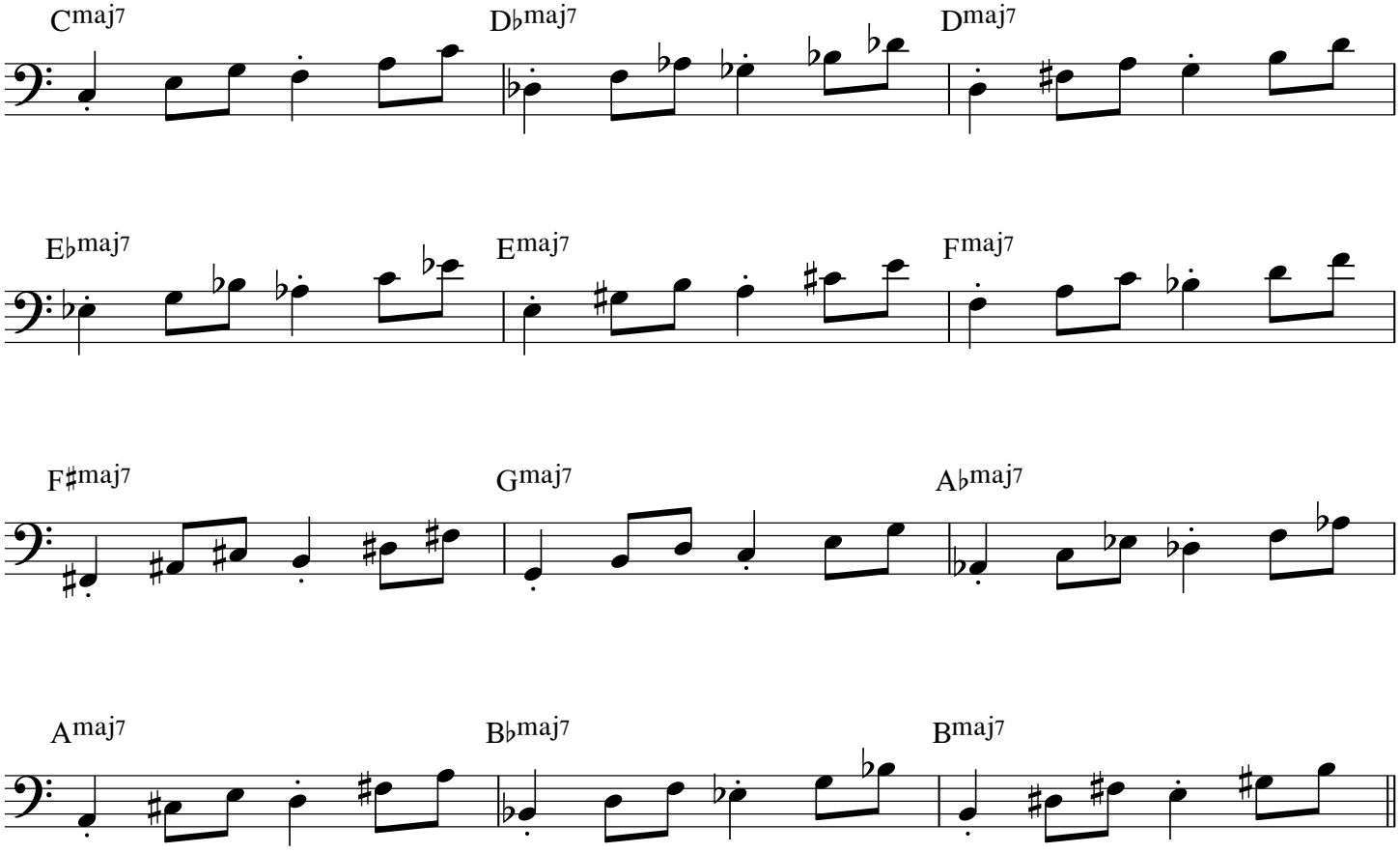


Here's a resolution directly from a Stitt solo containing this figure:



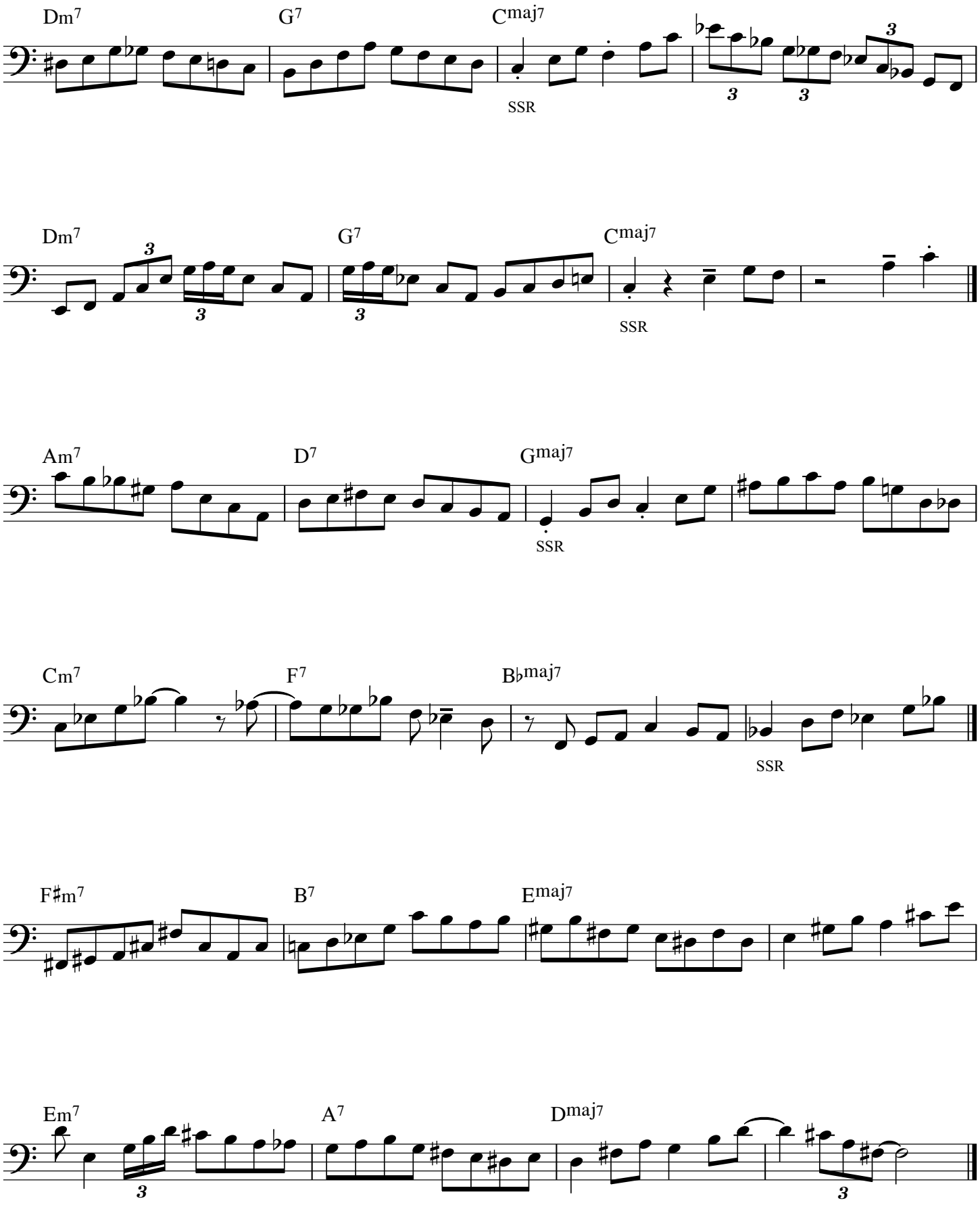
SSR

This truly is a resolution that seems to make your peers smile when you play it in a solo, as it usually sounds familiar to anyone even if they don't quite know where it's from. It's worth memorizing it in 12 keys!



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Here are several phrases of the SSR being played within common jazz chord progressions:
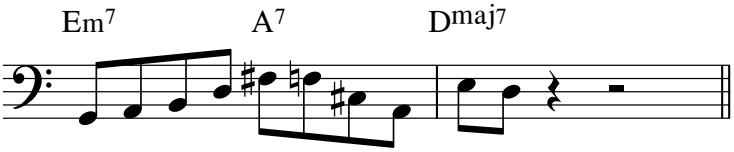


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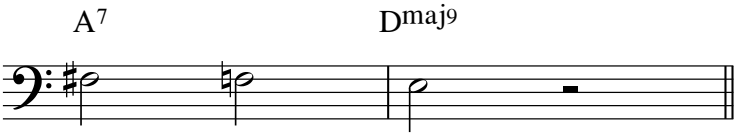
Lick 19

Surprise Augmented Triad (SAT)
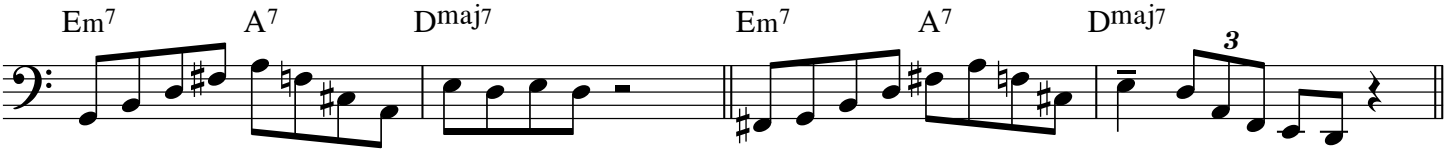
Here's a nice short ii-V phrase you may come across that feautures a surpise augmented triad. Let's call it the "Surpise Augmented Triad" (SAT) lick:
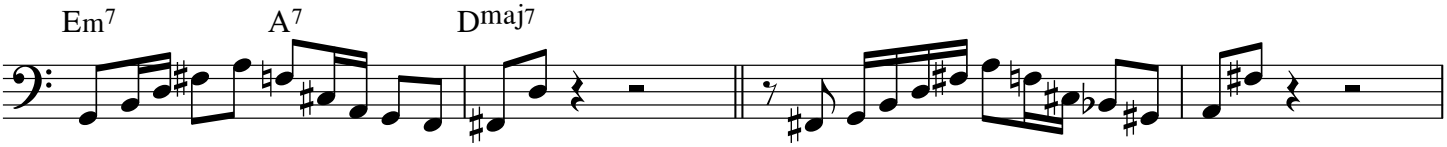


Really, it's a neat decoration around the chromatic voice-leading of 13 - b13 of the V7 chord to the 9th of the destination Imaj7 (or imin7) chord:



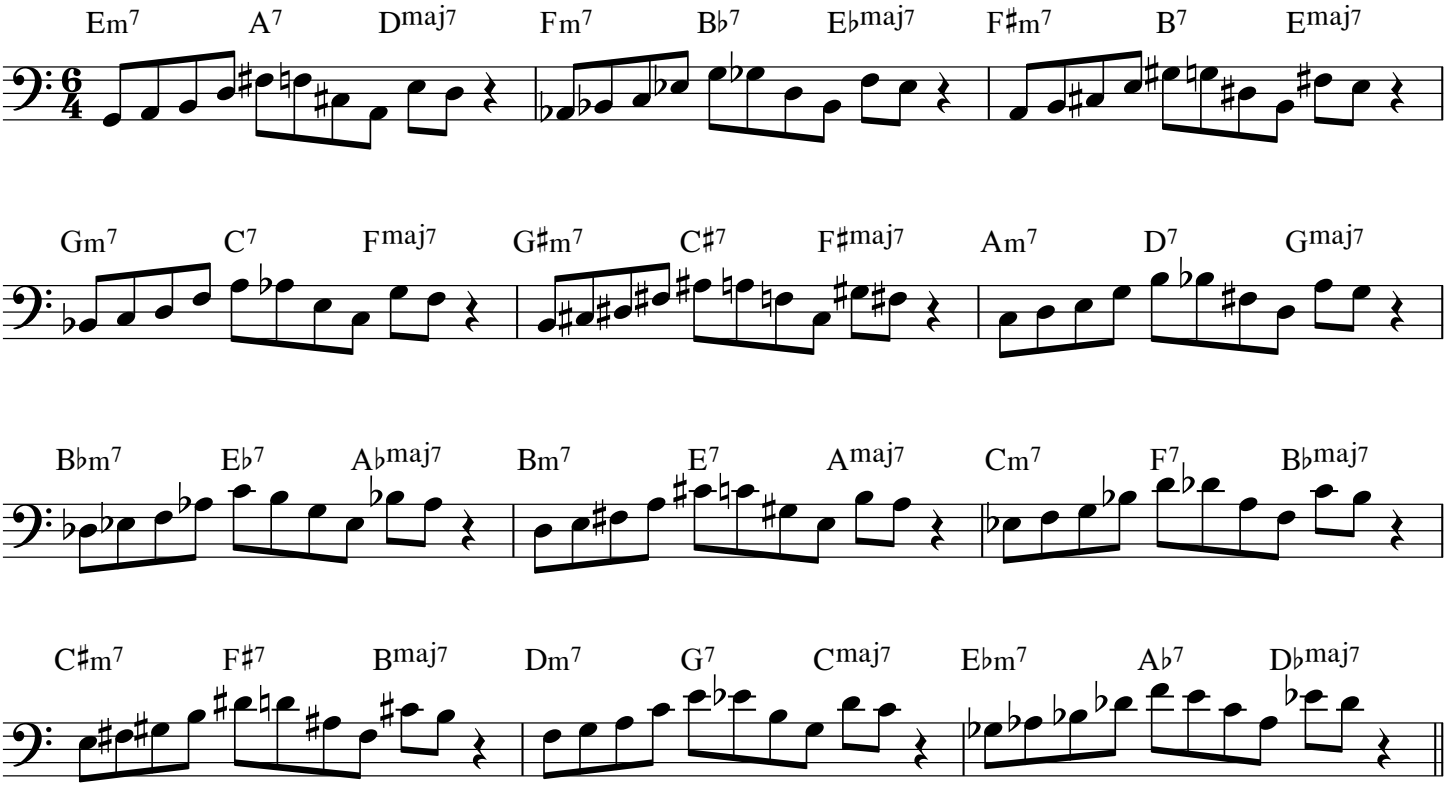
Here's some fun variations!



These don't resolve to the 9th, but still have the surprise augemented triad:

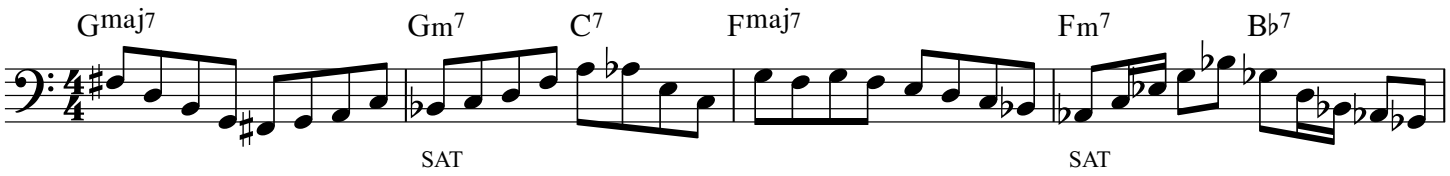


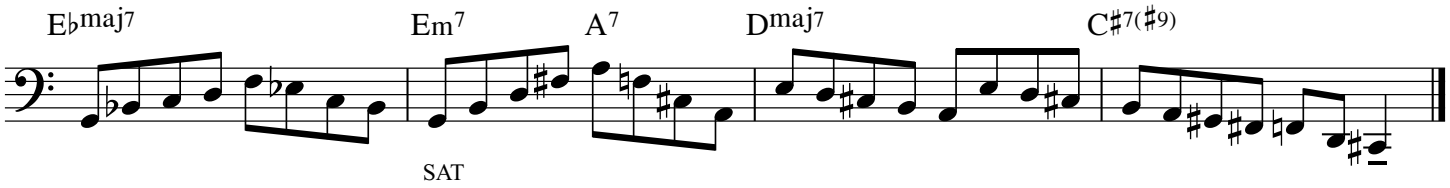
This is strong vocabulary to have internalized in 12 keys!

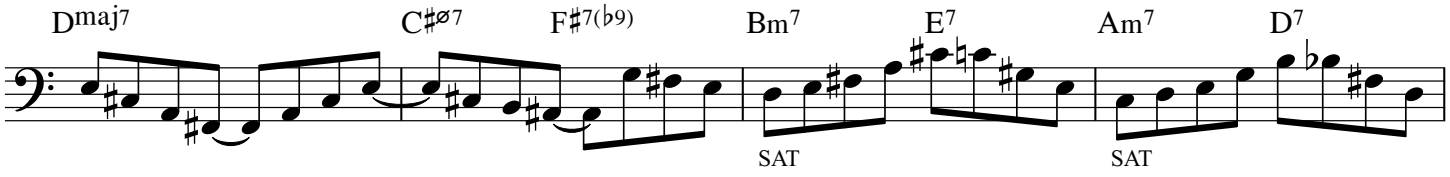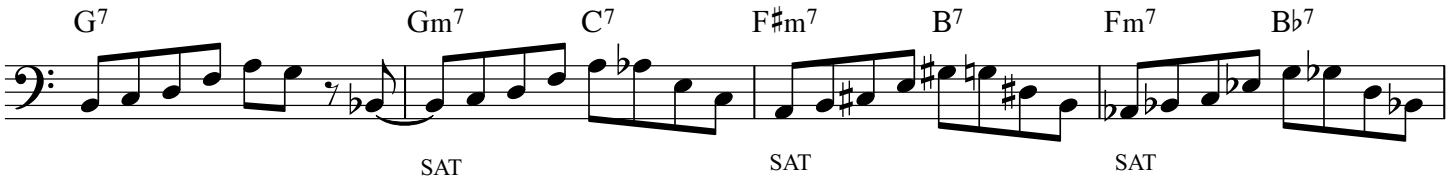


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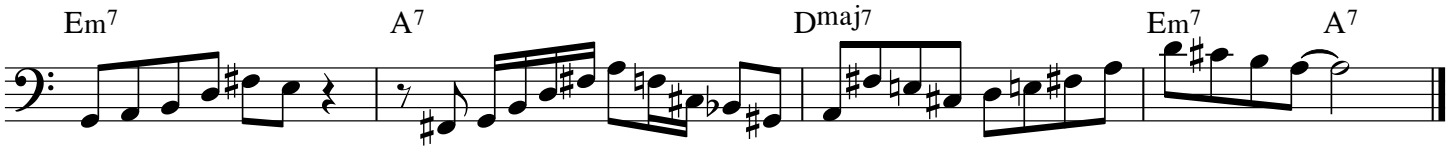
Here are several phrases of the SAT lick being played within common jazz chord progressions:
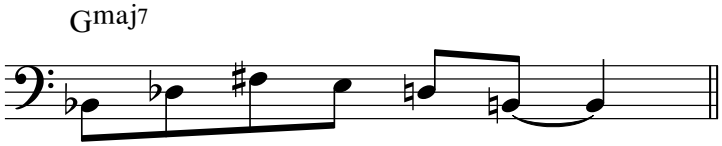










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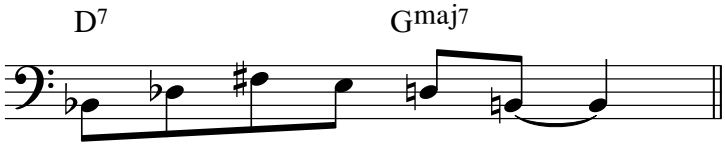
Lick 20

Common-Tone Diminished Cell (CTDC)
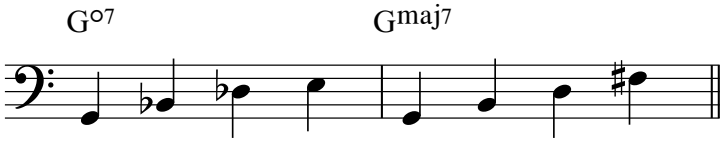
Here's a neat common-tone diminished cell that can enrich your major 7 chords. We'll call this the "Common-Tone Diminished Cell" (CTDC):



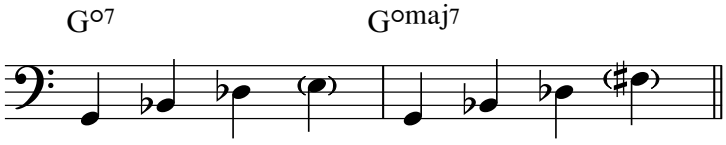
This cell also works in a V7 chord to melodically resolve to Imaj7:



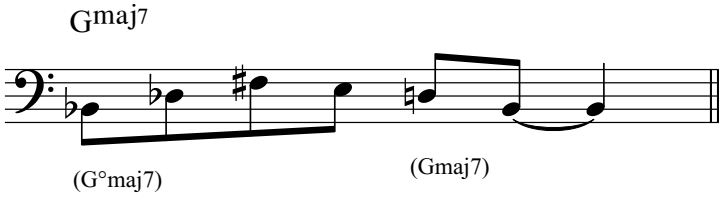
Why does this work? Well, diminished chords that share at least 1 note (AKA a "common tone") with the chord after it will always sound nice in a progression:
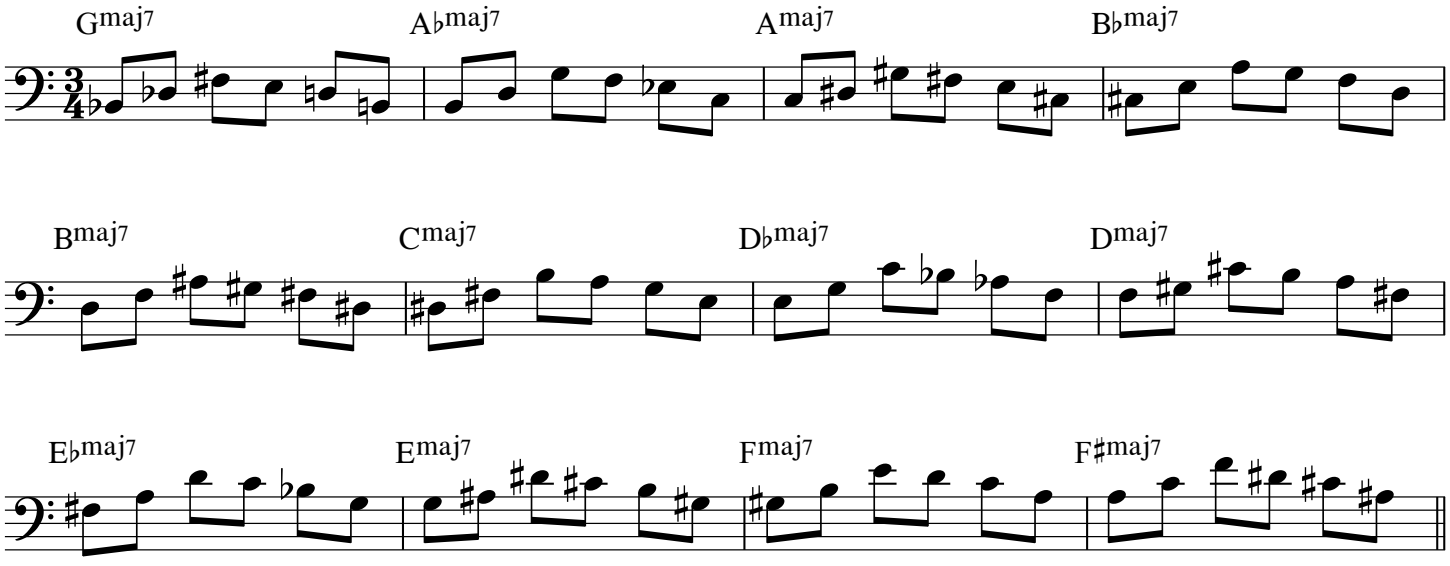


Also, the diminished 7th chord's bb7th can be traded for a major 7th for an effective color, as the major 7th is still diatonic to the G whole-half diminished scale:
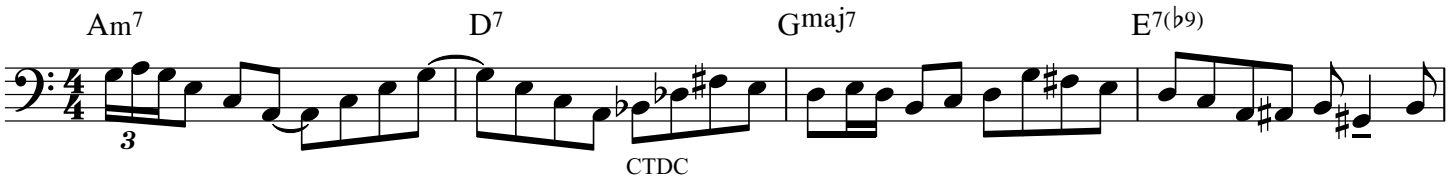


So essentially, we are implying the sound of a rootless I°maj7 chord through this cell!
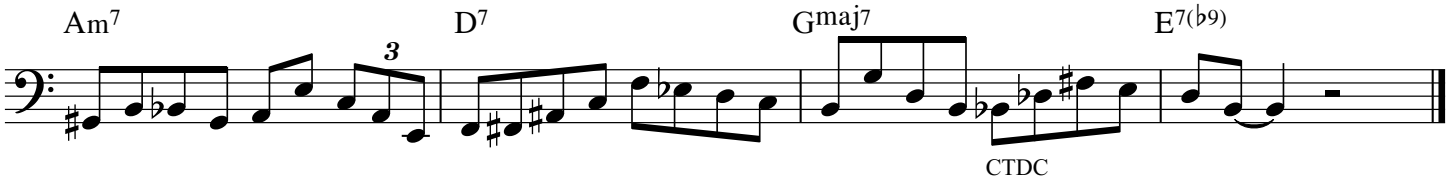


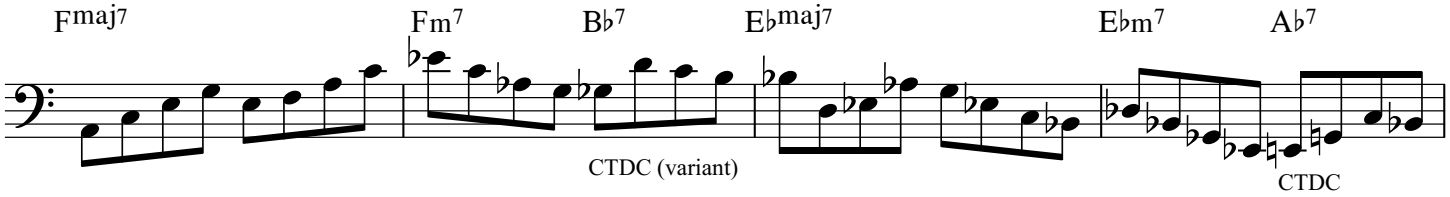


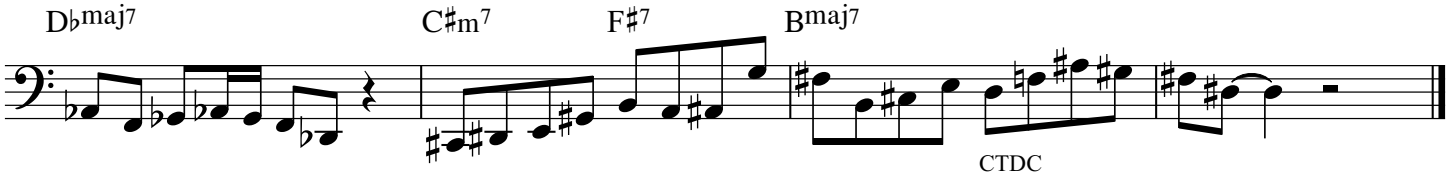
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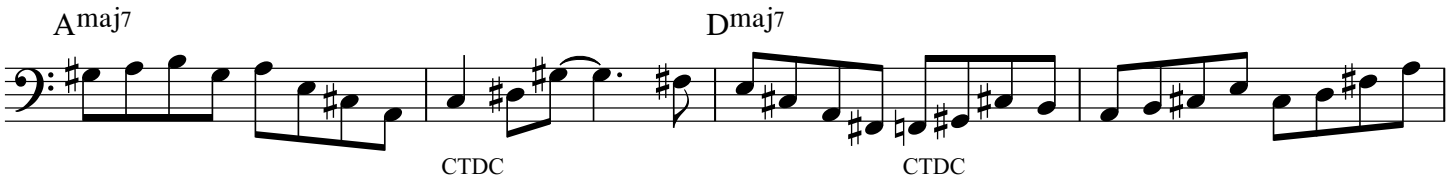
Here are several phrases of the CTDC being played within common jazz chord progressions:

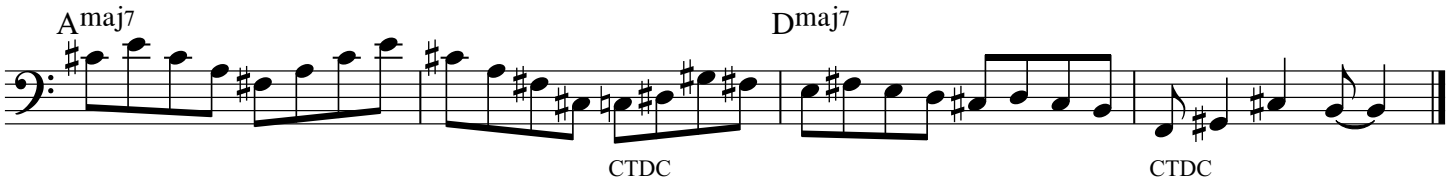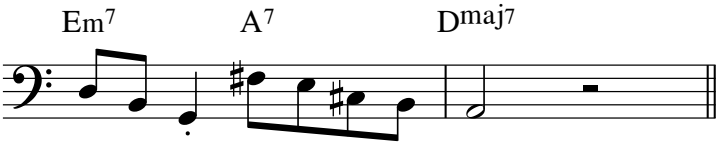












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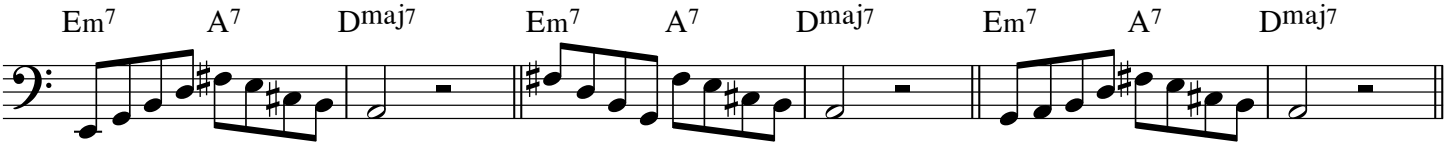
Lick 21

Triad to Pentatonic Resolution (TPR)

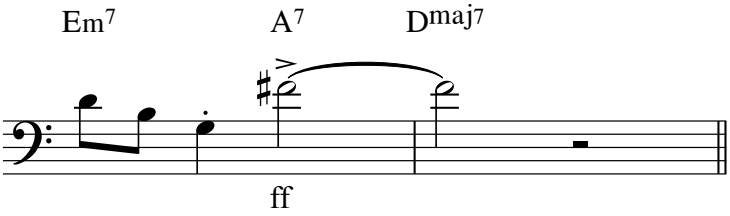
Here's a melodic resolution that's really effective. It's deceptively simple, containing just a major triad followed by a pentatonic run. So, let's label this the "Triad to Pentatonic Resolution" (TPR)
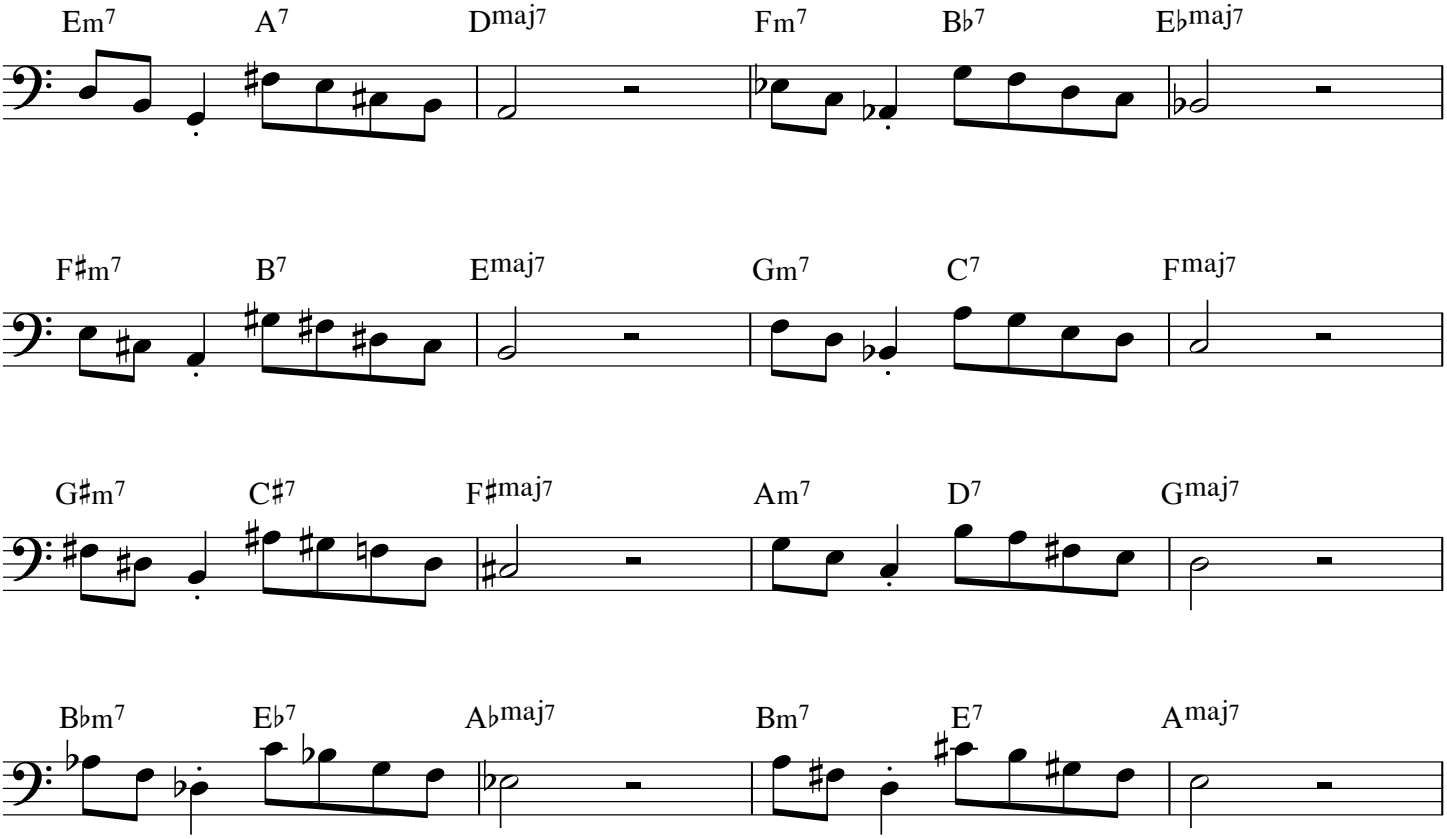


Here are some neat variants:



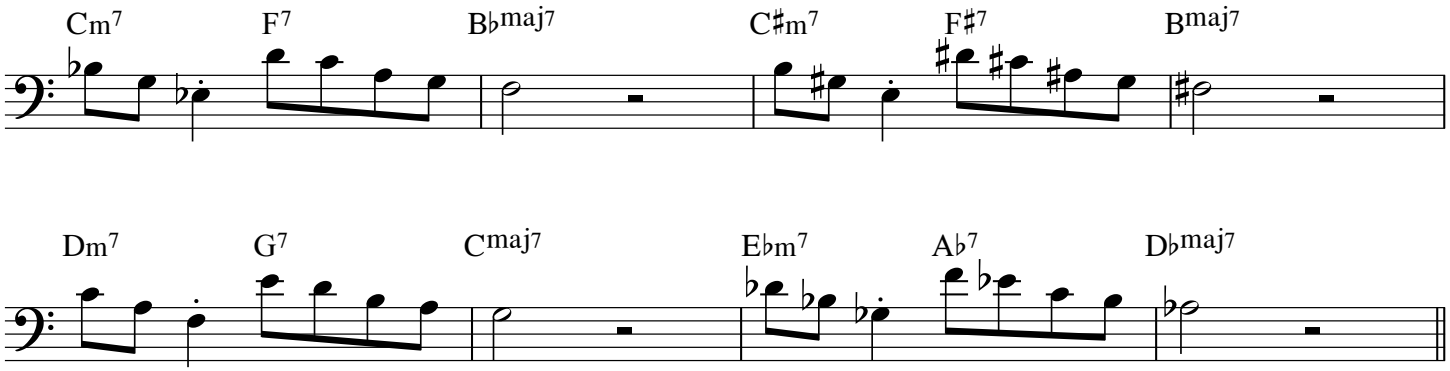
If you take it up an octave, change beat 3 into a sustained note and growl/split it, it can really make for a crowd-pleasing climax in a live solo!
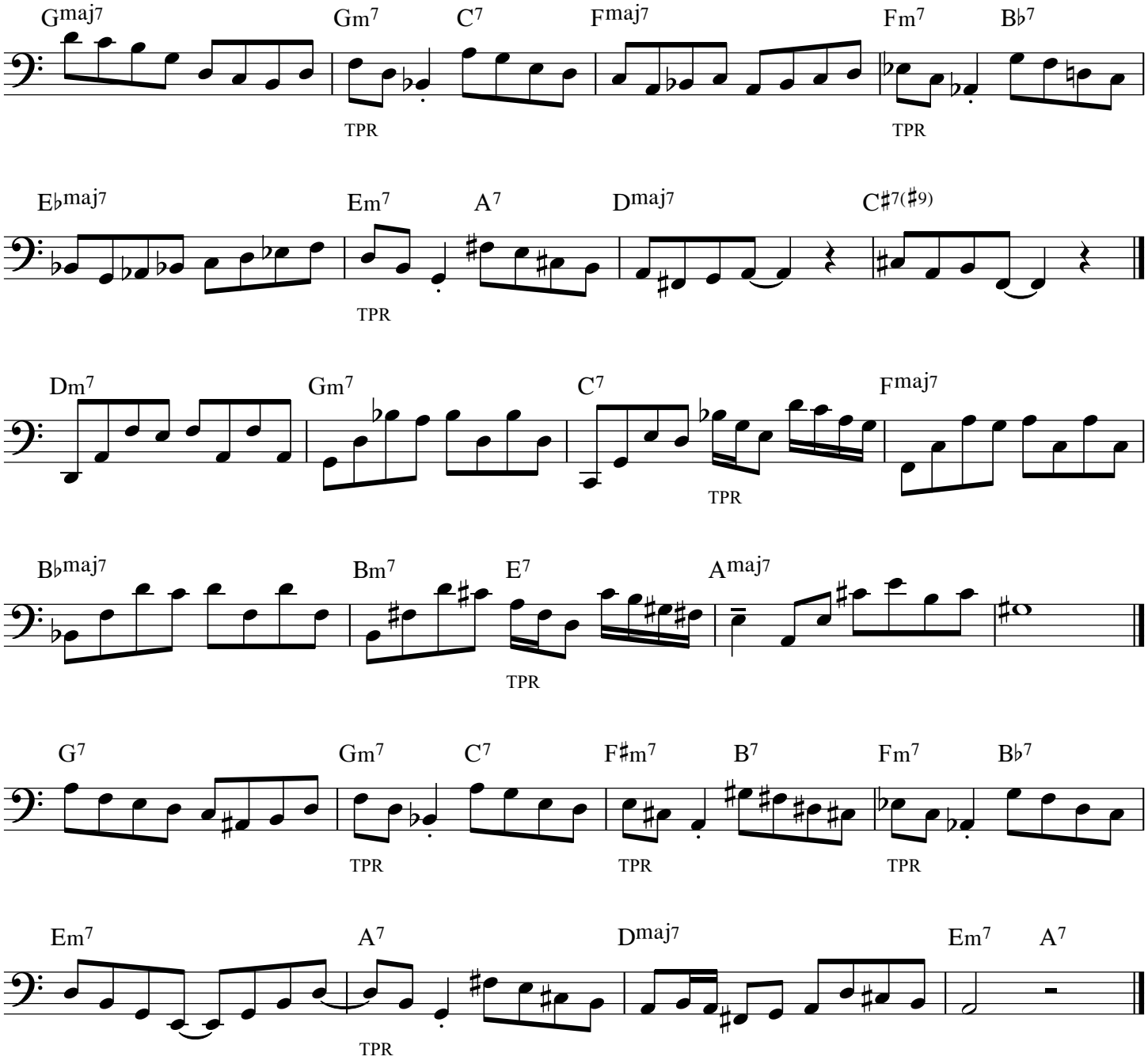


This is another great one to internalize in 12 keys:



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Here are several phrases of the TPR being played within common jazz chord progressions:

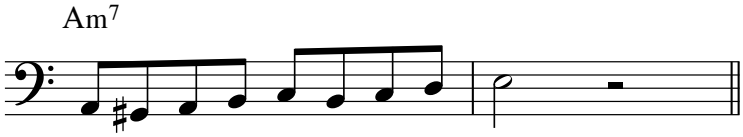


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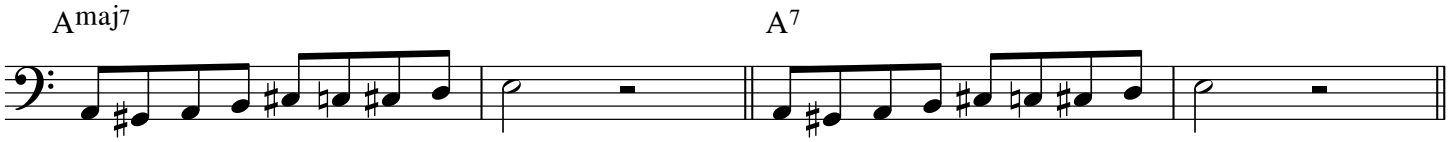
Lick 22
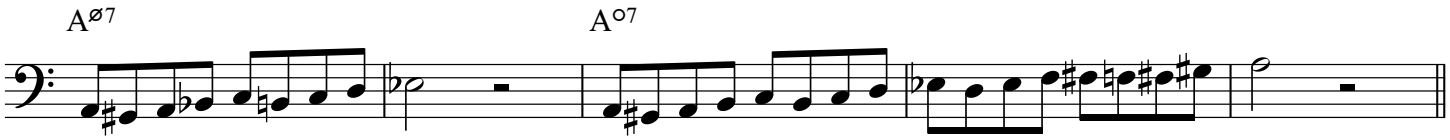
Neighbor-Tone Passage (NTP)

Here's a passage featuring chromatic neighbor tones. Let's label this one as the "Neighbor-Tone Passage" (NTP):
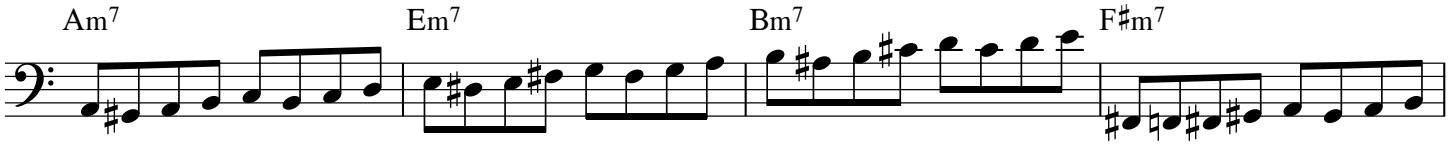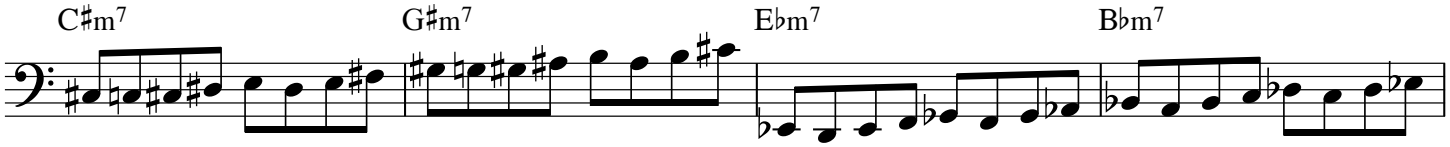


It works for any chord quality:
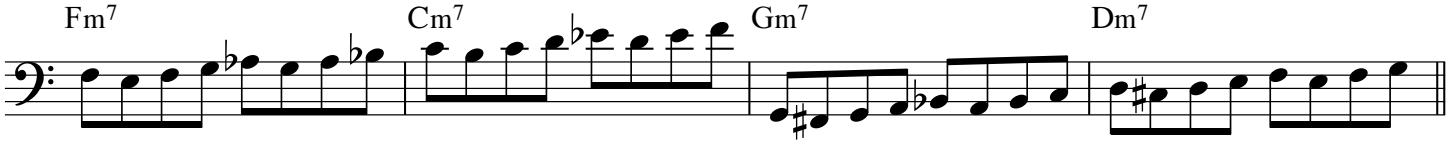




In my opinion, the minor version sounds the coolest. Pick one to start, and master it in 12 keys!

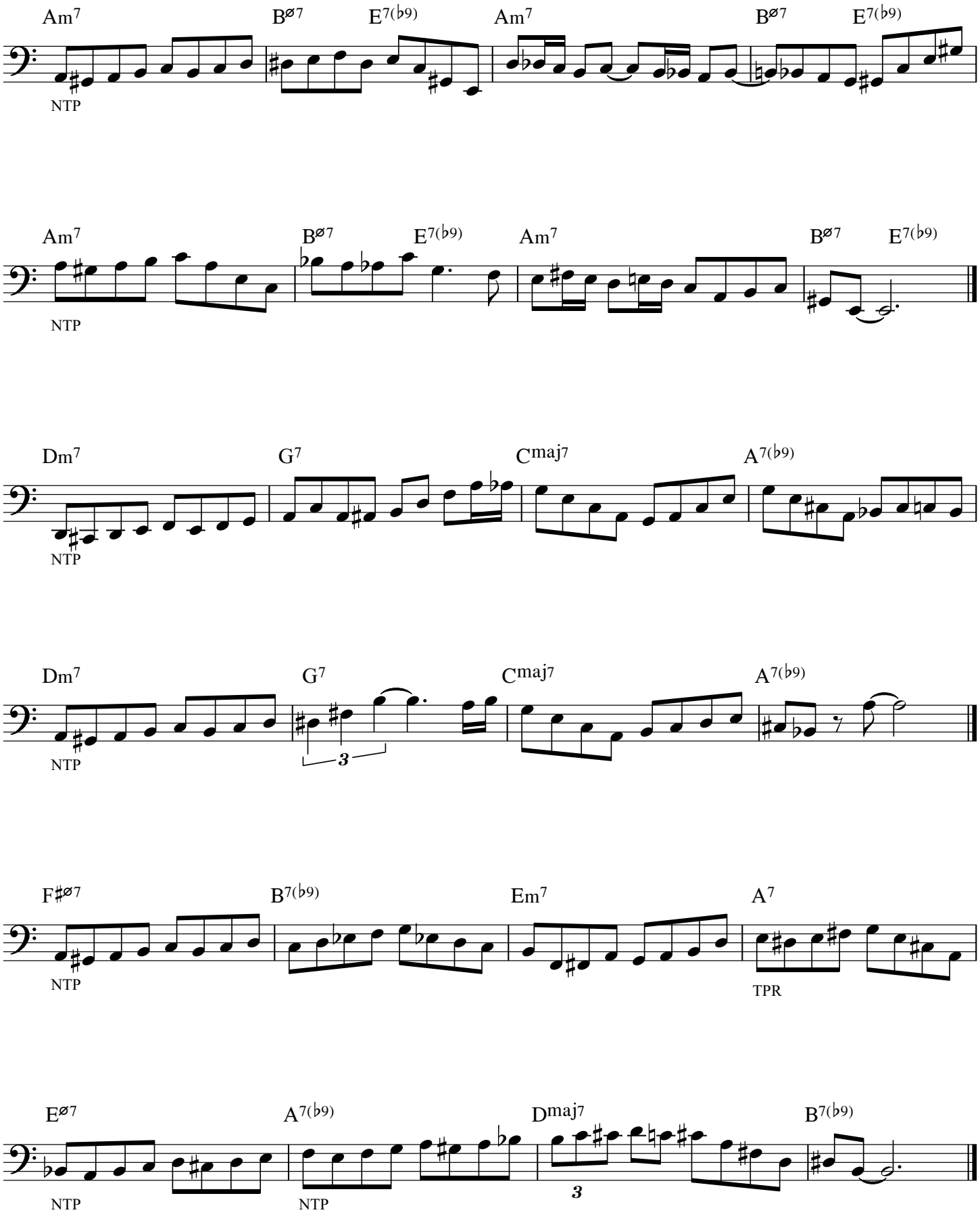






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Here are several phrases of the NTP being played within common jazz chord progressions:
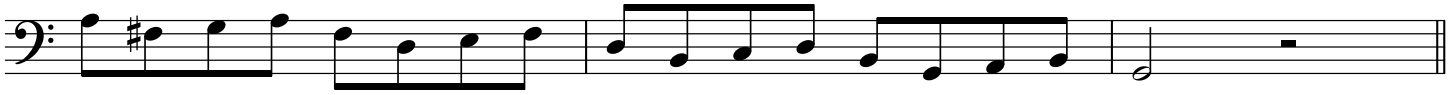


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Lick 23

Decorated Chord Tones (DCT)
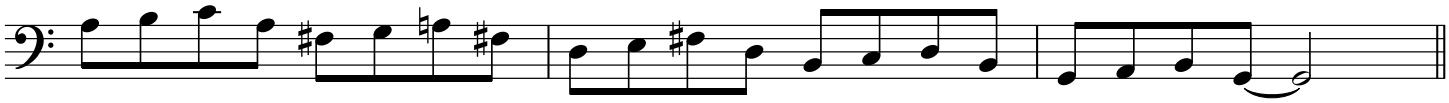
Here's a beautiful pattern that decorates all of the chord tones plus the 9th. Let's call this one the "Decorated Chord Tones" (DCT):

Gmaj7



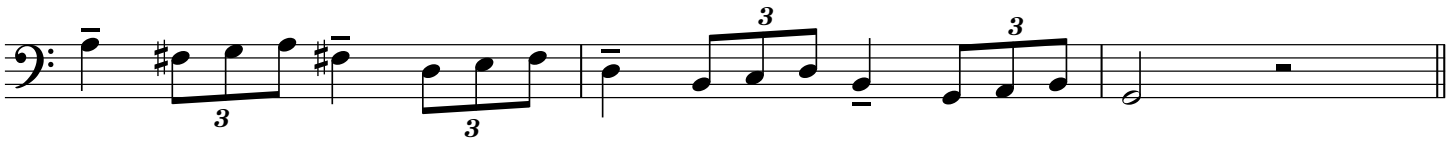
If you shift it all back an 8th-note, you're left with an equally beautiful variation:

Gmaj7
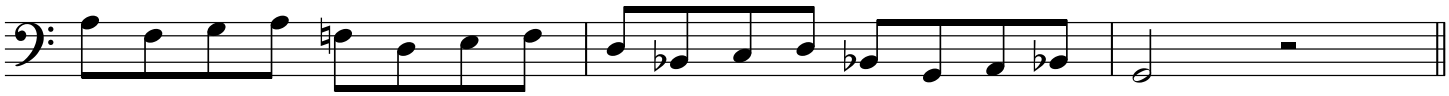


Here's a great rhythmic variation you may come across in a recording:

Gmaj7
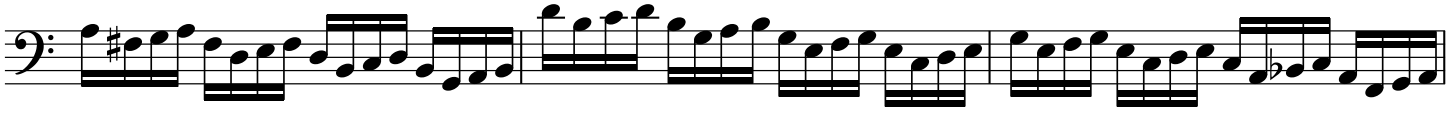


Of course, this works on all other chord qualities, as long as you keep it diatonic:

Gm7
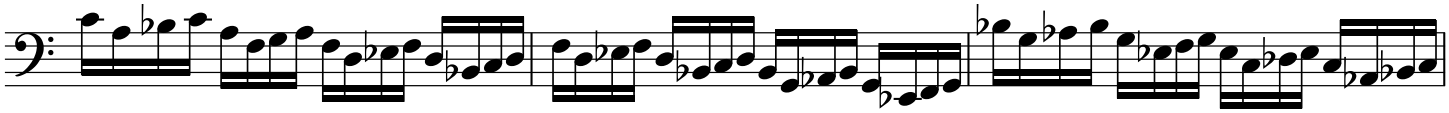


Memorizing this in 12 keys will be worth your time!
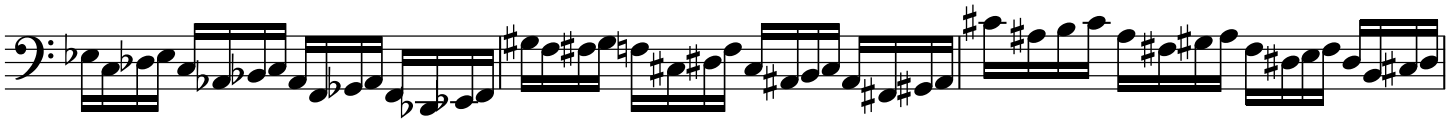
Gmaj7 Cmaj7 Fmaj7
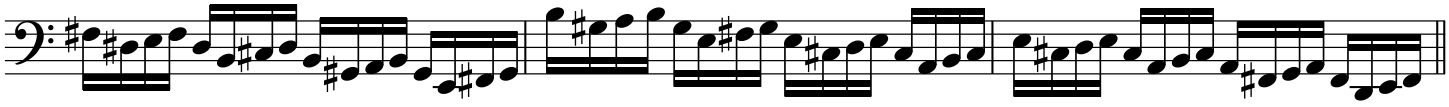


B♭maj7 E♭maj7 A♭maj7



D♭maj7 F♯maj7 Bmaj7

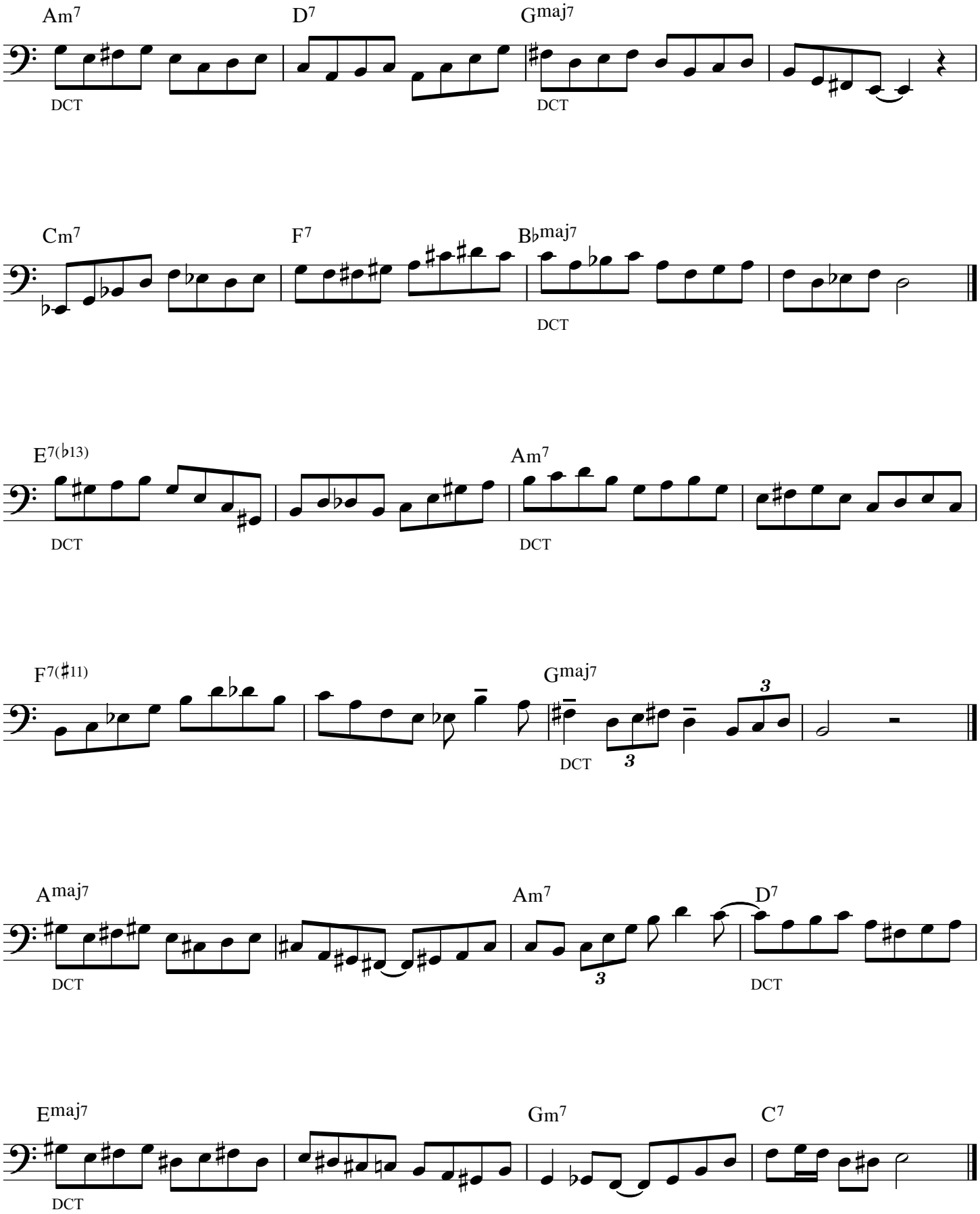


Emaj7 Amaj7 Dmaj7



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Here are several phrases of the DCT being played within common jazz chord progressions:
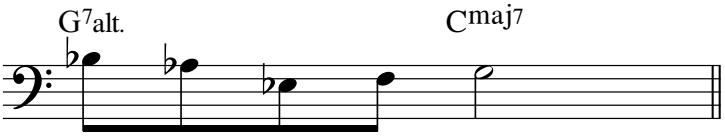


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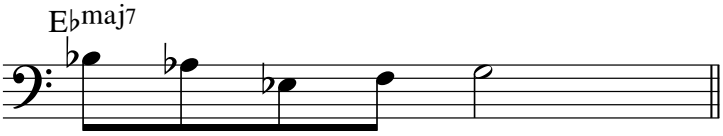
Lick 24

Altered Enclosure (AE)
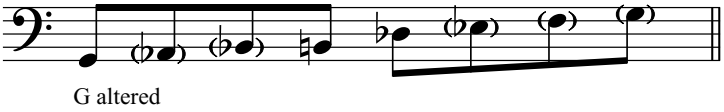
Here's a classic altered resolution featuring a 4-note diatonic enclosure targeting the 5th of the Imaj7 chord.
Let's call this one the "Altered Enclosure" (AE):



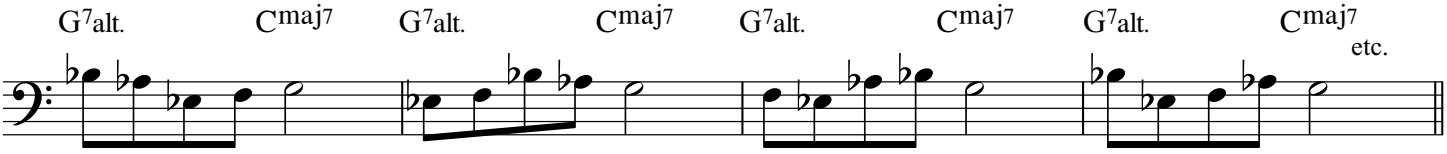
The cell itself is a 54123, which by itself sounds quite ordinary:



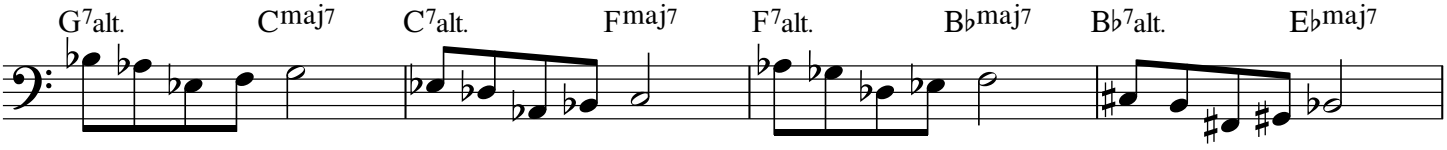
But, this cell can be found in other spots of other scales, like the G altered scale:

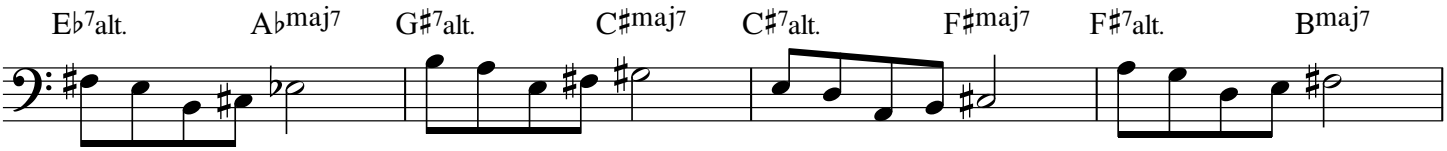


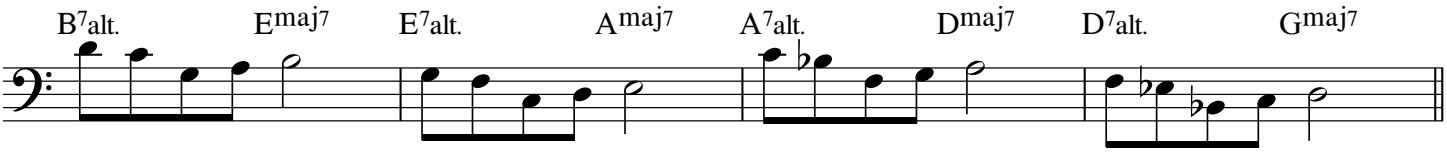
In this context, it makes for a powerful resolution! Consider trying various permutations:



If you internalize it in 12 keys, it will be easier to access it during your improvisation:

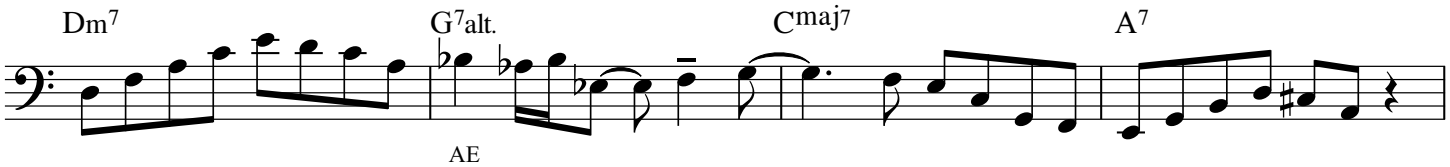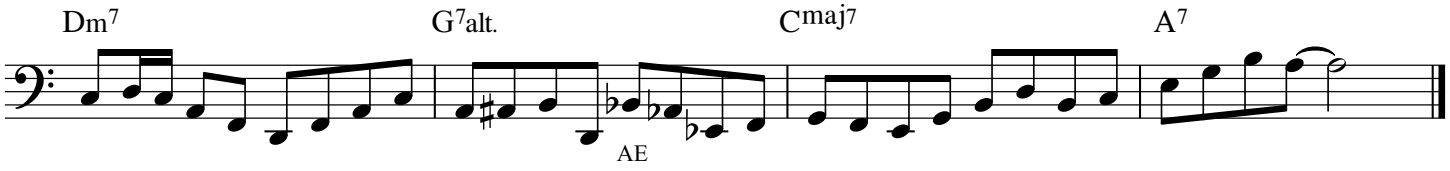




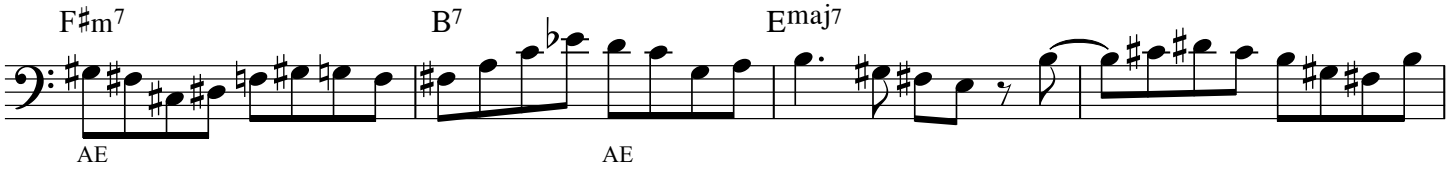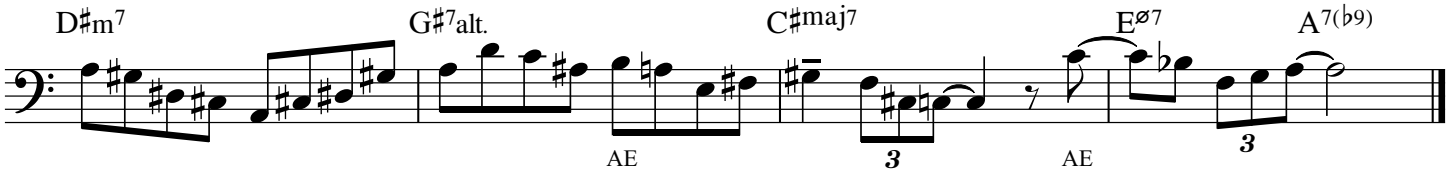


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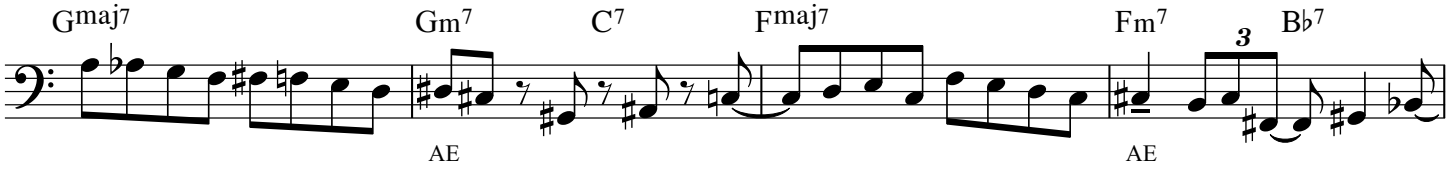
48 Here are several phrases of the AE being played within common jazz chord progressions:

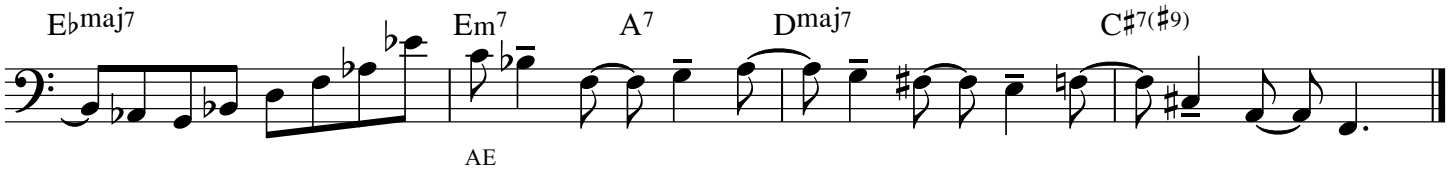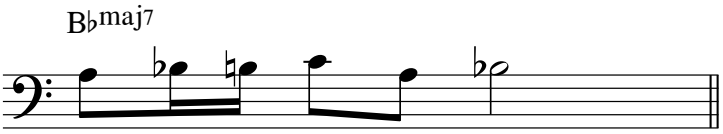












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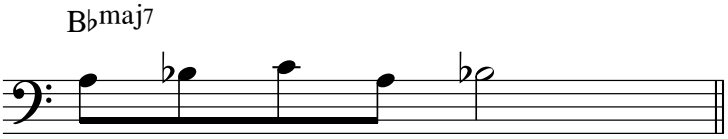
Lick 25

Fun Enclosure (FE)
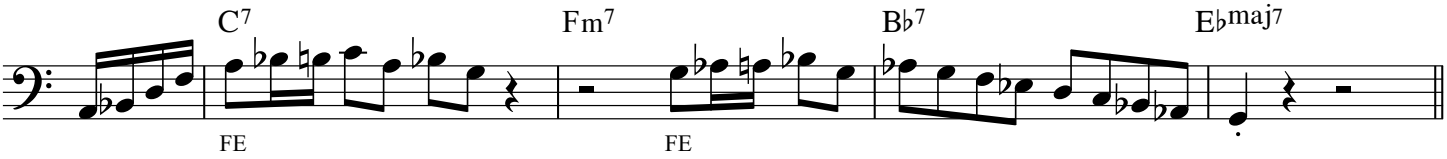
Here's a figure you'll come across often in jazz recordings, usually at fast bebop tempos. It's a fun variation on an enclosure, so let's just label it as the "Fun Enclosure" (FE):
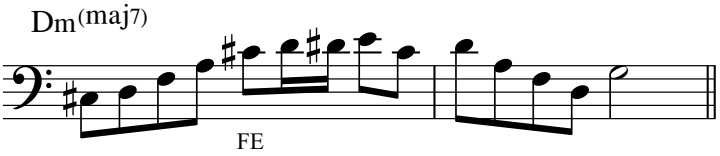


Essentially, it's an embellishment of encircling a target note (usually the root of a chord) like this:
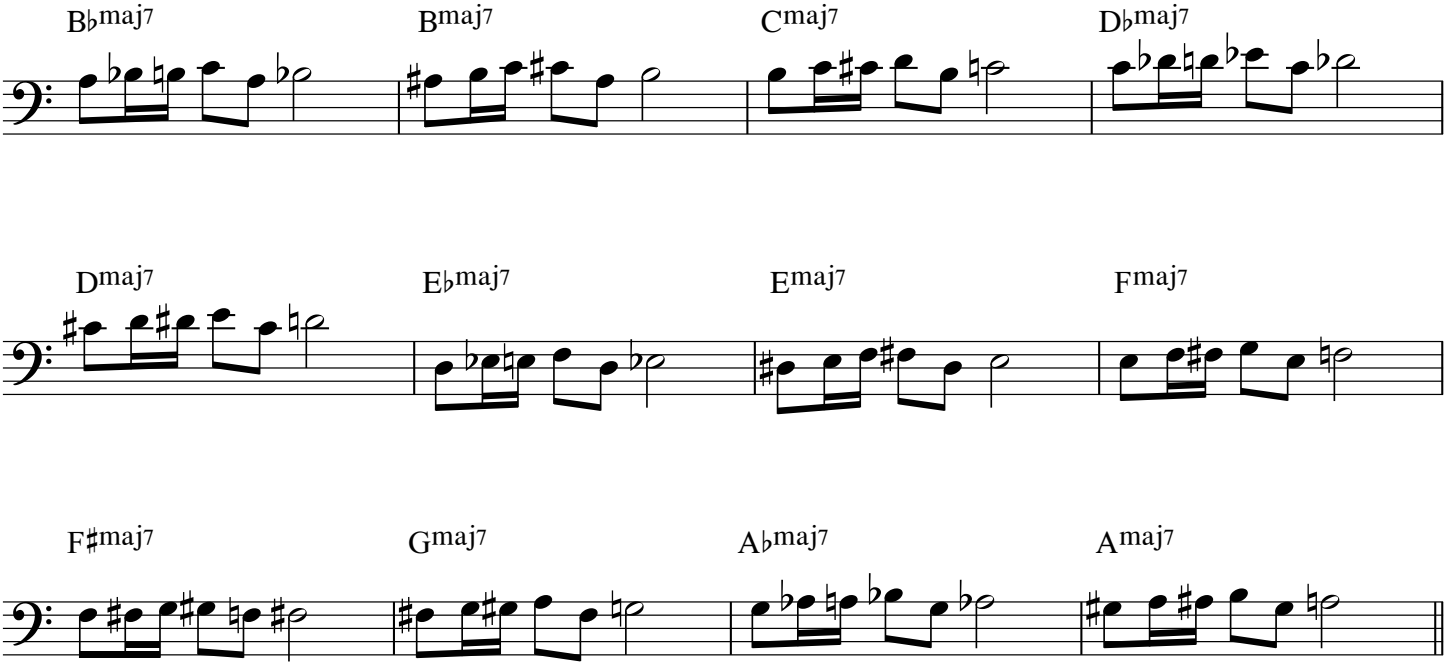


It's very versatile as its able to be used in many situations. Here's a line from Cannonball where he uses it twice:



It sounds great on minor chords as well:
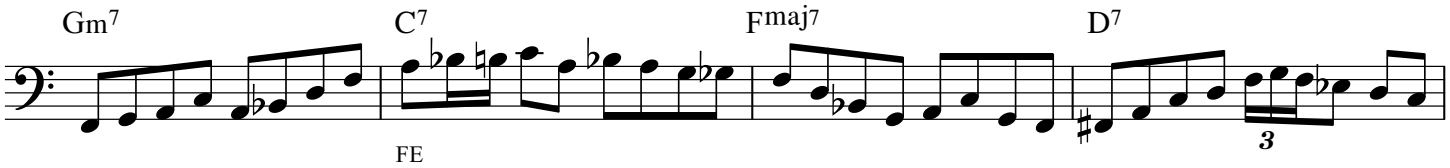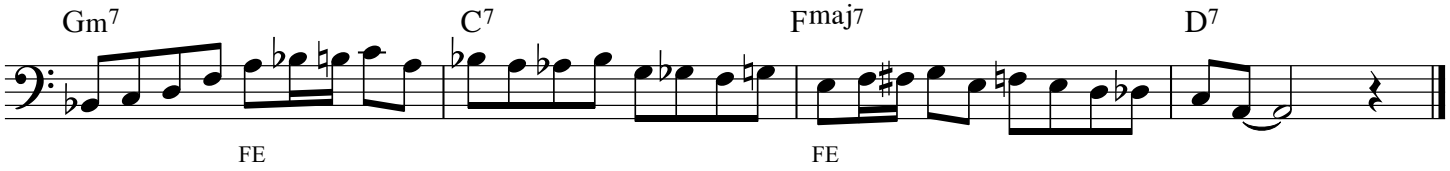


Memorizing it in 12 keys will help you notice it every time you hear it in other people's solos:
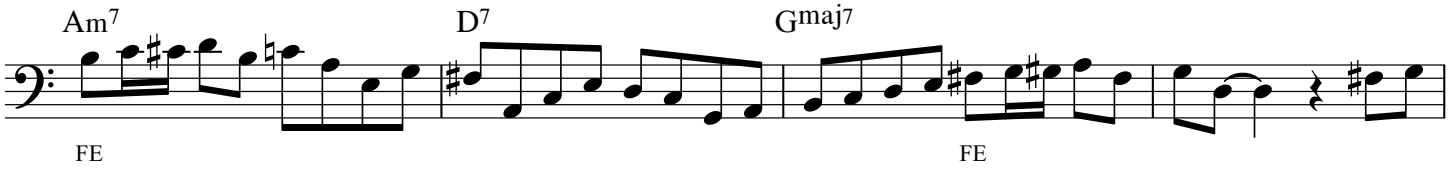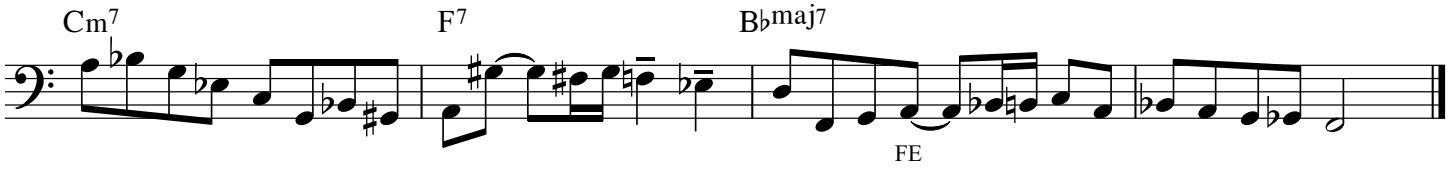


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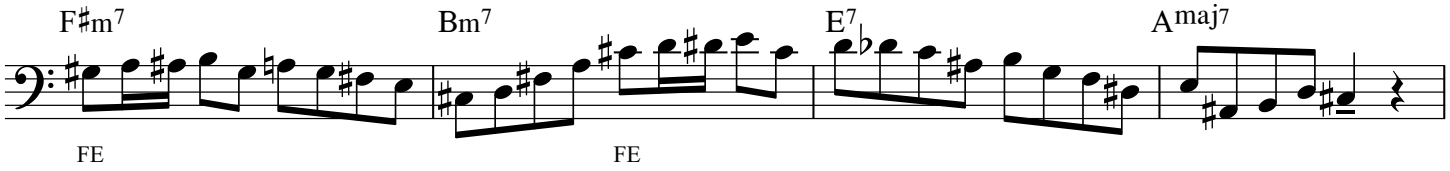
Here are several phrases of the FE being played within common jazz chord progressions:
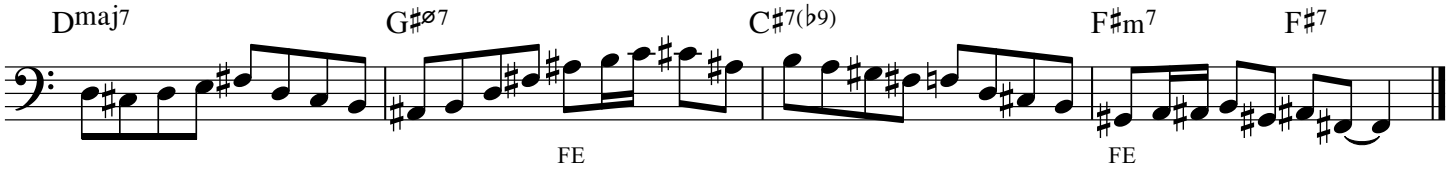










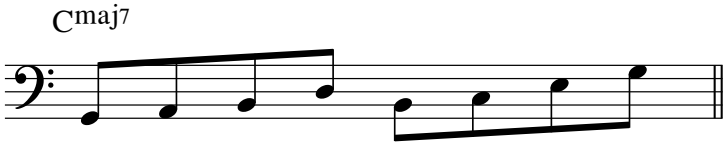


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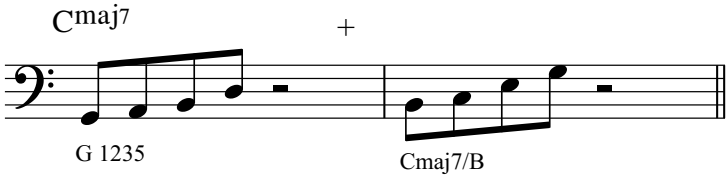
Lick 26

Bread and Butter (BB)

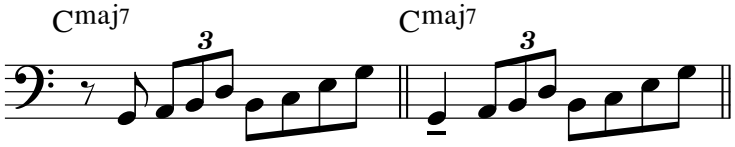
Here's a passage that's become very common lately in jazz. It's such a reliable way to fill up a measure, that I'll call this the "Bread and Butter" (BB):



This is a combination of two cells we mentioned earlier: 1235 Cell + Third Inversion Seventh Chord. But since it's so commonly put next to each other, deserves its own spotlight as a unit!

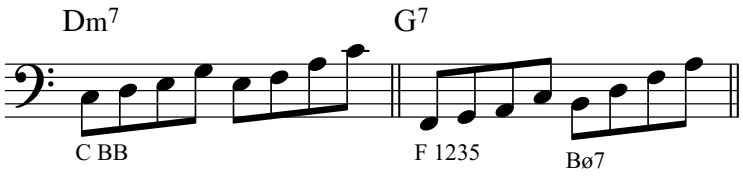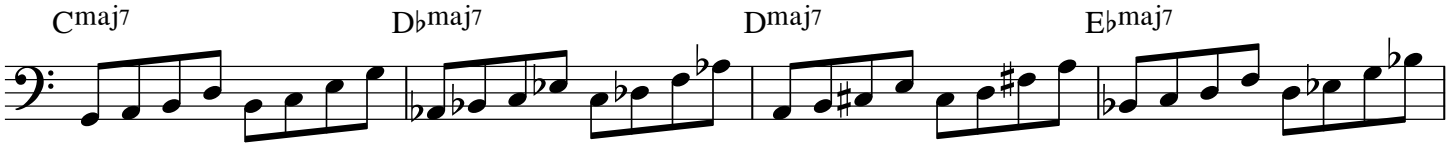


Here are the most common rhythmic variations:
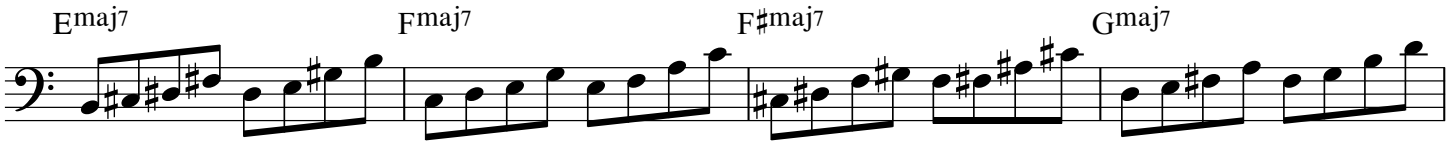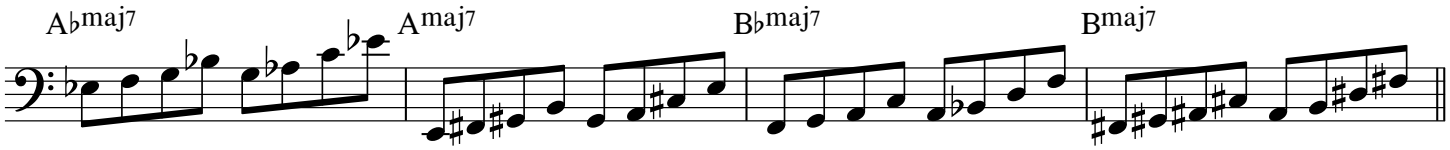


It works nicely over minor 7 chords as well, starting the BB from the b7:

All the spots for the BB in a dominant 7 chord are a little awkward, but if you change the second cell to a ø7 cell, then it works nicely!
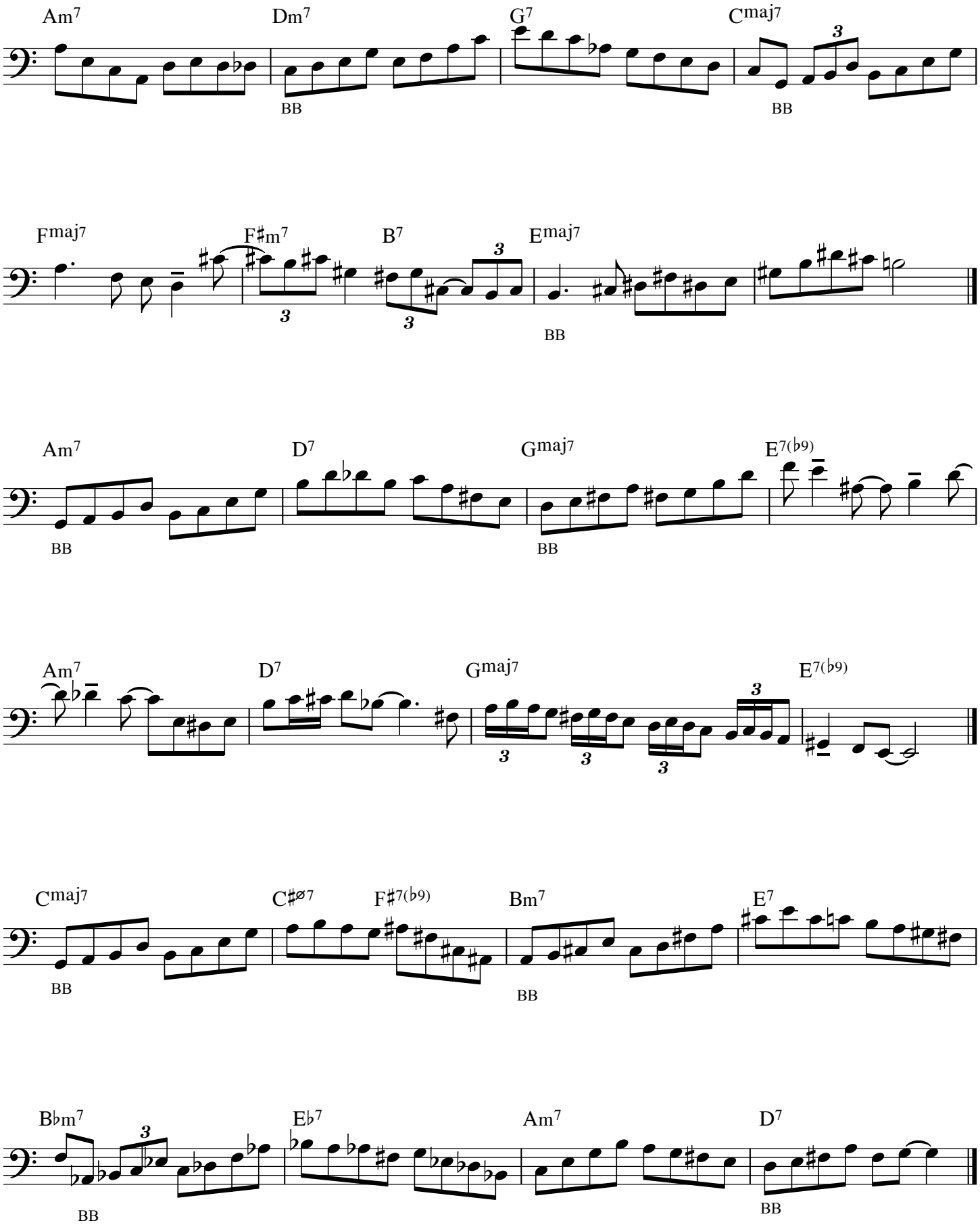








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Here are several phrases of the BB being played within common jazz chord progressions:

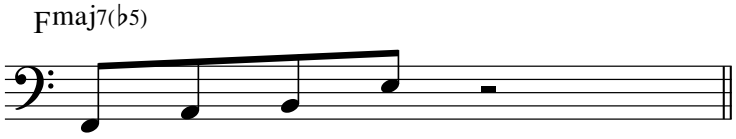


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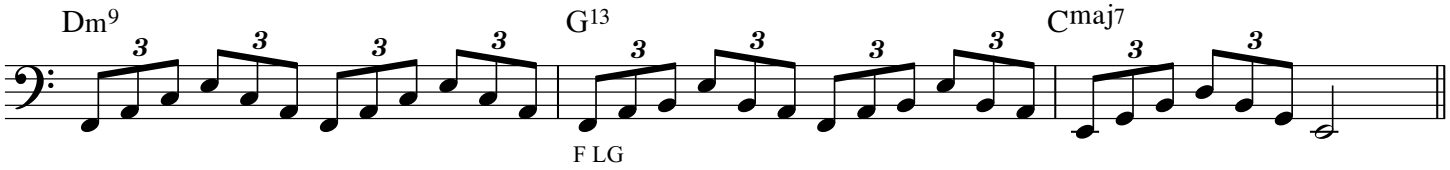
Lick 27

Lydian Grip (LG)

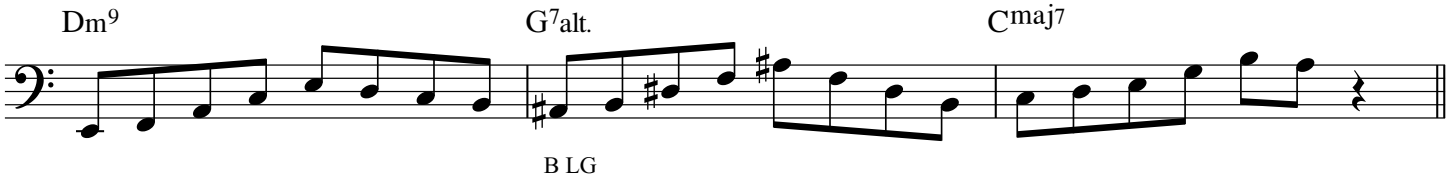
Here's a signature jazz sound. On its own, it's simple. But, its various application grants you powerfully enriched harmonic playing within your melodies. This one is called the "Lydian Grip" (LG):
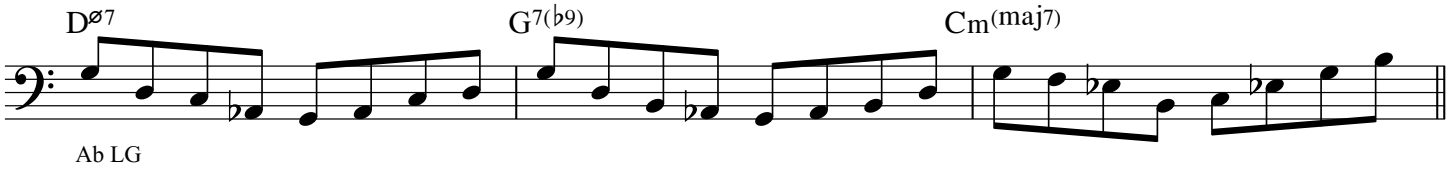


If you play the Lydian Grip from the 13th of a dominant chord, you'll get a richer mixoloydian sound:
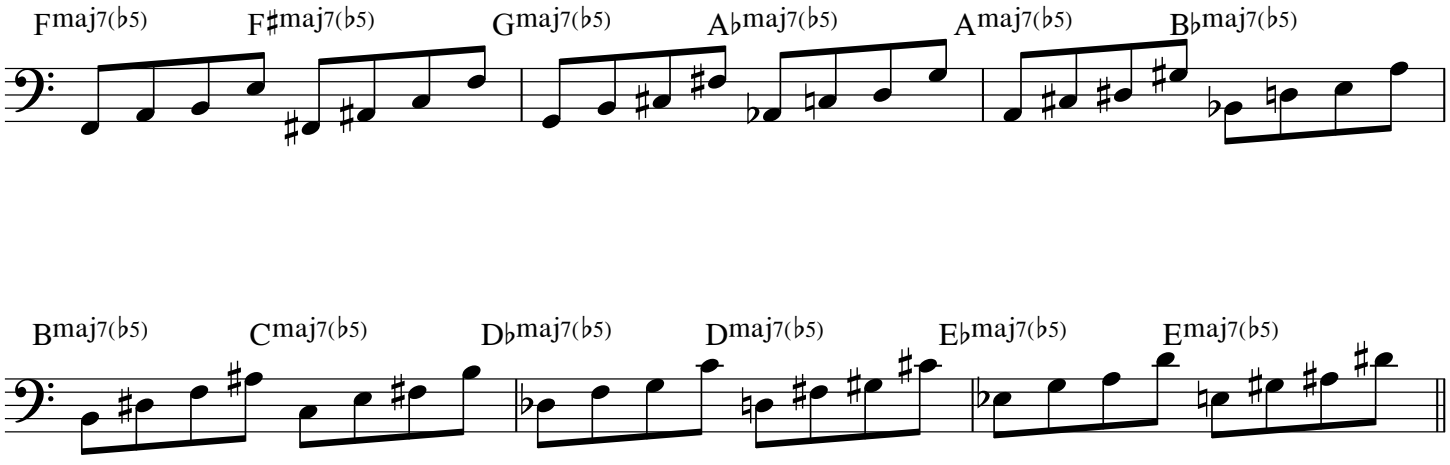


If you play the Lydian Grip from the 3rd of a dominant chord, you'll get an effective altered sound:



If you play the Lydian Grip from the b5th of a dominant chord, you'll get a richer locrian sound:

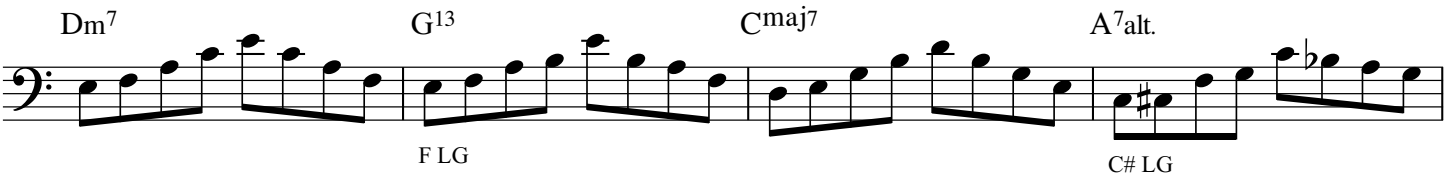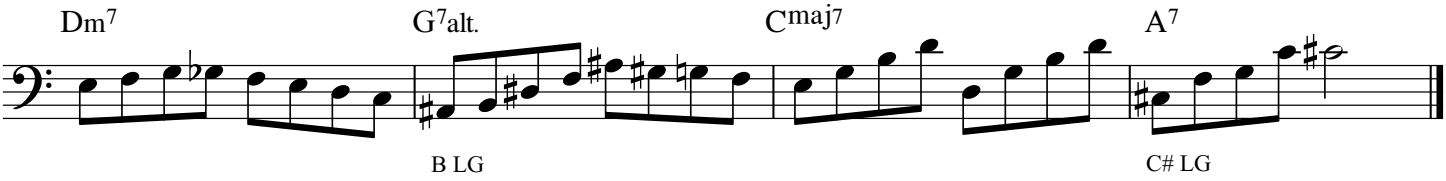


Treat the LG like a melodic cell and practice it through all 12 keys:

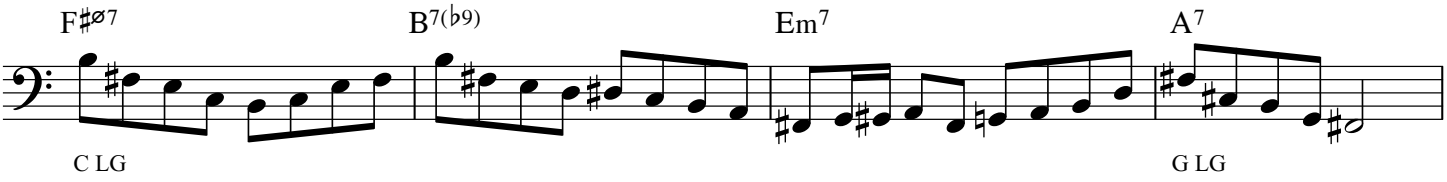


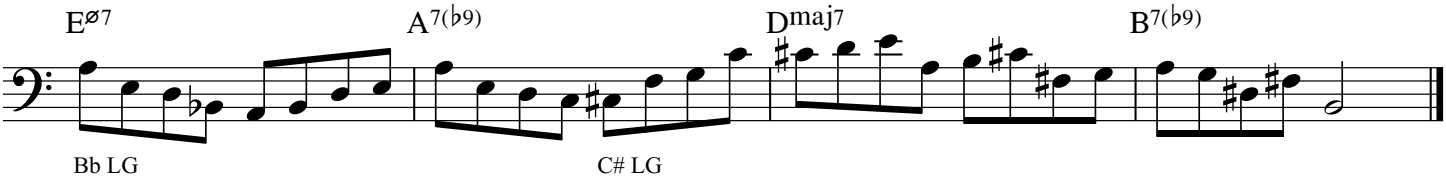
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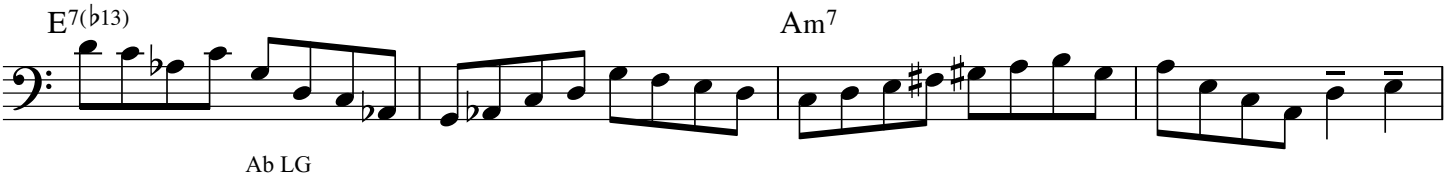
Here are several phrases of the LG being played within common jazz chord progressions:

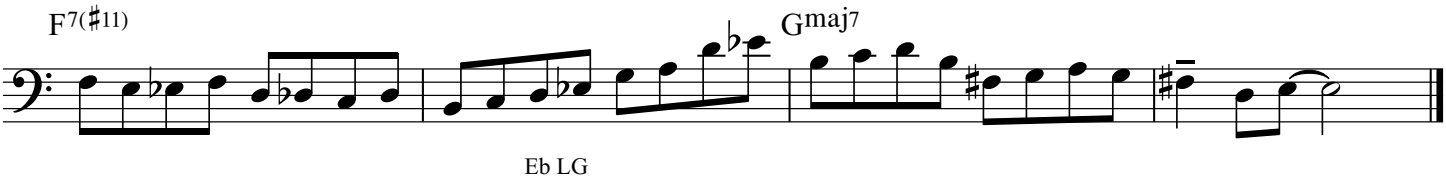










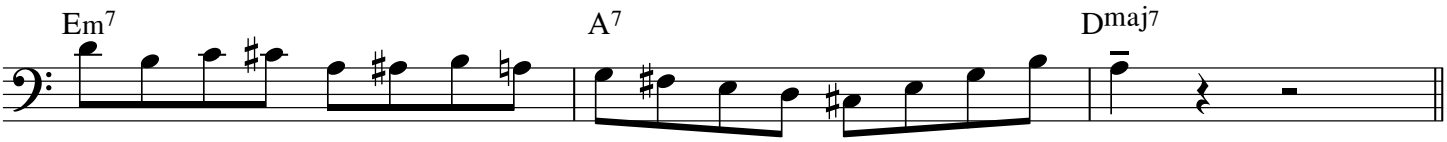


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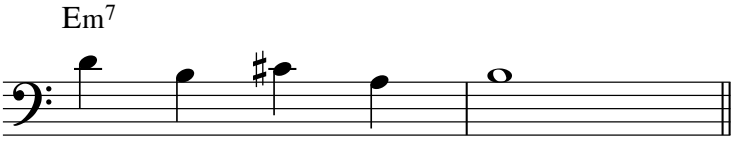
Lick 28

Bird's Chromatic Frenzy (BCF)

Here's a neat phrase that Charlie Parker invented. It's full of sycopated chromatic passing tones and enclosures, so let's just label this one as "Bird's Chromatic Frenzy" (BCF):

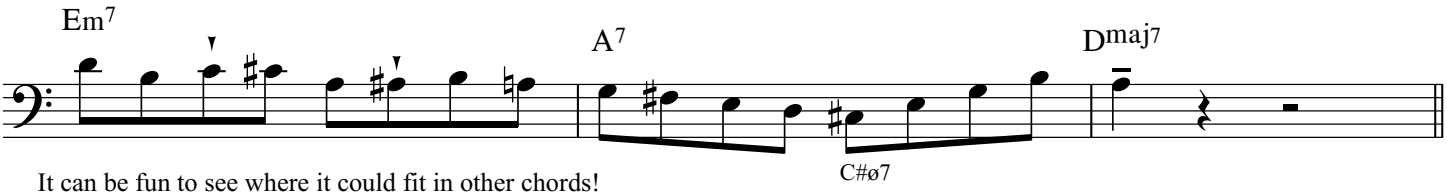


In the first half, we start on the b7 of our minor chord and play these descending diatonic 3rds:

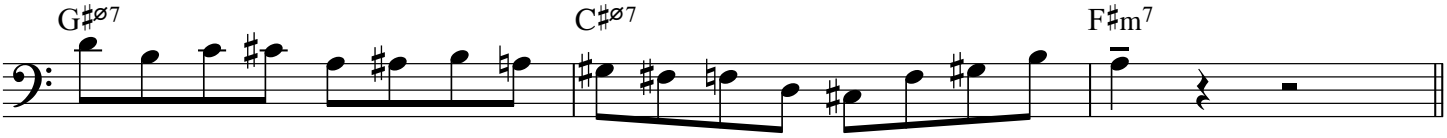


Then, we travel to each upper note by inserting chromatic passing tones:
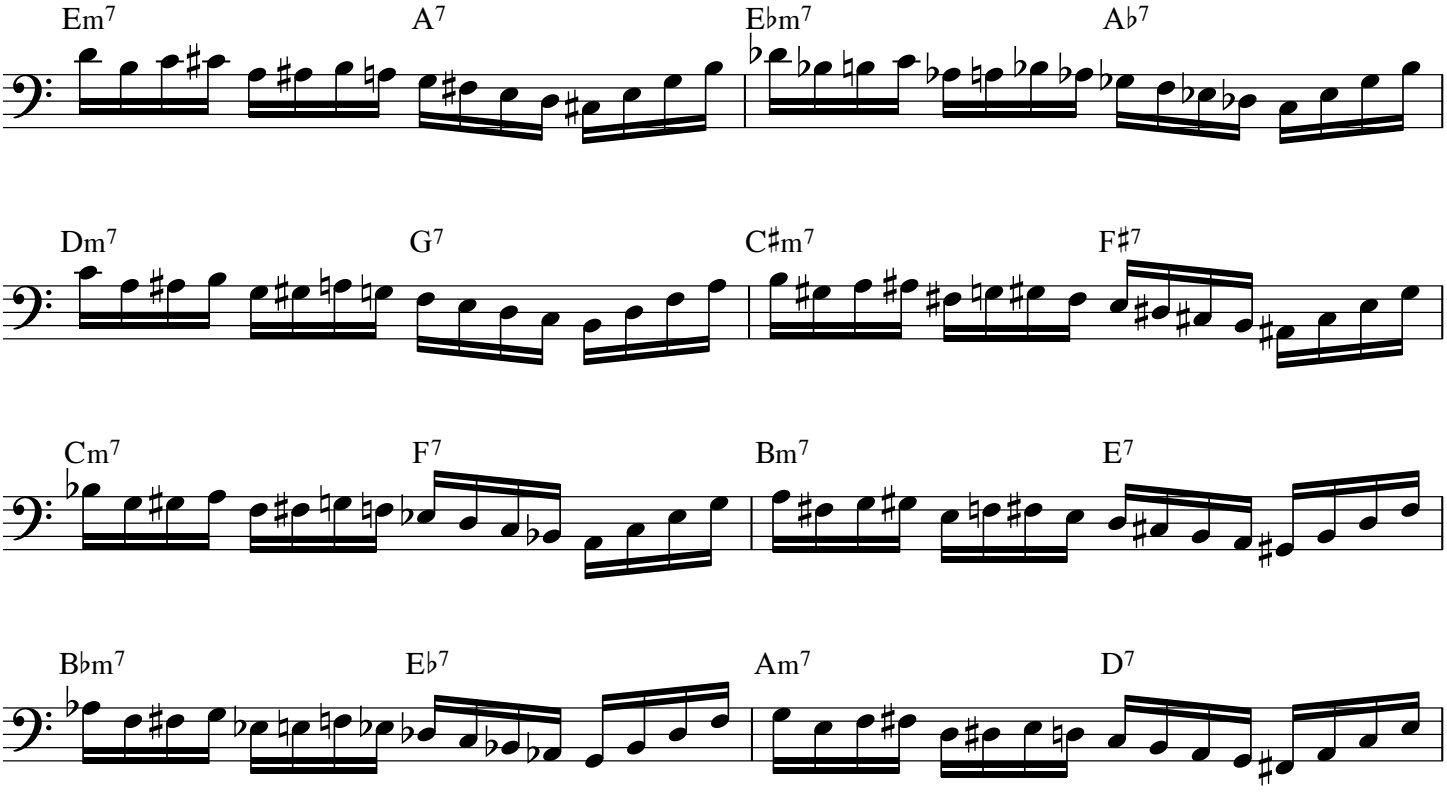
Then, we diatonically approach the b7 of the dominant chord, walk down to the third, scend with a ø7 cell, and land down onto the 5th of the Imaj7:
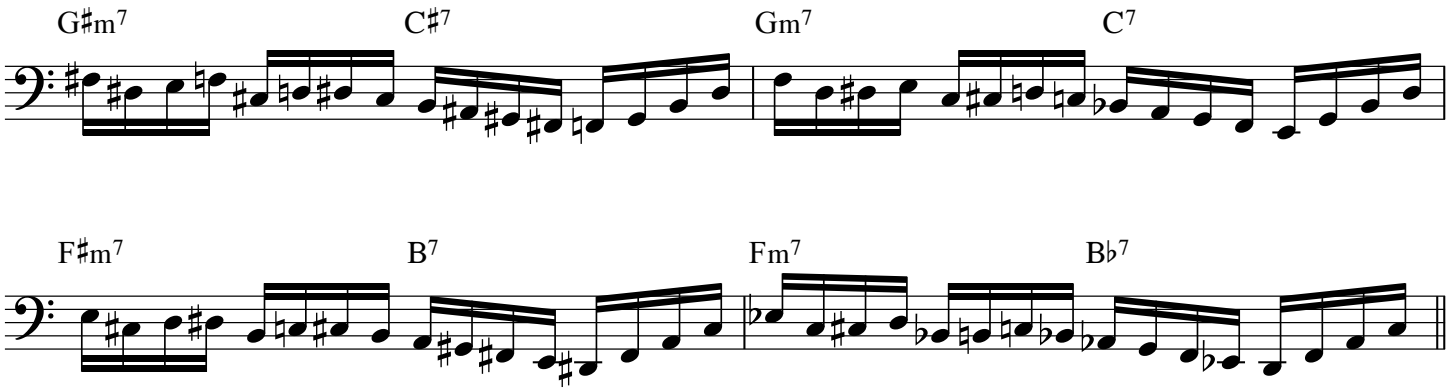


It can be fun to see where it could fit in other chords!
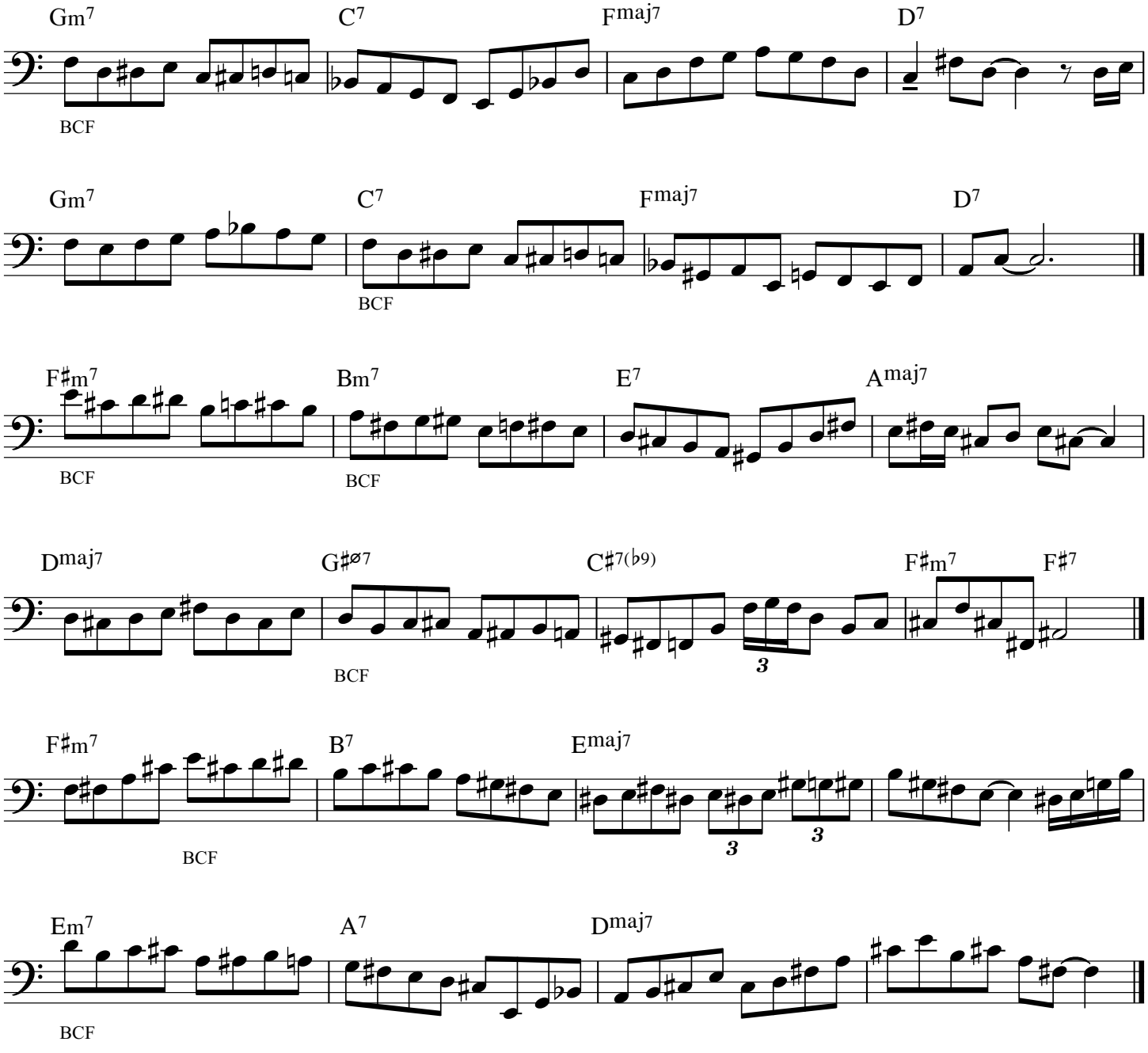


Working this out in your mind in 12 keys would provide the most fruitful benefts, but here is a written reference:



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Here are several phrases of BCF being played within common jazz chord progressions:
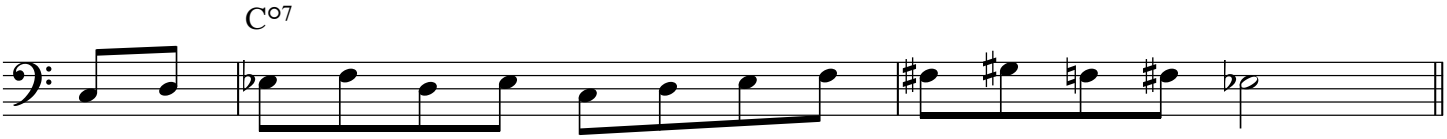


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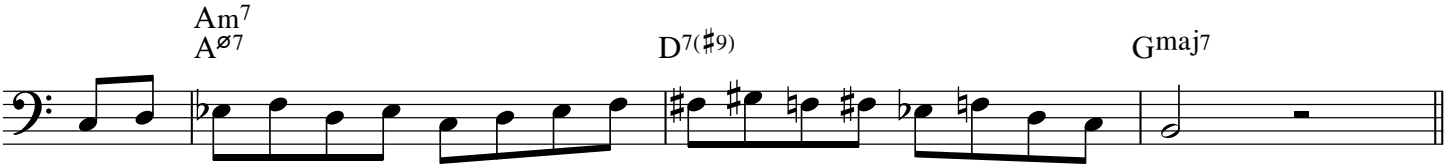
Lick 29

Diminished Stairsteps (DSS):
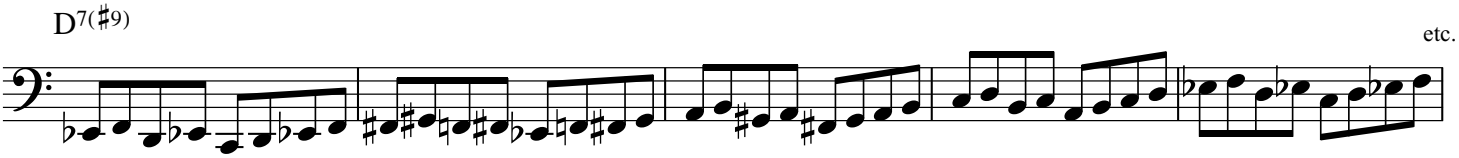
Here's a diminished passage that dates back many decades. Using the diminished scale, the pitches stairstep up and down a suspenseful way, so let's label this as the "Diminished Stairsteps" (DSS):
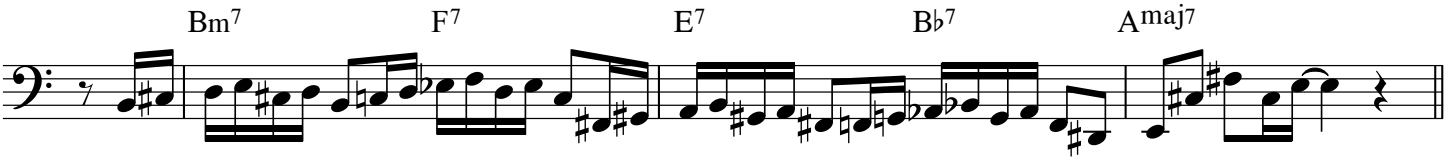


This is most often heard as either a minor or major ii-V phrase:
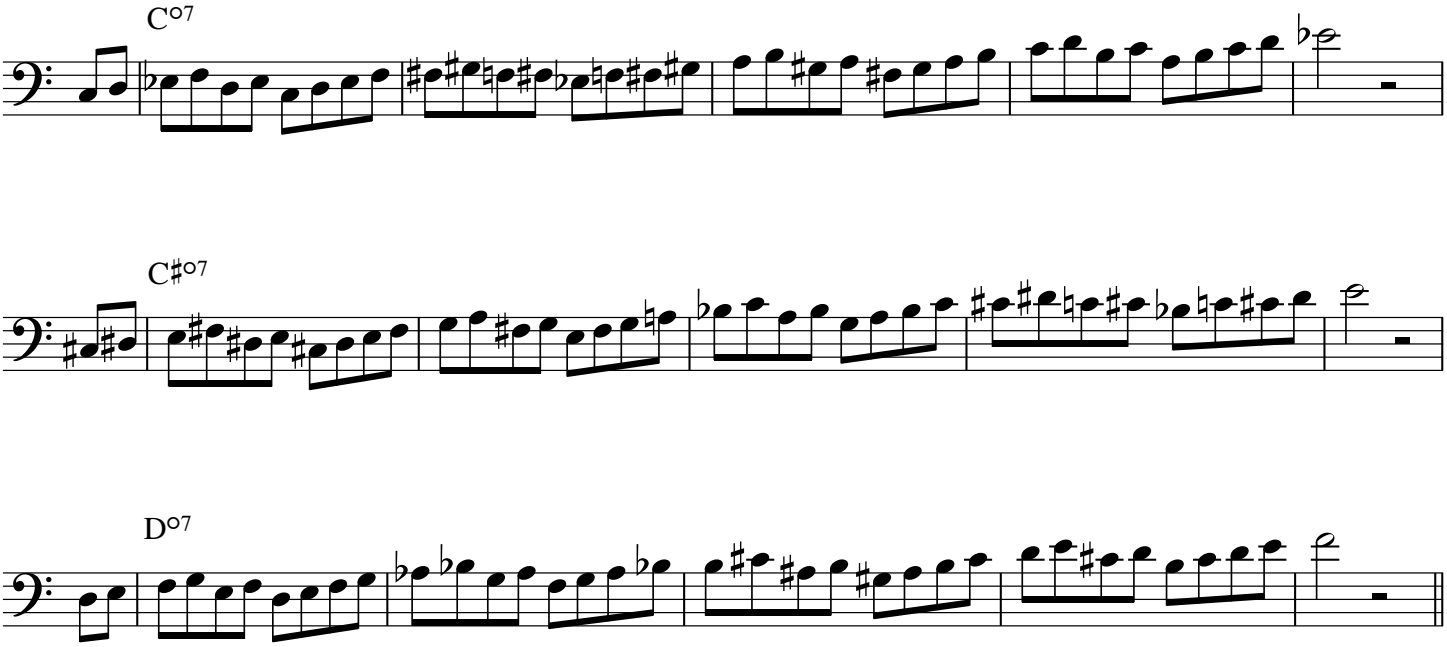


The DSS can continue on forever:



Here's a brilliant excerpt from Charlie Parker where he utulizes this in a really clever way:
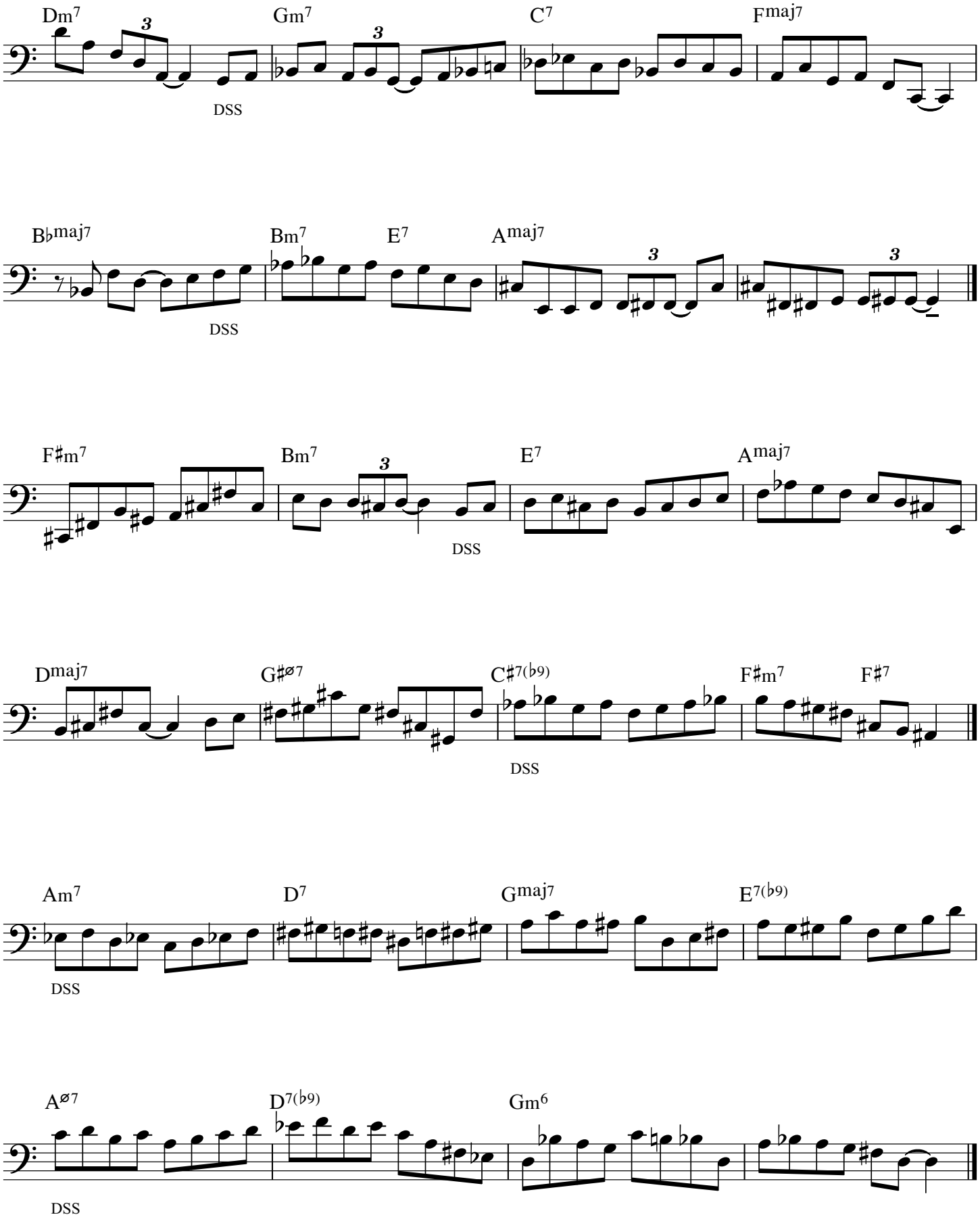


Since this is based in a symmetrical scale, there are only 3 real tranpositions before things start to repeat themselves!



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58 Here are several phrases of DSS being played within common jazz chord progressions:
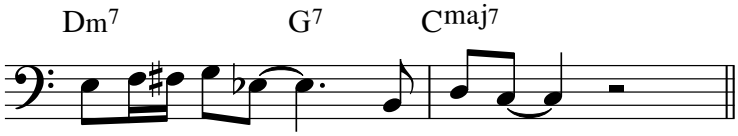


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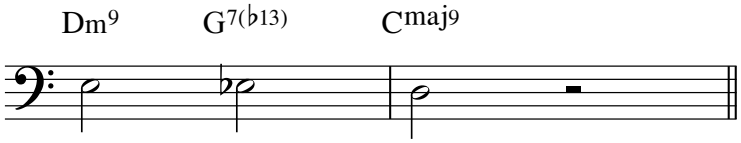
Lick 30

Nine to Nine Resolution (NNR)

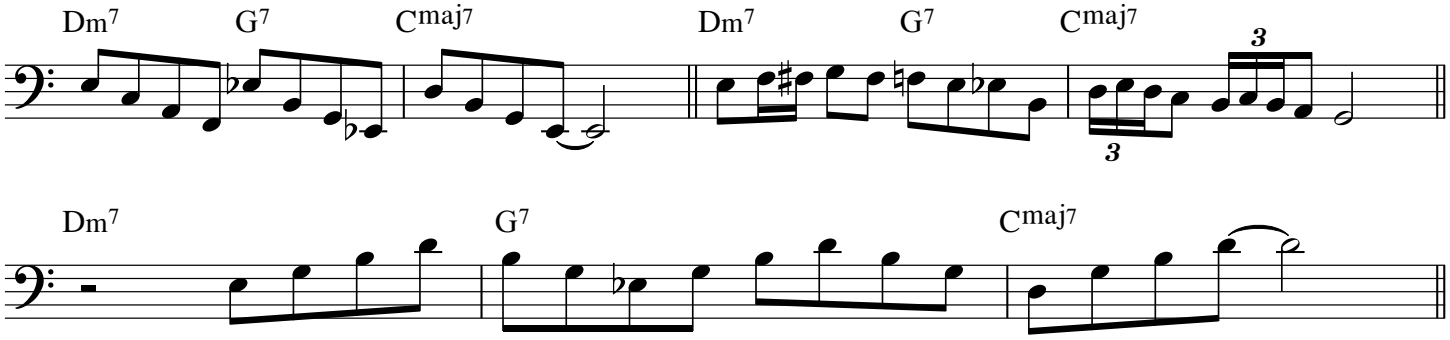
Thanks for making it to the end! Here is the final phrase (for now). It's a hip way to travel from the 9th of the ii chord to the 9th of the I chord, by voice leading with a powerful b13 in between on the V7. Let's call this the "Nine to Nine Resolution" (NNR):
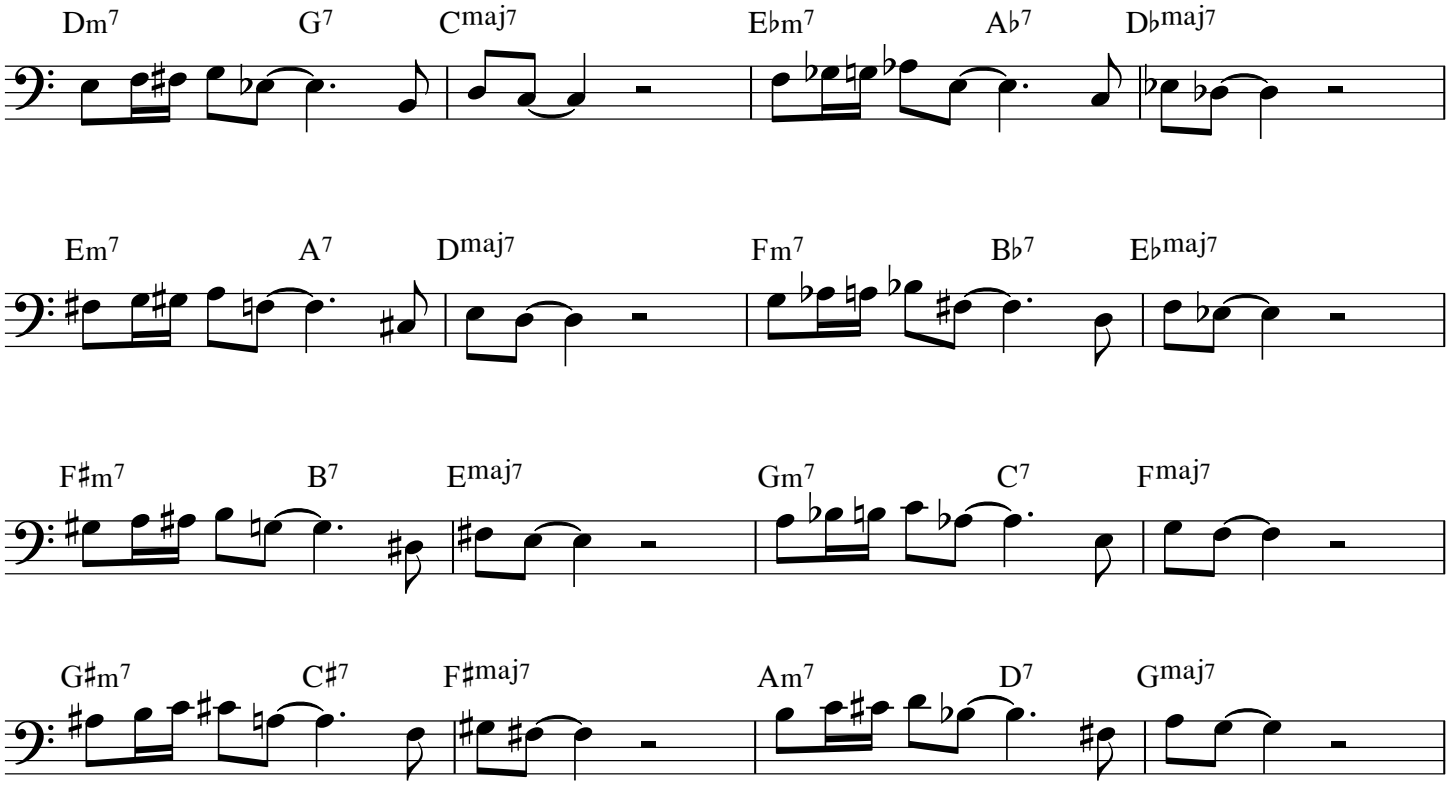


Here is the skeleton of this phrase:



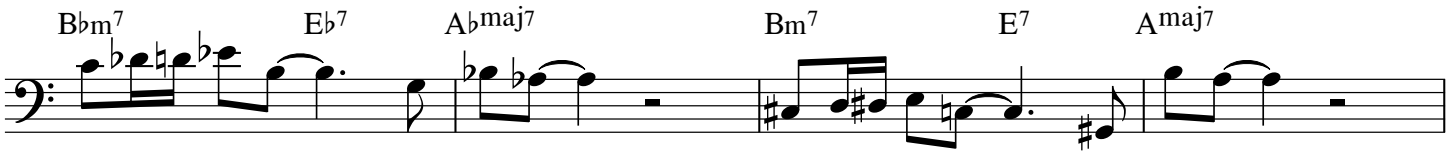
Any melody with this framework in mind is going to sound cool:

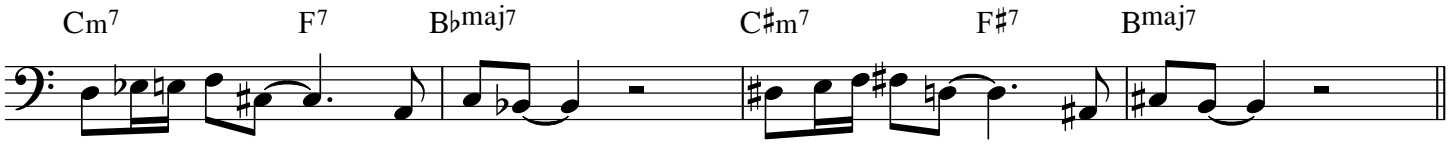


If you memorize the NNR phrase in 12 keys, it will be intuitive to channel within your live solos!

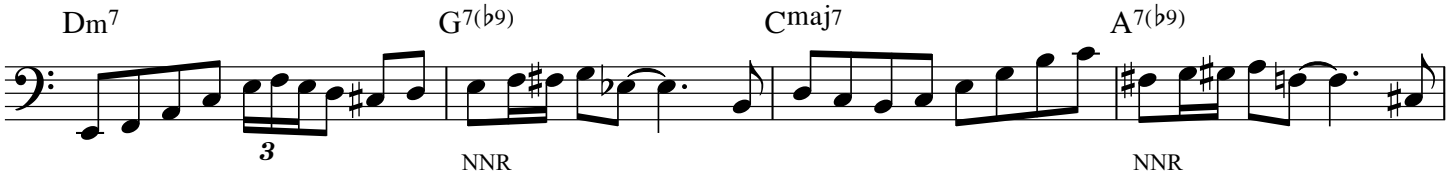


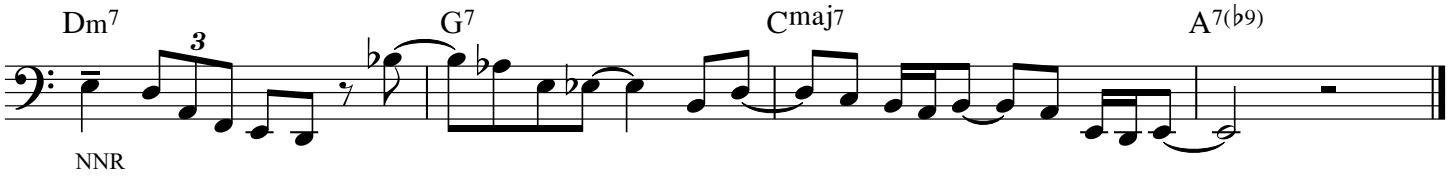
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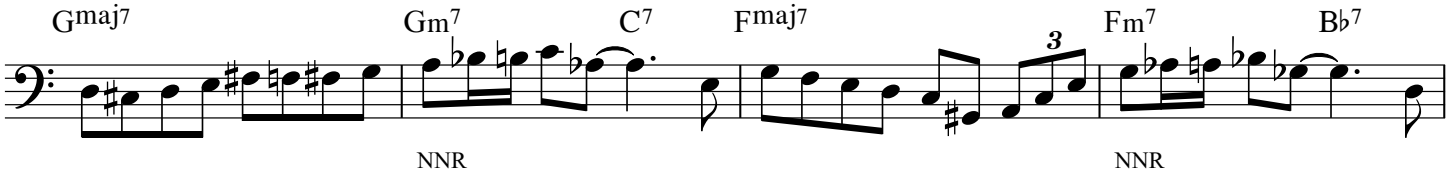


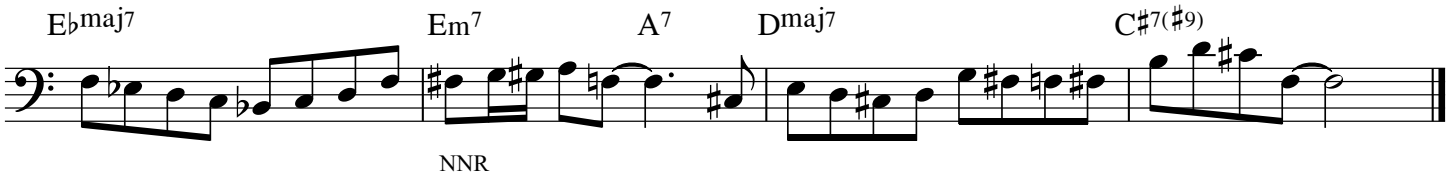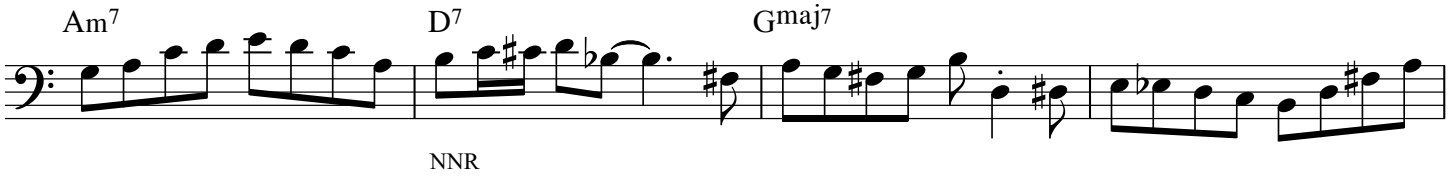


Here are several phrases of NNR being played within common jazz chord progressions:
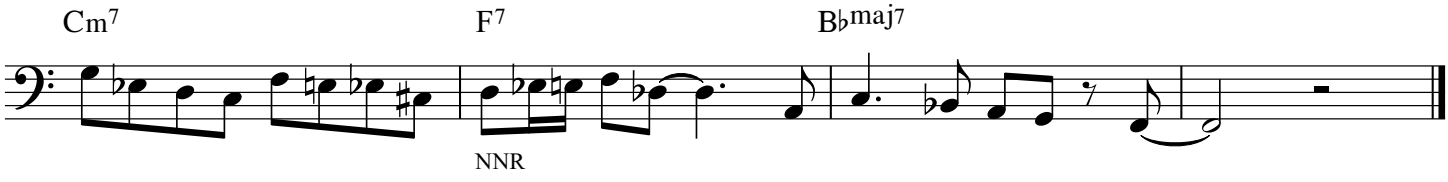












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